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SOCIAL ISSUES

Enduring Understanding(s):

What will students understand as a result of this unit?

1. What is defined as a social problem differs by context (e.g. time, place, political and legal systems).
2. Social problems are sociocultural, political and economic phenomena that prevent a significant number of societal participants from developing and using their full potential.
3. Social and political structures and arrangements determine the underlying features of the social world and play a role in perpetuating or mitigating social problems.
4. The politico-economic system of a society, from which social problems emanate, is a result of historical events and conscious choices by those with power and influence.
5. There may be a discrepancy between what a country is supposed to stand for and the actual conditions in which many of its people live.
6. Individuals are products of their social and political environment. Who they are, what they believe, what they strive for, and how they feel about themselves are all dependent on other people, the society in which they live, and the politics that govern their lives.

Essential Questions:

What are the essential questions of this unit?

1. What are the causes and consequences of social problems?
2. How significant is human agency in shaping, resisting, challenging and sometimes completely changing the social structures and institutions that affect their lives?
3. Why do governments prioritise some social problems to address over others?
4. Can social problems be effectively mitigated or eliminated?

Essay Questions on Social Issues (2010 – 2023)

FAMILY & MARRIAGE

<i>Cambridge 2019</i>	Should both parents take equal responsibility for raising their children?
<i>Cambridge 2015</i>	'Parents have no right to impose their own values and beliefs on their children.' Discuss.
<i>Cambridge 2014</i>	'Traditional marriage is an outdated concept.' To what extent is this true of your society?
<i>Y6 CT 2023</i>	'It is harder than ever to keep children safe in today's world.' Comment.
<i>Y5 CT 2023</i>	'The family no longer plays an influential role in raising teenagers.' How true is this of your society?
<i>Y6 Timed Practice 2023</i>	'Young people today have little interest in traditional marriage.' How true is this of your society?
<i>Y5 CT 2022</i>	'The traditional family has lost its importance today.' Discuss.
<i>Y6 Timed Practice 2021</i>	Is the traditional family still relevant in your society today?
<i>Y5 Promo 2021</i>	'Modern parenting does not prepare children for the future.' How far is this true?
<i>Y5 CT 2021</i>	Is marriage still an attractive option in today's world?
<i>Y5 Promo 2020</i>	'Parents have too much control over their children's lives.' How far is this true of your society today?
<i>Y5 CT 2018</i>	'The idea of marriage is outdated in modern society.' Discuss.
<i>Y5 Promo 2015</i>	In the family, should the most important role of a man be that of a breadwinner?
<i>Y6 CT2 2014</i>	'Good parenting has little to do with how children turn out.' Comment with reference to your society.
<i>Y6 CT2 2013</i>	Is marriage still relevant in modern society?
<i>Y6 CT1 2013</i>	'Modern life is not conducive to the survival of the family.' Comment.
<i>Y6 CT2 2012</i>	"The traditional institution of marriage is in decline." Is this a cause for concern?
<i>Y5 CT 2011</i>	'The family has suffered at the expense of economic growth in Singapore.' How far do you agree?
<i>Y6 Prelim 2011</i>	'An unhappy marriage is best resolved with a divorce.' Comment.
<i>Y5 CT 2010</i>	Is monogamy unrealistic in modern society?

GENDER

<i>Cambridge 2016</i>	Evaluate the claim that equality of opportunity for females is a desirable, but unrealistic, goal.
<i>Cambridge 2014</i>	Consider the view that some careers are more suited to one gender than the other.
<i>Cambridge 2011</i>	The world would be a better place if women had a greater say in politics. To what extent do you agree?
<i>Y6 TP 2024</i>	'Gender issues should be given greater attention by the state.' Consider this view in the context of your society.
<i>Y5 TP 2024</i>	'There is no point in fighting for gender equality today.' Do you agree?
<i>Y6 CT 2023</i>	To what extent is gender inequality a significant issue in the world of science?
<i>Y5 CT 2023</i>	To what extent are different genders valued equally in today's society?
<i>Y6 Timed Practice 2022</i>	Consider the view that we are moving further away from, rather than moving closer to, achieving gender equality.
<i>Y6 Timed Practice 2021</i>	How far would you agree that technological progress has done more harm than good for gender equality?
<i>Y5 CT 2021</i>	'It is a woman's world today.' How far do you agree?
<i>Y5 Common Essay Assignment 2021</i>	'We can never close the gender divide.' Do you agree?

<i>Y5 Timed Practice 2020</i>	Consider the view that gender equality is a desirable but unrealistic goal.
<i>Y6 CT1 2019</i>	'Success comes more easily to men than women.' To what extent is this true of your society?
<i>Y5 Promo 2018</i>	Can we ever achieve gender equality in sport?
<i>Y6 CT 2018</i>	Assess the view that women have been unfairly treated today.
<i>Y6 Prelim 2018</i>	"Women have never had it better." How true is this?
<i>Y5 Promo 2017</i>	"It is increasingly difficult to be a man today." Discuss.
<i>Y6 CT1 2014</i>	'No country can really develop unless its women are educated.' Do you agree?
<i>Y5 Promo 2013</i>	'Women are a decorative sex.' (Oscar Wilde) How far is this still an issue today?
<i>Y6 CT2 2012</i>	Does it matter that the leaders of most countries are men?
<i>Y6 Prelims 2012</i>	'Women are not suitable for politics.' To what extent is this true?
<i>Y5 CT1 2012</i>	'The pursuit of gender equality will do more harm than good.' Discuss.
<i>Promo 2011</i>	'It is increasingly challenging to be a man today.' Do you agree?
<i>Y6 CT1 2011</i>	'A nation cannot really progress until it empowers its women.' Do you agree?
<i>Y6 CT2 2011</i>	'Women in the developed world have never had it so good.' Do you agree?
<i>Y6 CT2 2010</i>	'Infidelity is a biological imperative.' Discuss.
<i>Y6 CT2 2010</i>	Do you think there is much ambiguity and confusion about what it means to be a man in today's world?

SOCIAL STRATIFICATION + DISCRIMINATION

<i>Cambridge 2019</i>	To what extent should income equality be a goal in your society?
<i>Cambridge 2013</i>	How far is increased prosperity for all a realistic goal in your society?
<i>Cambridge 2012</i>	In your society, how far is equality for all a reality?
<i>Cambridge 2011</i>	It is inevitable for technology to be more responsive to the problems of the rich than the poor. Discuss.
<i>Y6 Prelim 2024</i>	How far do you agree that efforts to promote inclusiveness do more harm than good?
<i>Y5 TP 2024</i>	To what extent are people in your society treated equally?
<i>Y5 EOY Holiday Assignment 2023</i>	To what extent is there true racial harmony in your society?
<i>Y6 Prelim 2023</i>	Winning at sport is due to wealth, rather than talent. Comment.
<i>Y5 CT 2023</i>	To what extent is meritocracy an effective way to enhance social mobility in your society?
<i>Y6 Prelim 2022</i>	'People with special needs are no longer invisible.' Is this true of the world today?
<i>Y6 CT 2022</i>	To what extent is meritocracy in your society still desirable?
<i>Y5 CT 2022</i>	'Equality for all is only an aspiration.' How far is this true of your society?
<i>Y5 CT 2022</i>	How far do you agree that celebrities have too much influence today?
<i>Y6 Prelim 2021</i>	Have our efforts to address discrimination made us overly sensitive? Discuss this in relation to your society.
<i>Y6 CT 2021</i>	'Criminals are victims too.' To what extent do you agree with this view?
<i>Y6 CT 2021</i>	Discuss the view that ending poverty is desirable but unachievable.
<i>Y6 CT 2021</i>	Is diversity of people and their viewpoints truly celebrated in your society?
<i>Y5 Promo 2021</i>	To what extent does your society truly care for its underprivileged people?
<i>Y5 CT 2021</i>	'The key to good health is wealth.' Comment.
<i>Y5 Timed Practice 2020</i>	To what extent should the rich be expected to help the poor?
<i>Y5 Timed Practice 2020</i>	'It is surprising that discrimination still exists in the world today.' How far do you agree?
<i>Y6 Prelim 2019</i>	Assess the view that your society is not doing enough to eradicate prejudice.
<i>Y6 Prelim 2019</i>	To what extent is poverty the fault of the individual?

Y6 CT2 2018	'Poverty is a result of personal failure.' To what extent is this true of your society?
Y6 CT1 2013	Is equality for all within your country a realistic and desirable aim?
Y6 CT 1 2012	Do you agree that we can now do little to help the poor in our world?
Y6 CT2 2012	Is it ever possible to eliminate stereotypes in society?
Y6 Prelim 2012	'Success is determined by one's intelligence.' Discuss.
Y5 CT1 2012	'People who are in poverty have only themselves to blame.' Comment.
Y5 Promo 2011	Is it always the responsibility of the state to help the poor?
Y6 CT2 2011	What can people in your society learn from its youth?
Y5 Promo 2010	Have we paid too high a price in our pursuit of economic growth in Singapore?
Y6 Prelim 2010	'Inequality is a fact of life.' To what extent should we accept this?

(Age) SOCIAL STRATIFICATION + DISCRIMINATION

Cambridge 2022	Assess the extent to which different age groups in your society are valued equally.
Cambridge 2017	To what extent are people judged more by their physical appearance than by their abilities?
Cambridge 2016	Longer life expectancy creates more problems than benefits. Discuss
Cambridge 2015	When a government's finances for social welfare are limited, should they be directed towards the young or the old?
Y6 CT 2022	'The elderly are vital to society.' Examine this view in a world increasingly reliant on technology.
Y5 CT 2022	Assess the view that skills training for older workers is futile in your society.
Y6 Timed Practice 2021	'There is little to look forward to in one's old age.' To what extent is this true of your society?
Y5 Promo 2021	'Technology is key to reducing inequality.' How far do you agree?
Y5 CT 2021	To what extent is ageism a problem in your society?
Y5 Common Essay Assignment 2021	Evaluate the claim that too much has been done for the elderly in your society.
Y5 Promo 2020	'When a government's finances for social welfare are limited, the poor should be given the highest priority.' What is your view?
Y6 CT1 2019	Should the responsibility of taking care of the elderly fall solely on the government?
Y5 CT1 2013	Is old age approached with horror in your society?
Y5 CT1 2012	How far do you agree that it is the responsibility of the young to take care of the elderly in your society?
Y5 CT1 2011	Is longer life expectancy a blessing or a curse?
Y6 CT2 2011	'Retirement is a redundant word today.' To what extent is this true?
Y5 Promo 2010	To what extent is raising the retirement age a necessary evil in today's society?
Y6 CT1 2010	'Growing old can be an empowering process.' Do you agree?

YOUTH

Cambridge 2023	Evaluate the claim that sports personalities make good role models for young people.
Cambridge 2023	'Young people want to change the world because they do not know it is impossible.' How far do you agree?
Cambridge 2019	'Religion is an important part of the lives of young people today.' Consider whether this is true in your society.
Y6 Timed Practice 2024	'Young people in your society should fear the future rather than embrace it.' To what extent is this an accurate view?
Y6 Timed Practice 2023	'Young people today have little interest in traditional marriage.' How true is this of your society?
Y5 CT 2023	'Young people today are only interested in themselves.' Is this a fair comment?
Y6 Prelim 2021	How far is an overseas education a necessity for young people in your society?

<i>Y6 Timed Practice 2020</i>	To what extent do young people have a significant voice in political affairs?
<i>Y5 Timed Practice 2020</i>	To what extent are young people in your country prepared for the future?
<i>Y6 Prelim 2019</i>	To what extent are young people in your society prepared for a world that is constantly changing?
<i>Y6 Prelim 2018</i>	'Young people celebrate the wrong heroes.' How far is this true in your society today?
<i>Y6 Prelim 2016</i>	In your society, how far are young people prepared for the challenges of tomorrow?
<i>Y6 Prelim 2014</i>	'Young people today think of nothing but themselves.' Is this a fair description?
<i>Y5 CT1 2014</i>	Do you agree that teenagers in your society have a bright future ahead of them?
<i>Y6 CT1 2013</i>	With reference to the developments in the world today, to what extent would you agree that the future holds much promise for young people?
<i>Y5 Promo 2013</i>	'Always follow your dreams.' Is this good advice for young people today?
<i>Y6 Prelim 2012</i>	Are the youth in Singapore prepared for future challenges?
<i>Y5 Promo 2011</i>	Is too much being expected of today's youth?
<i>Y5 Promo 2010</i>	'Today's youth have no regard for authority.' Discuss this with reference to the youth in your society.
<u>EDUCATION</u>	
<i>Cambridge 2024</i>	'Education today should involve more than the study of academic subjects.' How far do you agree?
<i>Cambridge 2020</i>	'An appreciation of music is vital for a fully rounded education.' How true is this of your society?
<i>Cambridge 2013</i>	'Education should only be concerned with what is useful in life.' Discuss.
<i>Cambridge 2011</i>	Does better education necessarily lead to a better standard of living?
<i>Y5 Timed Practice 2024</i>	'Schools fail to adequately prepare students for adult life.' How far is this true?
<i>Y5 EOY Holiday Assignment 2023</i>	Is there still a place for tests and examinations in schools today?
<i>Y6 Prelim 2023</i>	'Formal education is less valuable today than it was in the past.' Is this true?
<i>Y6 Timed Practice 2023</i>	Is teaching to the test a relevant approach to education today?
<i>Y5 CT 2023</i>	Do you agree that the use of technology for education is not always beneficial?
<i>Y6 CT 2022</i>	'Online learning can never replace the physical classroom.' Discuss.
<i>Y6 CT 2021</i>	'To be effective, schools must turn to technology.' How true is this of education today?
<i>Y5 Common Essay Assignment 2021</i>	To what extent is education an effective way to combat poverty?
<i>Y6 Timed Practice 2020</i>	Do you agree that a university education is becoming increasingly unnecessary today?
<i>Y5 Timed Practice 2020</i>	Do schools in your society still teach what is relevant?
<i>Y6 CT1 2019</i>	To what extent is education still the key to a nation's success?
<i>Y6 CT1 2014</i>	Consider the view that the study of history is essential for mankind.
<i>Y5 Promo 2014</i>	To what extent do you think that creativity can be cultivated?
<i>Y5 Promo 2014</i>	How relevant is the study of History in our world today?
<i>Y5 CT1 2014</i>	'Only grades matter in education.' Discuss.
<i>Y6 Prelim 2013</i>	'Qualified but not enlightened.' Is this a fair description of educated people today?
<i>Y6 CT1 2013</i>	'The teaching of literary classics should be made compulsory in schools.' Discuss.
<i>Y5 CT1 2013</i>	'Singapore can do without the study of the humanities.' Discuss.
<i>Y6 CT2 2012</i>	To what extent should schools use examinations to evaluate students?
<i>Y6 Prelim 2012</i>	'An educated people can be easily governed.' Is this a valid statement?

Y5 CT1 2011	'Education has resulted in only more inequality.' Do you agree?
Y5 CT1 2010	'Education is the great leveller.' How far is this true?
Y6 Prelim 2010	To what extent should government influence education? Discuss with reference to your country.

CRIME, PUNISHMENT & JUSTICE

Cambridge 2024	Evaluate the measures taken in your society to deter crime and punish criminals.
Cambridge 2024	Assess the view that it is always right to challenge injustice.
Cambridge 2017	'Rehabilitation, not punishment, should be the purpose of the justice system.' Discuss.
Y5 Promo 2021	'The purpose of the justice system should be rehabilitation, not punishment.' Discuss.
Y6 Timed Practice 2020	Should capital punishment still have a place in your society today?
Y6 CT 2019	How far is punishment an effective solution to crime?
Y6 CT 2012	Consider the view that capital punishment has no place in civilised society.

WORK & EMPLOYMENT

Cambridge 2023	How realistic is it for countries to implement a national minimum wage for all their workers?
Cambridge 2023	'People who undertake voluntary work do so more for their own benefit than for the benefit of others.' Discuss.
Cambridge 2018	'People today do not work as hard as they did in the past.' How true is this of your society?
Cambridge 2016	'People who do the most worthwhile jobs rarely receive the best financial rewards.' To what extent is this true of your society?
Y6 Prelim 2022	'Workers today have never had it better.' Is this an accurate view?
Y5 CT 2022	Assess the view that skills training for older workers is futile in your society.
Y5 CT 2021	Should working from home become the norm in your society?
Y5 Promo 2020	'Work-life harmony is a myth.' How far is this true of your society today?
Y6 Prelim 2013	Is work-life balance ever achievable in your society?

SOCIAL ISOLATION

Cambridge 2011	Examine the view that loneliness has become the new curse of modern society.
Y6 CT2 2012	"Not in my backyard." To what extent is this a growing problem in your society?

OTHER SOCIAL ISSUES

Cambridge 2024	How desirable is it for a country to provide free healthcare for all its citizens?
Cambridge 2023	Assess the extent to which all people in your society have the opportunity to achieve their full potential.
Cambridge 2023	To what extent are festivals and national holidays effective in promoting unity in your society?
Cambridge 2022	To what extent can individuals shape their own lives when the world is so unpredictable?
Cambridge 2022	'Consumerism is more of a curse than a blessing.' How true is this of your society?
Cambridge 2022	'It is not winning, but taking part, which matters.' How acceptable is this as an approach to life?
Cambridge 2021	How far is the pursuit of happiness the most important human goal?
Cambridge 2021	To what extent is charitable giving desirable?
Cambridge 2020	To what extent is human life in general about the survival of the fittest?
Cambridge 2020	'We shape our buildings, but then our buildings shape us.' To what extent is this true of your society?
Cambridge 2020	To what extent can any society claim to be great?
Cambridge 2020	How far can prosperity and uncontrolled population growth go hand in hand?

Cambridge 2018	Is pressure a motivating force or a cause for unhappiness?
Cambridge 2018	Consider the view that we do not take enough responsibility for our own well-being.
Y6 Prelim 2023	How successfully has your society balanced the needs of the state against those of the individual?
Y6 CT 2023	How far do you agree that healthcare in your society leaves much to be desired?
Y6 CT 2023	Should there be limits to freedom of speech in your society?
Y6 Timed Practice 2023	Examine the view that competition is necessary in today's world.
Y6 Prelim 2022	'Obedience is a virtue.' Is this an accurate reflection of your society?
Y6 CT 2022	'Given the state of the world today, it is irresponsible to have children.' What is your view?
Y6 Timed Practice 2022	'The end justifies the means.' How far would you agree with this view?
Y5 CT 2022	Is following the rules always desirable?
Y6 Timed Practice 2021	'All talk, no action.' How far does this describe activism today?
Y6 Timed Practice 2021	'Handicrafts no longer have any practical benefits in modern society.' Comment.
Y6 Timed Practice 2021	Is patriotism always desirable?
Y5 Promo 2021	'In the age of modern celebrity, there are no real heroes.' Do you agree?
Y5 Promo 2021	'City living is no longer attractive.' How true is this?
Y5 CT 2021	Does a crisis always unite a nation?
Y5 Common Essay Assignment 2021	How important is discipline in your society?
Y5 Common Essay Assignment 2021	Do you agree that public libraries serve little purpose today?
Y5 Common Essay Assignment 2021	'Co-operation, not competition, is the key to success today.' Comment.
Y5 Common Essay Assignment 2021	'If you have not left your borders, you have not learnt much.' How true is this?
Y5 Common Essay Assignment	'A nation that simply complains.' Is this a fair comment about your society?
Y6 Timed Practice 2020	To what extent should sport in your society focus on local rather than foreign talent?
Y6 Timed Practice 2020	Consider the value of having routines in today's world.
Y5 Promo 2020	Is cooperation always desirable?
Y5 Promo 2020	Discuss the value of humility in today's world.
Y5 Timed Practice 2020	Consider the value of creativity in society.
Y5 Timed Practice 2020	Should tradition be regarded with greater importance in the world today?
Y5 Promo 2019	Consider the value of empathy in our world today.
Y6 CT2 2019	Is it fair to expect businesses to give back to society?
Y6 CT1 2019	'Talent matters most.' How far is this true of your society?

Y6 CT2 2018	Is it ever justifiable for people in society to make decisions for those who are unable to do so?
Y6 CT2 2014	Do you agree with the view that consumerism is harmful to society?
Y5 Promo 2014	In modern life, are we trying to do too much?
Y5 CT1 2014	'Change should always be embraced.' Comment.
Y5 CT1 2014	'Stress is healthy.' Discuss.
Y6 CT2 2013	'People today lack the capacity to imagine and feel.' Is this a fair characterisation of individuals in your society?
Y6 Prelim 2013	How important are memories?
Y6 CT1 2013	Do we expect too much from public figures?
Y5 Promo 2013	How important is it for us to recognise and celebrate our heroes?
Y5 Promo 2013	To what extent is Singapore a liveable city?
Y5 CT1 2013	Consider the importance of conversation.

SECTION A: GENDER ISSUES

Reading 1: Why do we still distrust women leaders?

EU 2-6

Christine Ro | BBC | 19 January 2021 [adapted]

This reading will help you understand:

- The progress that has been made in gender equality for women
- Underlying biases that hamper women in leadership
- The benefits of promoting greater inclusion of women in leadership

Despite strides in women's representation in powerful roles, a surprising number of people across the world still don't trust women to lead effectively. These biases are deep-seated – and may be difficult to change.

In November 2020, Maia Sandu reached a milestone by becoming Moldova's first woman president. Following years of sexist attacks from men and women alike, it was a major victory for Sandu – and women around the world – who are increasingly reaching positions of power. The same month, the American people elected Kamala Harris vice-president; on 20 January, she'll become the highest-ranking woman in US history.

Yet **even though women are vaulting to power, a pernicious culture of distrust in women leaders endures**. Recent research suggests this is even true in countries with long experiences of women's leadership, from Germany to India; in these places, much of the public remains stubbornly resistant to the idea of women in charge. Leaders have had to battle sexist comments, even as they climb ranks or succeed on a global stage – such as New Zealand's Jacinda Ardern, who was globally lauded for her leadership during the Covid-19 pandemic.

So, while women are receiving votes from the electorate, why are they not also receiving votes of confidence? There's not one concrete answer – but there are clues in society that can help us piece together the reason.

'It's just a myth that one female leader changes society'

The Reykjavík Index assesses attitudes toward female leadership in the G7 countries – Canada, France, Germany, Italy, Japan, the UK and the US – as well as India, Kenya and Nigeria. Its most recent survey of more than 20,000 adults led to some surprising and disheartening results.

Only 38% of people in Japan were comfortable with the idea of a female head of government or a female CEO of a major company. In both Nigeria and Kenya, the scores (out of 100) were 62 for government and 56 for politics. The average G7 score for government and politics was higher, holding fairly steady over the last three years at 78. But this is still far from a score of 100 – which would indicate that women and men are seen as equally suitable for leadership positions.

Additionally, only 41% of people in Germany said they felt very comfortable with a woman being the head of government, in spite of Angela Merkel's long-time chancellorship. "It's just a myth that one female leader changes society," says Michelle Harrison, who leads the public division of Kantar, the market research company that runs the Reykjavík Index surveys. And it's **unrealistic to expect a single leader (woman or otherwise) to create sweeping change around gender roles**.

Another striking finding was that around the world, young men were especially unlikely to endorse women leaders. This is surprising given that younger generations are often considered more progressive than older ones.

But in general, it's **common for beliefs about leadership to default to stereotypes about masculine behaviour, leading to unconscious gender bias**. This can be present even in people who consider themselves progressive, including younger people.

The work of Yoshikuni Ono, a political scientist at Waseda University in Tokyo, offers another clue to this generational puzzle. In the US, Americans tend to overestimate women's representation in Congress – in one study, by 14% on average. But younger people are especially inaccurate, and the gap in correct knowledge is increasing between older and younger people.

It may be, Ono explains, that “especially young, male voters think that women are already represented in politics because at schools, at universities, they see more women. These days, there are many more female students in college than men.” Generally, if you think that gender balance already exists, you're less likely to think it's important to elect women leaders. So, erroneous beliefs may lead to bias against women's leadership.

Overall, the situation may be even more stark than these findings suggest. The Reykjavik Index researchers asked respondents, “For each of the following sectors or industries, do you think men or women are better suited to leadership positions?” But political scientists have found that when asked direct, explicit questions about prejudice against women leaders, many survey respondents deny their prejudice. This is largely due to social-desirability bias; essentially, it's hard to admit to a belief that's seen as socially unacceptable. **Social-desirability bias** bedevils survey researchers and pollsters in a number of fields where people feel uncomfortable being completely honest, leading to potentially inaccurate results.

Some people who don't consider themselves sexist believe that because the world is sexist, women leaders are likely to be weaker. Sean Nguyen, a 33-year-old living in Los Angeles who runs a website that compares internet service providers, believes that “male leaders tend to have more authority. It's wrong and I'd like to see that change, but ... we have to work within the system we exist in.” Nguyen also admits that this preference extends to politics and business. “If I were completely honest, I would prefer a man to lead my company over a woman.”

These kinds of beliefs aren't surprising, according to Alice Eagly, a psychologist at Northwestern University in Evanston, Illinois. “The stereotype is that women aren't agentic” – or decisive and authoritative – “and their voices aren't as loud and they're kind of small.” Because those are the types of traits traditionally associated with men and with leaders, **notions of leadership have become bound up with perceptions of masculinity.**

In working within and against these gender norms, women leaders may find themselves in a double bind. Political scientist Ono explains, “Female candidates face a more difficult time figuring out what would be the good strategy to win the election or get more support from people, because deviating from gender stereotypes might be bad for women. At the same time, conforming to gender stereotypes punishes them as well. So, it seems very difficult for female politicians to find the sweet spot when they plan their strategy.”

This double bind also applies to other groups that may be criticised whether they adhere to or push against biases. In multiracial societies, women of colour are often particularly penalised. For example, black women are stereotyped as too abrasive and Asian women are stereotyped as too docile to lead. Among women and minorities, **“tokens” are highly visible within organisations and especially within positions of power, which creates an additional dilemma:** excel, and become even more conspicuous and scrutinised; or moderate their achievements, to fit into dominant groups' expectations.

The Covid-19 effect

Unfortunately, the pandemic has not been a turning point for bias against women in power. In the pandemic-linked recession, women are being disproportionately affected by job cuts and reduced working hours. Women are also under-represented in scientific and policy committees related to Covid-19 response.

Women heads of government have won plaudits for decisive leadership during the pandemic, including New Zealand's Ardern and Taiwan's Tsai Ing-wen. And in the US, states with women governors initially had fewer deaths from Covid-19 than states with male governors.

But it's hard to judge patterns when these women leaders are still such a small sample (currently only 9 out of 50 US governors are women). More generally, the **strong performance of women leaders doesn't appear to have improved public beliefs about women's leadership**. This pattern already exists in other domains. While women's leadership in the banking and finance sector is associated with more stability and higher financial returns, this sector remains imbalanced in terms of gender.

Referring to the three years of Kantar's survey research on attitudes toward women's leadership, Harrison comments, "The consistency of the data is a standout feature, that you can have Covid and that you can have Me Too, and you don't see big shifts at all."

Over time, some beliefs have shifted – up to a point. According to Eagly's and colleagues' analysis of seven decades of opinion polls on gender stereotypes, from 1946 to 2018, the **US public considers women more competent than it did before. But beliefs about women's agency (the ability to achieve goals and reach mastery) haven't budged**. As more women have entered the workforce, "female ghettos" have emerged within traditionally male fields, such as education ministries within government or human relations within management. To reach the top of the top, more cultural change is needed.

For discussion/reflection:

1. Ro describes women in today's world as "vaulting to power" (line 9). With reference to recent developments, how far would you agree this is the case? Highlight specific examples to support your case.
2. Why might it be "unrealistic to expect a single leader...to create sweeping change around gender roles"? (lines 30-31)
3. Explain what the author means when she speaks of "female ghettos" (lines 97-98) emerging within traditionally male fields, and what might be the implications of such a development.
4. Apart from the distrust of female leaders highlighted by the article, what do you think are other significant obstacles or roadblocks to gender equality?
5. Based on the reading and your responses to the above questions, do you think there is more room to hope or for doubt with respect to the progress of gender equality for women today?

Related Cambridge/RI essay questions:

1. Evaluate the claim that equality of opportunity for females is a desirable, but unrealistic, goal. (Cambridge 2016)
2. To what extent are different genders valued equally in today's society? (Y5 CT 2023)
3. 'It is a woman's world today.' How far do you agree? (Y5 CT 2021)

Supplementary readings:

- a. "How big is the global gender gap? Depends on which number you look at – by Andre Tartar and Cedric Sam, 27 March 2019" (<https://www.bloomberg.com/graphics/2019-bloomberg-new-economy/progress-women-made-worldwide-gender-gap/>)
- b. "Summary of progress of the world's women, 2019-2020; Families in a changing world" – by UN Women (https://www.aidsdatahub.org/sites/default/files/publication/UNWOMEN_Progress-of-the-worlds-women-2019-20-Executive-summary-2019.pdf)
- c. Global cost of failing to invest in women and gender equality is \$10tn a year – UN (<https://www.theguardian.com/global-development/2024/sep/16/un-women-gender-snapshot-2024-equality>)

SECTION A: GENDER ISSUES

Reading 2: How the fight for gender equality is changing

EU 1-4 & 6

Ai-jen Poo | TIME | 8 March 2018

In this article you will learn about:

- How women across the societal spectrum are actively advocating for gender equality
- The power of alliances to shift the struggle of marginalised groups into the public eye

In 2006, TIME magazine named “You” as the Person of the Year, recognizing the shift that had taken place on the internet. Users had become the drivers of the World Wide Web. YouTube made users producers, Wikipedia made users experts and MySpace made people stars. Users were tired of being passive so they stopped being the audience, and TIME’s cover headline read, “You control the Information Age. Welcome to your world.” Nothing has been more true.

The same shift is happening now in the women’s movement.

Women have been fighting for equal rights for generations, for the right to vote, the right to control our bodies and the right to equality in the workplace. And these battles have been hard fought, but we still have a long way to go, and our victories are under threat. Equality in the workplace — women in a range of fields from domestic work to the entertainment industry can tell you — it’s still just a dream.

January 2017 marked a new moment for women as millions gathered around the country and the world, and launched our Web 2.0 of the women’s movement. We knew President Trump’s administration wasn’t going to listen to us. But we marched to be heard not by the president or a political party, but by one another.

While previous marches focused on specific issues, this time we wanted to raise them all. Years of activism by women organizers leading the Black Lives Matter movement, the Dreamer immigrant youth movement and leaders like Tarana Burke, founder of “Me Too,” created a new foundation for how we understood and made connections between our different experiences with violence and inequality.

And we began to listen to our own stories, and respond, at scale. We heard women with disabilities share their health care stories at Town Hall meetings and we called Congress in unprecedented numbers to protect our care. We heard Susan Fowler’s year at Uber, and we called for accountability in Silicon Valley. We heard our sisters speak about harassment in the workplace and we named names and even got some out. We heard actresses tell of their casting couch experiences and we made The Weinstein Company toxic. Farmworker women listened to women in Hollywood, and recognized their own stories in the courageous truth-telling they heard. Our capacity to listen exploded with the number of voices speaking until the cultural momentum of #MeToo became unstoppable.

And that’s when it happened. We stopped looking up, to those in power, and started looking around at the women standing beside us — from different backgrounds, working in different sectors, of different ethnicities, with different stories — and realized our strength is in our diversity not our singularity, and the power that we need to claim is our own.

We shifted from focusing on protesting laws to lifting each other up to become the lawmakers. Danica Roem is now the first transgender person to serve as a state legislator in the country. In fact, more

40 women than ever have decided to throw their hats in the ring and run for public office. We grew tired of reporting sexual predators, so we, following the leadership of black women, went to the polls and voted for Roy Moore's opponent.

We're writing a new playbook for power. We are growing our organizations, taking over others and forming new ones. We're working together, refusing to be isolated and doing what it takes to get the job done. Because that's what women have always done.

45 We have seen the effects of this shift already in 2018. When yet another mass school shooting took place in Parkland, Florida we saw the rise of Emma Gonzalez, an 18 year-old student tired of the lack of action on gun control by the powers that be. At the Oscars last weekend, Frances McDormand invited producers to meet with all of the other female nominees because "we all have stories to tell and projects we need to be financed," and called for "inclusion riders" to make sure storytelling is inclusive both in front of and behind the camera. Farmworkers and domestic workers, 50 the two groups of women workers who have been the most systematically excluded from protections at work, are mobilizing to Washington, D.C. to demand new protections from sexual harassment for all women.

The message is loud and clear: We'll take over from here, thanks. The rate things have been going, we're certain we'll do a better job. When Lev Grossman wrote the feature for TIME's Person of the 55 Year in 2006, he said, "It's about the many wresting power from the few and helping one another for nothing and how that will not only change the world, but also change the way the world changes." The same is true of the power shift we are witnessing with women.

We are watching women create the world we want to live in — not only changing the world, but also changing the way the world works. This year Golden Globe attendees who are part 60 of #TIMESUP invited activists, myself included, as their "plus ones" because they know this movement will only be successful when all women are successful.

This International Women's Day is about every single woman. It's about every LGBTQ woman and every woman of colour, every Hollywood actress and every domestic worker, every woman who loses a job to an under-qualified man, every woman who has been assaulted because of her gender whether 65 she works in the spotlight or in the shadows. Every last one of us.

We're done with asking for things to change; we're making change ourselves. And so far it looks pretty good. It's only March, but every single woman is the Person of the Year. Welcome to our world.

[See end of Reading 3 for discussion/reflection questions.]

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Reading 3: Bridging the gender health gap in Singapore

EU 1- 4 & 6

Adapted from 'Don't suffer in silence': These women leaders work to bridge the health gender gap in Singapore

Stephanie Yeo | The Straits Times | 9 March 2025

This article will help you consider:

- Social norms and structural barriers that women in Singapore face contributing to inequality
- Several ways individuals and institutions in Singapore are closing the gender health gap

By many measures of health, women in Singapore have it good. Thanks to a world-class healthcare system, they can expect to live to 85.2 years old at birth, one of the highest life expectancies in the world.

5 The Republic has one of the lowest maternal mortality rates, which is the ratio of women who die from pregnancy-related causes for every 100,000 live births. Women here also outlive men by almost five years.

10 However, disparities exist, especially in conditions that affect mainly or only women. Women in Singapore spend 12 per cent more time in poor health across their lives than men, according to a report by the McKinsey Health Institute in collaboration with the World Economic Forum in 2024. The report looked at the health gender gap globally. This is half the global average of 25 per cent, but the costs to individuals and society cannot be underestimated.

15 More than two-thirds of the health gap here afflict women in their working years, from ages 20 to 50, rather than later in life, the report revealed. This includes conditions ranging from period-related issues like premenstrual syndrome, commonly known as PMS, and endometriosis, to gaps in care and treatment for maternal health, menopause management and mental health issues, which impact women's healthcare costs and productivity.

20 Similar to other developed Asian economies such as South Korea and Japan, gaps in treatment and care are the result of insufficient research into women's health conditions, a lack of gender-specific healthcare services and societal norms, such as women tending to put the family or community before themselves, Ms Petersen says. If such conditions were better managed, society could reap economic benefits such as lower rates of absenteeism in schools and workplaces and higher productivity overall.

Insufficient research on women

25 Women make up half the world's population, but the reality is that science still does not know enough about how their bodies work, say women healthcare leaders. Female participation in medical research globally has traditionally been poor, as males have always been the default specimens.

However, women are not smaller-sized men. They are more likely than men to suffer adverse side effects when they take medications, according to a 2020 study of several thousand medical journal articles. It was conducted by researchers at the University of California – Berkeley and the University of Chicago and looked at 86 medications approved by the US Food and Drug Administration.

30 "Women have been neglected," says Professor Andrea Maier, a German longevity research expert, citing as an example the different ways men and women present the classic symptoms of a heart attack. Chest pain is the most obvious sign, but women may feel extreme fatigue and shortness of breath instead. Cardiovascular disease is the top cause of death among women here.

35 "It's the same cardiac issue, but the symptomology is different, and that's the reason, very often, it's under-diagnosed and later-diagnosed. We have to change that," says Prof Maier, co-founder of

longevity clinic Chi Longevity. That means not only educating women that they should seek help early, but also educating family doctors so they can pick up the differences in symptoms between the sexes, she adds.

40 Conforming to damaging societal expectations also shapes women's priorities, often to their detriment.

In their 20s, women should be eating healthily and exercising to bank their health reserves for their later years since they outlive men, says Dr Low Yen Ling, senior director of international nutrition science, global research and innovation for Abbott, a US-headquartered healthcare multinational company.

45 "The secret to healthy ageing is not what you do when you're old, it's what you do when you're young," she says. "Unfortunately, the period when they should be building their health reserves is the time when women face the highest social pressure to be trim and pretty. Many go on restrictive diets."

50 Skipping a meal like breakfast and eating two meals a day instead of three naturally makes it harder to get enough protein and essential vitamins and minerals such as vitamin C, calcium and iron. "Poor nutrition through the years will lead to low bone and muscle banks, causing health problems to emerge much faster than they might otherwise," Dr Low says.

Women's traditional role as caregivers to the young and elderly also means they often place their own needs last, Dr Low adds. "Self-care for women is not a big thing. You almost feel like you are a bad mum, wife or daughter if you take care of yourself."

55 Professor Lee Soo Chin, a senior consultant from the Department of Haematology-Oncology at the National University Cancer Institute, Singapore (NCIS) and a former head of the department, says: "The fact that women in Singapore outlive men yet spend a decade in poor health is a stark reminder that longevity alone is not enough. We need to focus on improving healthspan, not just lifespan." Healthspan refers to the years of good health in one's life.

60 "The societal expectation for women to prioritise caregiving over self-care, combined with cultural pressures around appearance, often means that women delay seeking medical attention until their conditions have progressed," she says.

65 For instance, an American study on acute myocardial infarction or heart attacks in 2018 found that a third of the women delayed seeking treatment. "This is particularly concerning in diseases like cancer, where early detection and timely intervention significantly impact outcomes."

Taking charge of one's health

70 The good news is that there is a growing emphasis on women's health issues. Instead of treating women only when they are ill, the strategy at KK Women's and Children's Hospital (KKH) now is to take a "life course approach" at all stages, says Associate Professor Chan Yoke Hwee, chairman of KKH's medical board and a workgroup member of the Ministry of Health's Taskforce on Child and Maternal Health and Well-being.

This line of action puts in interventions at critical periods and works with the community, including schools, to see how to improve health literacy and empower females of all stages to look after their own health, she says.

75 For instance, KKH launched the Maternal and Child Health Research Institute in 2021 to translate findings from research studies into real-life strategies. The institute's Healthy Early Life Moments In Singapore programme, for instance, uses the latest research updates to improve women's metabolic

and mental health through lifestyle modifications and interventions before they conceive. In this way, it breaks the vicious circle of disease and chronic conditions for their children and grandchildren.

80 In addition to regular public outreach activities, the hospital has since 2018 rolled out guidelines on women's health topics, including gestational diabetes, nutrition, mental health and exercise in pregnancy. These guidelines are disseminated to all doctors through the various medical societies to better equip them to manage their female patients.

85 At the primary care level, there is now more focus not just on the health of newborns, but also that of their mothers. One example of this is the Integrated Maternal and Child Wellness Hub at Punggol Polyclinic – a collaboration between KKH, SingHealth Polyclinics and Temasek Foundation – which launched in 2019.

90 Beyond screening babies for developmental milestones and vaccinating them, the hub also offers breastfeeding advice to mothers, screens them for postnatal depression and coaches them on what to expect as their child grows. The idea was so successful that this mother-child model of care has been adopted by more polyclinics.

KKH also set up a dedicated Menopause Centre in October 2023, as the menopause transition is set to be a big problem in a fast-ageing population, says Prof Chan.

Nurturing women in healthcare

95 With more women in leadership positions in healthcare today, it is easy to forget that female representation has been a hard-won battle.

100 For instance, it was only in 2003 that the National University of Singapore (NUS) lifted a 24-year quota limiting the number of women entering its undergraduate medical programme to one-third of its annual cohort. NUS was the only medical school here at that time. The reason behind the quota was that women would marry, have babies and leave the profession, so it was a waste to train them.

Fast forward two decades, and the situation is looking up. Women comprised 60 per cent of the 286 students in the 2024 intake at the National University of Singapore Yong Loo Lin School of Medicine (NUS Medicine), says its spokesperson.

105 Seeing a female doctor or healthcare expert can help women deal with the distress arising from their medical conditions, says Associate Professor Shefaly Shorey, president of the National University Health System's (NUHS) Women in Science and Healthcare (Wish) initiative.

110 Launched in 2017, Wish aims to promote gender equity and empower women in healthcare leadership and research. One woman that Prof Shorey interviewed in her research felt stressed about menopause, as her mother had developed cancer and died during that period of her life. She was afraid she would go through the same thing as her mother, but felt reassured when her female gynaecologist shared her own menopause experience and reassured her she would be fine.

115 "When they see another female researcher or a clinician telling them, 'We have gone through this and there are ways to manage it so you don't have to suffer in silence', it becomes very relatable," says Prof Shorey, who is also the vice-dean of administration at NUS Medicine and undergraduate programmes director for year four at the NUS Alice Lee Centre for Nursing Studies.

Role models show the way

At an institutional level, NUHS' Wish has launched initiatives to boost opportunities for female doctors and scientists. These include the Lunch & Learn series, which are informal regular knowledge sessions,

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Supplementary readings on gender equality globally:

1. [The Drugs Don't Work](#) (Invisible Women – Chapter 10)
2. “Over the Glass Cliff: Over the glass cliff: female chief executives have shorter tenure than men due to crisis management roles” – James Tapper, The Guardian, 5 Nov 2023 (<https://www.theguardian.com/business/2023/nov/05/over-the-glass-cliff-female-chief-executives-have-shorter-tenure-than-men-due-to-crisis-management-roles>)
3. “Across the Globe, a ‘Serious Backlash Against Women’s Rights’” – Alisha Gupta, The New York Times, 4 December 2019 (<https://www.nytimes.com/2019/12/04/us/domestic-violence-international.html>)
4. “Women’s 2024 In Politics, Business And Sports: Progress And Setbacks” – Kim Elsesser, Forbes, 20 December 2024 (<https://www.forbes.com/sites/kimelsesser/2024/12/20/womens-2024-in-politics-business-and-sports-progress-and-setbacks/>)

Supplementary readings on gender equality in Singapore:

5. “Paternity leave helps but for men to take on fair share of parenting, a rethink of gender roles is needed” – Channel News Asia, 2 October 2023 (<https://www.channelnewsasia.com/today/big-read/big-read-paternity-leave-men-parenting-fatherhood-family-gender-roles-3810696>)
6. “Invisible barriers prevent Singapore women from joining AI boom” – Ng Wei Kai, The Straits Times, 7 Feb 2025 (<https://www.straitstimes.com/singapore/invisible-barriers-prevent-spore-women-from-joining-ai-boom>)

SECTION A: GENDER ISSUES

Reading 4: Do transgender athletes have an unfair advantage?

EU 1- 4

Tiffany Abreu | DW News | 24 July 2021

This reading helps you understand:

- The different measures implemented by various parties to make competitive sports more inclusive
- Why in areas like sporting ability, gender and equality, much remains to be done to put transgender athletes on a more equal footing

Several trans women competed in the Tokyo Games, marking the first time openly trans athletes participated in the Olympics. New Zealand's Laurel Hubbard first attempt in the weightlifting competition marked her Olympic debut. Hubbard's participation as a trans woman in the Summer Olympics has prompted controversy — and uproar — with critics saying her eligibility is a threat to fairness in sport. Others say the inclusion of trans athletes cannot be overlooked if there are no meaningful advantages.

What does the science tell us about trans athletes in elite sport?

Few studies have been done on trans people's athletic performance — and, to date, there are no published studies on trans athletes participating at the elite level, say experts. But some papers have been published in the lead-up to the Olympic Games. One study, published in 2020, looked at US military personnel who transitioned while in service and found that trans women maintain an edge after one year of feminizing hormone therapy, which usually includes suppressing testosterone levels and boosting estrogen. The research was carried out by Dr. Timothy Roberts, a pediatrician and associate professor at the University of Missouri-Kansas City, and his colleagues. They found that trans women who underwent hormone therapy for one year continued to outperform non-transgender women, also known as cisgender women, though the gap largely closed after two years. But even then, trans women still ran 12% faster.

Roberts, however, suggested the difference in running times needs additional perspective. "It was a 12% advantage after two years in run times. But to be in the top 10% of female runners, you have to be 29% faster than the average woman. And to be an elite runner, you've got to be 59% faster than the average cis woman," he told DW. Another study, carried out by sports scientist Tommy Lundberg, found that trans women who underwent feminizing hormone therapy generally maintained their strength levels after one year.

Do trans women have an advantage when competing in elite sports?

Without hormone therapy — yes. But even with hormone therapy, current research suggests trans women still maintain an edge in strength. "Pretty much any way you slice it, trans women are going to have strength advantages even after hormone therapy. I just don't see that as anything else but factual," said Joanna Harper, a medical physicist at Britain's Loughborough University.

Strength is one of several key factors — including explosiveness, endurance and lean body mass — that determine whether an athlete has an edge. But Harper, whose research focused on trans runners like herself, rejects the idea that trans women competing in sport would have an "unfair" advantage, noting that there are many other factors that go into shaping how an athlete performs — including hand-eye coordination and technique, which are necessary for excelling in sports like golf.

35 One major factor is hemoglobin levels — which is the most important physiological factor when it comes to endurance sport. Hemoglobin in the blood transports oxygen throughout the body, including to the muscles. Since hemoglobin levels follow testosterone levels, non-transgender men tend to have higher hemoglobin levels than cisgender women. But Harper's study found that testosterone suppressants reduced hemoglobin levels in trans women to that of cisgender women, thus eliminating the advantage.

40 For Tommy Lundberg, whose research at Sweden's Karolinska Institute focuses on skeletal muscle strength of trans people receiving hormone therapy, the advantages for trans women in strength are to the point where fairness cannot be ensured in most sports. "The big problem right now is that the [hormone] therapy itself doesn't really remove the advantage to an extent that you can claim that fairness has been achieved," Lundberg told DW. "And actually, the IOC (International Olympic
45 Committee) states that the overriding objective is, and remains, the guarantee of fair competition. That's what they say in their guidelines. So that's the problem right now: They don't go hand-in-hand."

In another paper Lundberg co-authored that looked at untrained trans women, Lundberg and his colleague found that "muscular advantage enjoyed by transgender women is only minimally reduced when testosterone is suppressed." The study, like any other — including Roberts and Harper's — has
50 its limitations. Harper, who had also done a review of a similar set of studies to Lundberg's, said both of their studies found a "fairly modest change" in strength in non-athletic trans people. "But their review made it seem more definitive than our review did," she said.

"If you are looking for information on cisgender athletes, you'd never use studies on non-athletic trans people. You just wouldn't do that. It's just that we don't have any data on trans athletes. So I think you
55 have to take the results with a certain grain of salt."

When do differences between sexes in athletic performance emerge?

Young boys and girls, regardless of the gender assigned at birth, have similar muscle mass. It's only once a child experiences puberty that the differences begin to emerge — and they become pronounced once boys experience a surge in testosterone. "Typically, if you're 8 or 9 years old, there
60 is no biological performance difference between boys and girls. So it starts at around age 11 where you start to see this disparity — and then it really kicks in during puberty. And then you have, basically, this big difference in muscle mass," said Lundberg.

Roberts, who is a pediatrician specializing in adolescent medicine, said: "Younger children before puberty — there is no reason to have divisions of sex between boys and girls. They're physiologically
65 fairly equivalent. It's after puberty that you really see this divergence in athletic performance."

There have been no studies carried out on adolescent trans athletes. So there is no data on trans athletes who took puberty blockers or gender-affirming hormone therapy during puberty — and certainly none before puberty. Part of this comes down to following guidelines. The World Professional Association for Transgender Health requires trans adolescents to have begun puberty
70 before undergoing puberty suppressants, the first stage before undergoing hormone therapy.

Trans adolescents in sport have made headlines in recent years, as more than a dozen US states have a policy that allows trans girls to compete competitively at the high school level as long as they self-identify as female. For Blair Hamilton, a Brighton University researcher on trans athletes, this doesn't go far enough to achieve an equal playing field.

75 "For example, Connecticut was allowing [trans female runners] to race unmedicated," said Hamilton, who is also a transgender footballer. "We don't agree with that." Hamilton said athletes seeking

eligibility to run in competitive races in the female category should first undergo hormone therapy to reduce the advantages. To do otherwise, said Roberts, would give them an edge. "To compete against the females as soon as you socially transition — before you get any hormone blockers or hormone therapy — it's unfair." "Tomorrow, if I said: 'I'm a woman and I'm going to go compete in the women's class.' It's unfair. I still have testosterone, I have all the advantages I started with," said Roberts.

What is the recommended testosterone for trans women to compete?

This is a thorny issue that sports scientists disagree on. The "normal" healthy range for cis women is between 0.3 and 2 nmol/L, according to Mayo Clinic estimates — though they vary among labs. Women with polycystic ovarian syndrome tend to have higher testosterone levels, which can reach 5.2 nmol/L. "Healthy" male testosterone ranges from 8.3 nmol/L to 32.9 nmol/L.

The IOC's regulations say trans women can compete if their testosterone levels in serum are at 10 nanomoles per liter for a year for at least 12 months prior to their first competition. With Roberts and Lundberg's recent papers, however, the IOC has faced renewed criticism following Hubbard's inclusion due to its eligibility criteria. But the IOC said it would not review its guidelines — set in place in 2015 — until after the Tokyo Games.

World Athletics (IAAF) in 2019 changed its rules, requiring testosterone levels to be below 5 nmol/L continuously for at least 12 months. This criterion for trans women is backed by Hamilton as well as Harper, who noted the IOC's current guidelines are based on outdated techniques measuring testosterone levels. But the IAAF's criteria runs contrary to Roberts' study on trans military personnel, which suggests two years of hormone therapy is needed before competing.

Lundberg, however, said there is no sufficient evidence that two years would be enough to ensure fairness in the female category in most sports. "It would be an easy fix if you could just change regulation to two years, instead of one. But I don't think that's a feasible solution either. Actually, right now, there is nothing to indicate that."

Do trans men have an advantage when competing in elite sport?

"What we've got in our study is, actually, the trans men dominated," said Roberts, referring to his study on trans US military personnel. After one year of masculinizing hormones, there was no difference in pushup or run times — however, the number of situps performed in one minute by trans men exceeded cisgender men, or non-transgender men. "But nobody's up in arms saying that trans men are going to dominate men's sports," said Roberts, adding that much of the advantage gained for a cisgender man occurs during puberty. "Having gone through female puberty does not provide you with a baseline skeletal advantage over your average cis man. You're getting testosterone, which levels the playing field in large part because testosterone really produces a lot of differences, but there's not that extra anatomical advantage that a trans woman has over cis women — a trans man isn't going to have that over a cis man," he said.

Sports scientist Lundberg notes that trans men competing is "not as sensitive in sports." "Even if they get testosterone, it's not a threat to fairness if they switch to the male category," he said. "The problem then is, of course, if they would want to stay in the women's category even when they get testosterone — because then it would become doping."

Is there a way to achieve both fairness and inclusion in sport?

None of the experts interviewed support a blanket ban on trans athletes, which is in line with a recent study. But experts, like Lundberg, say the regulations should be determined on a sport-by-sport basis, especially when safety is a factor, like in rugby. "We don't have this easy fix or easy regulation that can

120 be applied," said Lundberg. "You basically have to choose or prioritize either inclusion or fairness. They don't go hand-in-hand right now."

"And in most sports, it's going to be problematic to include transgender women and achieve fairness. That's what the current research suggests," he said. Lundberg's research has seen him come under fire on social media, with many accusing him of being transphobic. But he tells DW that is not the case.

125 "I think the transgender issue is very important. But protecting the women's category in sport is also very important. They have fought long enough to have fair competition in sport," he said.

In the meantime, sports scientists and researchers will continue to debate and advise on what the best steps forward will be. "There's not very much information out there and even less that's really specific to trans athletes. But the Olympics are here, international sports are here, and trans people are around. So decisions have to be made," medical physicist Harper said. "So people have to make the best decisions they can with the data that are available now."

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"And hopefully, as we get more — and better — data, it will lead to improved policies."

For reflection/discussion:

1. How have scientific studies been used to shape public perception towards trans-athletes' participation in sports? Can science have a significant impact on social norms?
2. Who are the other stakeholders involved in this issue? What do their concerns say about social norms and sports in general?
3. The debate about transgender athletes is one specific issue within a broader discussion concerning transgender rights. What is another issue you can think of, where a similar tension between inclusivity and fairness can be observed? Explain your answer.
4. How do current regulations on trans athletes' participation align with the ideals of inclusivity and fairness in sports?
5. While the broader debate concerns trans athletes, the discussion has been centred on trans women's participation in competitions. Why do you think this is the case? Concurrently, there is also a greater focus on trans women in the larger trans debate. What do you think this illustrates about the larger trans movement? Do you think it is cause for celebration or pessimism? Why?
6. In Y5 Term 1, we learnt that being 'constructions of reality', the media can significantly shape 'perceptions of the world' (see Media Issues, EUs 3 and 4). How do you think the media has shaped and continues to shape the way people understand the debate on trans athletes and trans people?

Related Cambridge/RI essay questions:

1. Do you think there is much ambiguity and confusion about what it means to be a man in today's world? (Y6 CT2 2020)
2. Consider the view that we are moving further away from, rather than moving closer to, achieving gender equality. (RI Y6 Timed Practice 2022)
3. 'We can never close the gender divide.' Do you agree?
4. 'Change should always be embraced.' Comment. (RI Y5 CT1 2014)
5. Consider the view that gender equality is a desirable but unrealistic goal. (Y5 Timed Practice 2020)
6. 'It is surprising that discrimination still exists in the world today.' How far do you agree? (Y5 Timed Practice 2020)

SECTION A: GENDER ISSUES

Reading 5: Only half of women in developing world in charge of their own bodies

EU 1- 4

Lin Taylor | Thomson Reuters Foundation | 14 April 2021

This reading helps you understand:

- The different ways in which the lack of body autonomy has affected women in developing societies
- The sociocultural origins of such practices, which worsen gender inequality
- How the pandemic has magnified such inequalities

Only about half of women and girls in developing countries are able to make decisions over their own bodies such as whether they want to have sex, seek healthcare and use contraception, a United Nations report said on Wednesday.

5 From being denied access to contraception or abortion services, made to undergo female genital mutilation (FGM) and virginity tests, or married as children, women and girls are often forced to give up control over their bodies, it said. “The right to autonomy over our bodies means we must have the power and agency to make choices without fear of violence or having someone else decide for us,” said Natalia Kanem, head of the U.N.’s sexual and reproductive health agency, UNFPA.

10 Women in sub-Saharan Africa, South and Central Asia are least likely to have control over their bodies, such as being able to refuse sex with a partner or accessing sexual healthcare without needing permission from a male relative, UNFPA said. In places including Mali, Niger and Senegal, only 10% of women had “bodily autonomy”, said the report, which analysed multiple datasets on gender equality, sexual health and access to contraception in 57 countries.

15 Kanem said social taboos around sex and entrenched patriarchy prevented women and girls from having any say, since male relatives tended to have power over women’s choices. “Gender inequality is the most insidious and pervasive impediment to bodily autonomy. It starts from the cradle,” Kanem, a paediatrician and epidemiologist, told reporters in an online media briefing. “Gender unequal norms and attitudes lead to power imbalances that restrict women’s decision-making ... (driving) the expectation that women and girls will yield to others in all aspects of their lives.”

20 Kanem added that the coronavirus pandemic had worsened existing inequalities for women and girls. “What was previously bad is now worse with the COVID-19 pandemic which has resulted in increasing sexual violence, more unintended pregnancies, and new barriers to health access along with job and education losses.”

25 UNFPA said last April that global lockdowns could lead to a 20% surge in domestic violence as victims remained trapped at home with their abusers. Researchers also predicted there could be an extra 13 million child marriages and another 2 million cases of FGM in the next decade as the pandemic stymies global efforts to end both practices.

30 Deepening poverty caused by a global recession could also drive more families to marry off their daughters early, UNFPA said. Despite such setbacks, a World Bank report in February said 27 countries reformed laws or regulations to give women more economic equality with men in 2019-20.

For reflection/discussion:

Reading 4:

1. In the overview provided in reading 4 of policies that different regions have adopted to improve the lot of women, assess and classify the priorities in which each region has focused their efforts on in the following areas:
 - a. *Work-Life balance*
 - b. *Equal Pay*
 - c. *Harassment*
 - d. *Career Opportunities*
 - e. *Children & Career*
2. Which areas in the above classifications have seen the most improvements? How will these positive changes impact women in these regions?
3. What areas have seen the least improvements? How will these gaps further impact the plight of women?

Reading 5:

4. In groups, analyse the strength of the following factors that contribute towards the problems resulting from the lack of body autonomy mentioned in this article:
 - a. *Traditional views and practices*
 - b. *Lack of governance in enshrining and enforcing the rule of law to protect the rights of women*
 - c. *Lack of awareness due to limited education and/or media exposure*
5. What could be the potential long-term effects on a society that denies women the ability to make decisions regarding their reproductive health?

Related Cambridge/RI essay questions:

1. Evaluate the claim that equality of opportunity for females in a desirable, but unrealistic, goal. (Cambridge 2016)
2. How far would you agree that technological progress has done more harm than good for gender equality? (RI Y6 Timed Practice 2021)
3. 'It is a woman's world today.' How far do you agree? (RI Y5 CT 2021)
4. 'A nation cannot really progress until it empowers its women.' Do you agree? (RI Y6 CT1 2011)

SECTION B: ISSUES TO DO WITH FAMILY, MARRIAGE & PARENTING

Reading 6: The nuclear family was a mistake

EU 3 & 6

Adapted from The nuclear family was a mistake | David Brooks | The Atlantic | February 2020

This reading will help you understand that:

- The family structure is determined by the prevailing socio-economic and cultural forces and how these shifts will lead to a change in people's attitudes towards the family.
- The "nuclear family" structure may not be as ideal as some may have considered it to be.
- With the fall of the nuclear family, extended families might be able to fill the gap and maintain social stability, particularly for the marginalised.

The story of our times is that of the family, once a dense cluster of many siblings and extended kin, fragmenting into ever smaller and more fragile forms. We've moved from big, interconnected, and extended families, which helped protect the most vulnerable people in society from the shocks of life, to smaller, detached nuclear families (a married couple and their children).

- 5 For a time, it all seemed to work. From 1950 to 1965, divorce rates dropped, fertility rates rose, and the American nuclear family seemed to be in wonderful shape. Most people seemed prosperous and happy. In these years, a certain family ideal became engraved in our minds: the two-parent nuclear family, with one or two kids, living in some detached family home on some suburban street. We take it as the norm, even though this wasn't the way most humans lived during the tens of thousands of
- 10 years before 1950, and it isn't the way most humans have lived during the 55 years since 1965.

The fall of the "nuclear family"

- Today, only a minority of American households are traditional two parent nuclear families and only one-third of American individuals live in this kind of family. That 1950–65 window was not normal. It was a freakish historical moment when all of society conspired, wittingly and not, to obscure the
- 15 essential fragility of the nuclear family.

- For one thing, most women were relegated to the home. Many corporations, well into the mid-20th century, barred married women from employment: Companies would hire single women, but if those women got married, they would have to quit. Demeaning and disempowering treatment of women was rampant. Women spent enormous numbers of hours trapped inside the home under the headship
- 20 of their husband, raising children.

The period from 1950 to 1965 demonstrated that a stable society can be built around nuclear families – so long as women are relegated to the household, nuclear families are so intertwined that they are basically extended families by another name, and every economic and sociological condition in society is working together to support the institution.

- 25 But these conditions did not last. The constellation of forces that had briefly shored up the nuclear family began to fall away, and the sheltered family of the 1950s was supplanted by the stressed family of every decade since.

- Some of the strains were economic. Starting in the mid-'70s, young men's wages declined, putting pressure on working class families in particular. The major strains were cultural. Society became more
- 30 individualistic and more self-oriented. People put greater value on privacy and autonomy. A rising feminist movement helped endow women with greater freedom to live and work as they chose.

Also, since the 1960s, the dominant family culture has been the “self-expressive marriage.” “Americans,” he has written, “now look to marriage increasingly for self-discovery, self-esteem and personal growth.” Marriage, according to the sociologists Kathryn Edin and Maria Kefalas, “is no longer primarily about childbearing and childrearing. Now marriage is primarily about adult fulfilment.”

Fallout from the fall

This cultural shift was very good for some adults, but it was not so good for families generally. Fewer relatives are around in times of stress to help a couple work through them. If you married for love, staying together made less sense when the love died.

Over the past two generations, people have spent less and less time in marriage – they are marrying later, if at all, and divorcing more. In 1950, 27 percent of marriages ended in divorce; today, about 45 percent do. In 1960, 72 percent of American adults were married. In 2017, nearly half of American adults were single.

And while more than four-fifths of American adults in a 2019 Pew Research Center survey said that getting married is not essential to living a fulfilling life, it’s not just the institution of marriage they’re eschewing: In 2004, 33 percent of Americans ages 18 to 34 were living without a romantic partner, according to the General Social Survey; by 2018, that number was up to 51 percent.

Over the past two generations, families have also gotten a lot smaller. The general American birth rate is half of what it was in 1960. In 2012, most American family households had no children. There are more American homes with pets than with kids. In 1970, about 20 percent of households had five or more people. As of 2012, only 9.6 percent did.

Over the past two generations, the physical space separating nuclear families has widened. Married people are less likely to visit parents and siblings, and less inclined to help them do chores or offer emotional support. A code of family self-sufficiency prevails: Mom, Dad, and the kids are on their own, with a barrier around their island home.

Finally, over the past two generations, families have grown more unequal. America now has two entirely different family regimes. Among the highly educated, family patterns are almost as stable as they were in the 1950s; among the less fortunate, family life is often utter chaos. There’s a reason for that divide: Affluent people have the resources to effectively buy extended family, in order to shore themselves up. Think of all the child-rearing labour affluent parents now buy that used to be done by extended kin: babysitting, professional child care, tutoring, coaching, therapy, expensive after-school programs. (For that matter, think of how the affluent can hire therapists and life coaches for themselves, as replacement for kin or close friends.)

These expensive tools and services not only support children’s development and help prepare them to compete in the meritocracy; by reducing stress and time commitments for parents, they preserve the amity of marriage. Affluent conservatives often preach that everybody else should build stable families too. But then they ignore one of the main reasons their own families are stable: They can afford to purchase the support that extended family used to provide – and that the people they preach at, further down the income scale, cannot.

When you put everything together, we’re likely living through the most rapid change in family structure in human history. People who grow up in a nuclear family tend to have a more individualistic mind-set than people who grow up in a multigenerational extended clan. People with an individualistic mind-set tend to be less willing to sacrifice self for the sake of the family, and the result is more family disruption. People who grow up in disrupted families have more trouble getting the education they

75 need to have prosperous careers. People who don't have prosperous careers have trouble building stable families, because of financial challenges and other stressors. The children in those families become more isolated and more traumatized.

Who's paying the price?

80 The people who suffer the most are the vulnerable – especially children. In 1960, roughly 5 percent of children were born to unmarried women. Now about 40 percent are. The Pew Research Center reported that 11 percent of children lived apart from their father in 1960. In 2010, 27 percent did. Now about half of American children will spend their childhood with both biological parents.

85 About twenty percent of young adults have no contact at all with their father. American children are more likely to live in a single-parent household than children from any other country. Children of single parents or unmarried cohabiting parents tend to have worse health outcomes, worse mental-health outcomes, less academic success, more behavioural problems, and higher truancy rates than do children living with their two married biological parents.

90 Single men are affected too. Today many American males spend the first 20 years of their life without a father and the next 15 without a spouse. In the absence of the connection and meaning that family provides, unmarried men are less healthy – alcohol and drug abuse are common – earn less, and die sooner than married men.

95 For women, the nuclear-family structure imposes different pressures. Though women have benefited greatly from the loosening of traditional family structures – they have more freedom to choose the lives they want – many mothers who decide to raise their young children without extended family nearby find that they have chosen a lifestyle that is brutally hard and isolating. The situation is exacerbated by the fact that women still spend significantly more time on housework and child care than men do, according to recent data. Thus, the reality we see around us: stressed, tired mothers trying to balance work and parenting, and having to reschedule work when family life gets messy.

100 Without extended families, older Americans have also suffered. According to the AARP, 35 percent of Americans over 45 say they are chronically lonely. Many older people are now “elder orphans,” with no close relatives or friends to take care of them. In 2015, The New York Times ran an article called “The Lonely Death of George Bell,” about a family-less 72-year-old man who died alone and rotted in his Queens apartment for so long that by the time police found him, his body was unrecognizable.

105 Finally, because groups that have endured greater levels of discrimination tend to have more fragile families, African Americans have suffered disproportionately. Nearly half of black families are led by an unmarried single woman, compared with less than one-sixth of white families. (The high rate of black incarceration guarantees a shortage of available men to be husbands or caretakers of children.) According to census data from 2010, 25 percent of black women over 35 have never been married, compared with 8 percent of white women. Two-thirds of African American children lived in single-parent families in 2018, compared with a quarter of white children. Black single-parent families are most concentrated in precisely those parts of the country in which slavery was most prevalent. Research by John Iceland, a Penn state professor of sociology, suggests that the differences between white and black family structure explain 30 percent of the affluence gap between the two groups.

115 Americans are now hungry to live in extended and forged families, in ways that are new and ancient at the same time. This is a significant opportunity, a chance to thicken and broaden family relationships, a chance to allow more adults and children to live and grow under the loving gaze of a dozen pairs of eyes, and be caught, when they fall, by a dozen pairs of arms.

For decades we have been eating at smaller and smaller tables, with fewer and fewer kin. It's time to find ways to bring back the big tables.

For discussion/reflection:

- According to Brooks, what were the preconditions existing in America from 1950 to 1965 that allowed the nuclear family to be temporarily successful?
- What are some factors contributing to the weakening of the nuclear family structure over the last 50 years?
- How applicable are these factors to your society? Do you observe a similar shift/weakening in nuclear family structure in your society? Which factors were particularly significant and why?
- How has the shift from extended families to smaller ones affected the support that family members used to provide each other?
- How have changes in societal and/or cultural norms influenced perceptions of marriage and parenting?

Related Cambridge/RI essay questions:

1. 'Young people today have little interest in traditional marriage.' How true is this of your society? (Y6 Timed Practice 2023)
2. Is the traditional family still relevant in your society today? (RI Y6 Timed Practice 2021)
3. 'The idea of marriage is outdated in modern society.' Discuss. (RI Y5 CT 2018)
4. 'Modern life is not conducive to the survival of the family.' Comment. (RI Y6 CT1 2013)

Supplementary reading:

1. "Singapore's total fertility rate hits record low in 2023, falls below 1 for first time" – Theresa Tan, The Straits Times, 29 Feb 2024 (<https://www.straitstimes.com/singapore/politics/singapore-s-total-fertility-rate-hits-record-low-in-2023-falls-below-1-for-first-time>)

SECTION B: ISSUES TO DO WITH FAMILY, MARRIAGE & PARENTING

Reading 7: The nuclear family is no mistake

EU 3 & 6

Adapted from The Nuclear Family Is Still Indispensable | Hal Boyd & W. Bradford Wilcox | The Atlantic | 21 February 2020

This reading will help you understand that:

- Multigenerational families and other family structures cannot replace the nuclear family.
- The nuclear family will have spillover effects on the safety of the larger community and neighbourhood.

The nuclear family is disintegrating – or so Americans might conclude from what they watch and read. The quintessential nuclear family consists of a married couple raising their children. But from Oscar-winning *Marriage Story*'s gut-wrenching portrayal of divorce or the Harvard sociologist Christina Cross's *New York Times* op-ed in December, "The Myth of the Two-Parent Home," discounting the importance of marriage for kids, one might draw the conclusion that marriage is more endangered than ever – and that this might not be such a bad thing.

Meanwhile, the writer David Brooks recently described the post–World War II American concept of family as a historical aberration – a departure from a much older tradition in which parents, grandparents, siblings, and cousins all look out for the well-being of children. In an article in *The Atlantic* bearing the headline "The Nuclear Family Was a Mistake", Brooks argued that the "nuclear family has been crumbling in slow motion for decades." He sees extended families and what he calls "forged families" – single parents, single adults, and others coming together to support one another and children – as filling the vacuum created by the breakdown of the nuclear family.

Yet the search for alternate forms of family has two major flaws. First, there's evidence indicating that the nuclear family is, in fact, recovering. Second, a nuclear family headed by two loving married parents remains the most stable and safest environment for raising children.

There are, of course, still reasons for legitimate concern about the state of the American family. Marriage today is less likely to anchor family life in many poor and working-class communities. While a majority of college-educated men and women between 18 and 55 are married, that's no longer true for the poor (only 26 percent are married) and the working class (39 percent). What's more, children from these families are markedly less likely to live under the same roof as their biological parents than their peers from better-off backgrounds are.

But there is also ample good news – especially for kids. Today, the divorce rate is down, having fallen by more than 30 percent since peaking around 1980, in the wake of the divorce revolution. And, since the Great Recession, out-of-wedlock births are now dipping as well. Less divorce and less non-marital childbearing means that more children are being raised in stable, married families. Since 2014, the share of kids in intact families has begun to climb, reversing a decades-long trend in the opposite direction. And as Brooks noted – citing research that one of us conducted at the University of Virginia – the nuclear family headed by married parents remains a personal ideal even among men and women who harbour no moral objections to alternative family structures.

None of this suggests that scholars and social commentators are wrong to extol the role extended families can play in improving children's lives. In her *New York Times* article raising questions about the importance of the two-parent home, Cross hypothesised that living closer to extended family may actually be helping protect black children "against some of the negative effects associated with parental absence from the home". And, in Brooks' evocative telling, the alternatives to the nuclear

family hold enormous promise: “Americans are hungering to live in extended and forged families”, arrangements that “allow more adults and children to live and grow under the loving gaze of a dozen pairs of eyes, and be caught, when they fall, by a dozen pairs of arms”.

40 Grandparents, for example, are sharing homes with children and grandchildren; single adults and single parents are forging novel alliances on websites like CoAbode, where, according to Brooks, “single mothers can find other single mothers interested in sharing a home.” These emerging arrangements not only afford people more freedom to choose their own ties that bind, but they also promise to fill the void left in the absence of a strong nuclear family.

45 There’s no question that “a dozen pairs of arms” can make lighter work of family life. Society should applaud those who step up to try to rescue adults and children left adrift in a nation where, despite promising trends, many children still grow up outside an intact two-parent family.

Why the “nuclear family” still matters

But Americans should not presume that society can successfully replace families headed by married parents with models oriented more around kith and kin. Caution is especially warranted as extended families and communities struggle to foster upward mobility or to raise the next generation successfully in circumstances where the family once anchored by marriage has broken down in their midst.

55 It turns out that the relationship between nuclear families and larger communities is more symbiotic than substitutionary, more interdependent than interchangeable. Whatever the merits of extended or other non-nuclear forms of family life, research has yet to show that they are entirely equipped to shoulder the unique role of a child’s two parents.

Today, most multigenerational households – which include grandparents, parents, and children – contain only one parent. This often occurs because a mother has moved in with her own parent (or the reverse) following a divorce or breakup. According to the sociologist Wendy Wang, 65 percent of multigenerational families include a single parent. But research reveals mixed outcomes for such households.

65 Sara McLanahan of Princeton University and Gary Sandefur of the University of Wisconsin have found that the average child raised by a “mother and grandmother is doing about the same as the average child raised by a single mother” on outcomes such as dropping out of high school or having a teen birth. And in the absence of both parents, children raised by their extended kin, such as an aunt or uncle, are significantly more likely to have, in the words of one study, “higher levels of internalising problems” – including loneliness and sadness – compared to their peers raised by married parents.

70 As for other emerging forms of family, such as forged families, there are well-founded reasons for scepticism about the role unrelated adults might play in raising a child. Over the years, study after study has detailed the many possible downsides to introducing unrelated adults, especially men, into children’s lives without the presence of those children’s married parents.

75 This is because, sadly, adults who are unrelated to children are much more likely to abuse or neglect them than their own parents are. One federal report found that children living in a household with an unrelated adult were about nine times more likely to be physically, sexually, or emotionally abused than children raised in an intact nuclear family. All this is to say that, for kids, it matters if all the pairs of arms raising them include – first and foremost – those of their own parents.

The positive effects of stable marriage and stable nuclear families also spill over. Neighbourhoods, towns, and cities are more likely to flourish when they are sustained by lots of married households.

The work of the Harvard sociologist Robert Sampson tells us that neighbourhoods with many two-parent families are much safer. In his own words: “Family structure is one of the strongest, if not the strongest, predictor[s] of variations in urban violence across cities in the United States.”

His Harvard colleagues, the economists Raj Chetty and Nathaniel Hendren, have drawn similar conclusions about the relationship between the health of the American dream and the presence of two-parent families in a community. Working with a team of scholars, they found that black boys are more likely to achieve upward economic mobility if there are more black fathers in a neighbourhood – and more married couples, as well. And for poor children of all races, Chetty and his team have found that the fraction of children with single parents in a given community is the strongest and most robust predictor of economic mobility – or its absence. Children raised in communities with high percentages of single mothers are less likely to move up. In other words, it takes a village – but of *married* people – to raise the odds that a poor child will have a shot at the American dream.

To be sure, the isolated nuclear family detached from all social support is simply not workable for most people. Married couples raising children – as well as other family forms – are more likely to thrive when they are embedded in strong networks of friends, family, community, and religious congregations.

Likewise, communities are stronger and safer when they include lots of committed married couples. It’s good news, then, that the share of children being raised by their own married parents is on the rise. Extended kin can (and sometimes must) play a greater role in meeting children’s needs. But as any parent knows, when it comes to an inconsolable child, even a “dozen pairs of arms” from the village don’t quite compare to the warm and safe embrace of Mom or Dad.

For discussion/reflection:

- What are some reasons provided by the authors to support their view that the nuclear family is still indispensable?
- Why do the authors assert that ‘the relationship between nuclear families and larger communities is more symbiotic than substitutionary, more interdependent than interchangeable’ (lines 52-53)? How far do you agree with their arguments?
- While Brooks in the previous reading talks about the fall of the nuclear family and the need for extended families to fill the gap, Boyd and Wilcox believe that the nuclear family is still an important unit that cannot be replaced by extended families. Whose view do you think is more applicable to your society? Why?
- How might the upbringing of children in multigenerational households differ from those in two-parent households? What advantages and disadvantages are there to multigenerational households in terms of raising children?

Related RI essay questions:

1. ‘The traditional family has lost its importance today.’ Discuss. (RI Y5 CT 2022)
2. ‘Modern life is not conducive to the family.’ Do you agree? (RI Y6 CT1 2013)
3. ‘The family has suffered at the expense of economic growth in Singapore.’ How far do you agree? (RI Y5 CT 2011)

SECTION B: ISSUES TO DO WITH FAMILY, MARRIAGE & PARENTING

Reading 8: Singapore does not encourage single parenthood as a lifestyle choice **EU 1-3, 5 & 6**

Authorities Looking at Adoption Laws and Surrogacy, Do Not Support Gay Families | Rachel Au-Yong | The Straits Times | 14 January 2019 [adapted]

This reading will help you understand:

- The ethical, social, health and legal implications of adoption and surrogacy as a form of forming families
- That legislation and policy-making regarding adoption and surrogacy must take into account values of broader society

A landmark case in late 2018 saw the High Court of Singapore uphold an appeal to allow a gay father to adopt his biological child who was conceived through a commercial surrogate in the United States. This raised a question in parliament about whether a loophole in the laws surrounding the adoption process was being exploited.

5

Desmond Lee, Minister for Social and Family Development, acknowledges that lesbian, gay, bisexual and transgender people have a place in Singapore society and are entitled to their own private lives, but he stressed that Singapore does not support the formation of family units with children by gay parents, especially through processes such as adoption.

10

Currently, **surrogacy is barred in Singapore**. Those who have gone abroad for it and returned home to apply for adoption of their surrogate children will have their applications assessed on a case-by-case basis. To date, the courts have granted the adoption of 10 surrogate children to married couples who had turned to surrogacy because of infertility issues.

15

But the surrogacy issue, Mr Lee said, “is a complex issue with ethical, social, health and legal implications for all parties involved”. He added, “For commercial surrogacy in particular, concerns have been raised about the exploitation of women and commodification of children. These issues are not trivial, and warrant careful study and discussion.” He also cautions that those who are considering surrogacy should take this into account as it could have a significant impact on the child.

20

Members of parliament have pointed out that commercial surrogacy is exploitative to women and commodifies the life of a baby and hence, urges strict changes to be made to the adoption laws. Mr Lee, however, is cautious as such a decision needs to be made “holistically and carefully, keeping in mind the wishes, aspirations and concerns of mothers who would otherwise not be able to conceive their own flesh and blood.”

25

In the review of the Adoption of Children Act, the focus is to see how it can be “strengthened to better reflect public policy, which is, in turn, a reflection of the values of our broad society today,” Mr Lee said. Noting that the **“prevailing social norm” is still that of a man and woman marrying, and having and bringing up children in a stable family unit**, Mr Lee said his ministry did not support the gay couple's appeal to adopt the child, as “this would have been contrary to public policy”.

30

He added: “For instance, while the welfare of the child should always be a very important consideration in adoption proceedings, we are looking at whether the Adoption of Children Act needs to be amended so that an appropriate balance can be struck when important public policy considerations are involved.”

When questioned if the ministry would be involved in the monitoring of the gay couple's child in ensuring his psychological and mental well-being, Mr Lee replied: “We are concerned about the

35 formation and mainstreaming of same-sex parent family units in Singapore, **but when it comes to the welfare of the child, we have to act on the basis of whether there are concerns.**"

"Just like other Singaporeans, they have access to opportunities and social support such as education, employment, and healthcare, and should, like all Singaporeans, not be subject to prejudice and discrimination," he said. "However, we must be mindful that a push for rights and entitlements which
40 broader society is not ready for, or able to accept, will provoke a pushback, and can be very socially divisive. A push to use legislation or the courts to precipitate social change involving issues as deeply held and personal as this polarises society."

Mr Lee further added that "[m]ost of us would agree that it is ideal for children to grow up in families anchored by strong and stable marriages ... It follows that the **Government does not encourage
45 planned and deliberate single parenthood as a lifestyle choice.**" He also pointed out that "[w]hile adoption may make a child legitimate under law, it does not guarantee benefits and privileges such as citizenship, education or housing."

But, he added, "All Singaporean children, regardless of their legitimacy status, will receive government benefits that support their growth and development, including healthcare and education benefits."
50

In response to the 2018 landmark case, new laws regarding adoption were then enacted and tightened under the Singapore's Adoption of Children Act 2022 legislation, where any method including the use of assisted reproduction technology or surrogacy to conceive outside of "parenthood within marriage" was deemed to go against public policy and would be taken into consideration when determining a
55 couple's suitability to adopt.

For discussion/reflection:

1. According to Desmond Lee, surrogacy is 'a complex issue with ethical, social, health and legal implications for all parties involved' (lines XX). What are these implications and who are the parties involved?
2. In your opinion, should surrogacy be accepted as a way of forming families in your society? Consider this from multiple vantage points, such as from a social or ethical perspective.
3. Why do you think the government is 'concerned about the formation and mainstreaming of same-sex parent family units in Singapore' (lines XX)? Do you agree with this view? Provide a further point of support as well as opposition of your own.
4. Singapore's laws do not recognise same-sex marriage and the formation of same-sex parent family units, and children are only considered legitimate if they are born in a traditional family unit. Is it justified for the government to write laws that invalidate same-sex parent family units, and promote heterosexual parent family units?

Related Cambridge/RI essay questions:

1. To what extent are people in your society treated equally? (RI 2024 Y4 TP)
2. 'Young people today have little interest in traditional marriage.' How true is this of your society? (Y6 Timed Practice 2023)
3. Is marriage still an attractive option in today's world? (RI Y5 CT 2021)
4. Is diversity of people and their viewpoints truly celebrated in your society? (RI Y6 CT 2021)
5. Assess the view that your society is not doing enough to eradicate prejudice. (RI Y6 Prelim 2019)

SECTION B: ISSUES TO DO WITH FAMILY, MARRIAGE & PARENTING

Reading 9: Paternity leave has long-lasting benefits. So why don't more American men take it?

EU 3 & 6

Nathaniel Popper | *The New York Times* | 11 June 2019

This reading will help you understand that:

- Parental leave for men is a growing trend in many societies, though it may take different forms.
- Parental leave is significantly changing parenting patterns, while resulting in a range of positive outcomes for families in particular.
- The expansion of paternity leave programmes in some industrialised countries may overcome sociocultural barriers traditionally preventing fathers from taking paternity leave.

In 2017, my family and I began an unintended experiment, testing the effects of paternity leave.

When my first son was born in 2012, I had only recently joined *The New York Times* and all I got off was the week of vacation I had stored up at the time.

5 By the time my wife and I had our second son in 2017, the newspaper had significantly ramped up its support for new fathers, and I got 10 fully-paid weeks to spend with our growing family. For my wife and me, those first two months of life with a **newborn** were just as sleepless as they'd been the first time around. But there were fewer fights and less resentment, and my wife got back to her own work more quickly.

10 Long after I returned to the office, I noticed little differences in the way I related to my second son that seemed most easily explained by the extra time I'd spent with him. To this day he regularly calls out for me in the night in a way that my first son rarely did. And when I am with him, I feel a certain intangible sense of ease that has only come more recently with my older son. This feeling of ease, along with my growing comfort with wrangling both kids at once, have had predictably positive effects on my wife, reducing her stress levels, and making us both happier.

15 While I've always been hesitant to attribute too many of the subsequent improvements in our family life to the parental leave I took in 2017, a growing body of research suggests that paternity leave does, in fact, have far broader effects than we might have anticipated, including some which endure years after the leave period itself.

Men who take paternity leave are less likely to get divorced

20 Over the last two years, Richard Petts, a sociology professor at Ball State University, and Chris Knoester, a sociology professor at Ohio State University, have co-authored a series of papers, analysing data from long-term surveys of thousands of American families. Their research demonstrates that paternity leave provides lasting benefits, not only to relationships between fathers and their children, but also to mothers and to relationships between the parents.

25 In their most recent paper, published in May 2019, Petts and Knoester found that, even nine years later, children whose fathers took at least two weeks of paternity leave after they were born reported feeling closer to their fathers than children with fathers who did not take leave. In research on married parents for a forthcoming paper, the sociologists found that even relatively short periods of paternity leave caused couples' divorce risk to drop and to remain significantly lower for as many as six years to come, even as their children reached school age.

30

“The big news in the US is that the boost is not just in the year or two after a child’s birth,” Petts told me. “It seems to be more sustained.” This new work on American families builds on several earlier papers, mostly from Europe, where paternity leave is more common, which found that fathers are, in the long term, more likely to remain involved in parenting and to equitably divide household chores with their partners if they take time off after their children arrive. A recent study from Sweden found that mothers whose partners were offered flexible paid leave in the year after a child’s birth were less likely to need antibiotics and anti-anxiety medication.

Despite mounting evidence of the benefits of paid parental leave for fathers as well as mothers, occasional high-profile news about a major international company offering paternity leave, and legal wins such as the settlement in which JPMorgan Chase agreed to provide equal benefits to fathers and mothers, the expansion of paternity leave programs in the United States remains slow.

Public enthusiasm for paternity leave has been growing: A 2016 Pew Research Center study found that nearly 70 percent of Americans support some form of paid leave for new fathers. There are signs of a rapid cultural shift as well. Though, in 2014, New York Mets second baseman Daniel Murphy faced widespread criticism for taking three days off for the birth of his son, just four years later, basketball player Dwayne Wade was showered with support when he missed six games following his daughter’s birth in 2018. Nevertheless, recent surveys suggest that, while most American men take some time off work after the birth or adoption of a child, most take no more than a few days’ leave.

Why aren’t American men taking leave?

There are several reasons new fathers in the United States return to work so quickly, the most obvious being the lack of a national policy mandating paid leave for all workers. The Family and Medical Leave Act guarantees 12 weeks of unpaid parental leave, but its eligibility requirements are strict (to qualify, an employee must have worked at least 1250 hours during the 12 months before the start of the leave period, for an organization employing at least 50 people within a 75-mile radius), and many American workers do not meet them.

Even fewer American parents have access to paid family leave. Though six states — California, Rhode Island, New York, New Jersey, Washington and Massachusetts — as well as the District of Columbia have passed paid family leave laws, their provisions vary. A March 2018 national survey conducted by the Bureau of Labor Statistics found that only 16 percent of workers in the United States have access to some paid family leave through private-sector employers.

And research suggests that, even when fathers do gain access to paid parental leave, they may be reluctant to take it. After California’s paid family leave law, the first such law enacted in the United States, took effect in 2004, economists Charles L. Baum and Christopher Ruhm found that the percentage of men taking time off after a child’s birth rose only modestly; the average period of parental leave taken increased by nearly five weeks for mothers, but only two to three days for fathers.

California fathers’ caution about embracing paid paternity leave wasn’t entirely irrational. Some studies do show that taking paternity leave can damage a man’s professional reputation and affect his future earning potential. “Men who take paternity leave do tend to be stigmatized and viewed as less committed employees,” said Rebecca Glauber, a professor of sociology at the University of New Hampshire.

How to make paternity leave an American norm

The successful expansion of paternity leave programs in other industrialized nations suggests that these cultural barriers can be overcome. Certain policies have been shown to be especially effective in encouraging men to take full advantage of paternity leave benefits. The adoption of a so-called “daddy quota,” for example — a use-it-or-lose-it period of paid leave earmarked for new fathers —

has successfully boosted paternity leave participation rates in several Scandinavian countries. In 2006, in a departure from the rest of Canada, Quebec adopted a “daddy quota” similar to the Scandinavian model, offering five weeks of dedicated, non-transferable, government-paid leave to new fathers in the province.

Within two years, 75 percent of new fathers in Quebec were taking paternity leave, up from 22 percent before the use-it-or-lose-it “daddy quota” was implemented, according to research by Ankita Patnaik, an economist at Mathematica Policy Research in Washington, D.C.

Patnaik found that men in Quebec who’d taken the “daddy quota” continued to spend more time on household work, even one to three years after completing their paternity leave. Further, Patnaik’s research found, these fathers’ increased participation in household tasks appeared to free up their children’s mothers to pursue their own professional ambitions. One to three years after childbirth, mothers in Quebec whose partners had taken the “daddy quota” were working an hour longer per day, on average, and were 7 percent more likely to be employed full-time, Patnaik found.

Richard Petts, the Ball State University sociologist who researches the impact of paternity leave on American families, said that he did not find solid evidence that paternity leave boosts mothers’ careers, but that may simply be because American fathers take much shorter paternity leaves than their Canadian counterparts.

For my part, I came out of my own paternity leave with an easy ability to take both of the kids as soon as I was done at work, or to handle sick days when they came up. That allowed my wife to transition back to her own job more quickly, and to commit with more confidence to new projects. We are both still as overwhelmed as most other parents of little kids, but at least we feel like we’re muddling through it together.

For discussion/reflection:

1. According to the research cited in the article, what are some of the long-term effects on children whose fathers took paternity leave?
2. What potential impact does the stigma associated with men taking paternity leave have on their professional lives?
3. Popper raises the issue of legislative constraints and sociocultural norms hindering fathers in America from taking paternal leave. In your opinion, how could these existing challenges be effectively mitigated, apart from a proposed adaptation of a “daddy quota” (line 77)? Justify your opinions, with additional reading and research of your own.

Supplementary readings:

- For a Singapore perspective:
 - [2019 Straits Times Article on 6/10 Fathers Taking Paternity Leave](#)
 - [2022 Straits Times Article on 1 in 2 Dads Taking Paternity leave](#)
 - [2024 CNA video - CNA 2024 How Fair is Paternal Leave?](#)
 - 2025 [Government Paid Paternity Leave](#)
- 4. In your view, how far will the measures detailed in the above readings be effective in mitigating the challenges faced by families/ supporting families with working parents?

Related Cambridge/RI essay questions:

1. ‘There is no point in fighting for gender equality today.’ Do you agree? (RI 2024 Y5 TP)
2. Should both parents take equal responsibility for raising their children? (Cambridge 2019)
3. In the family, should the most important role of a man be that of a breadwinner? (Y5 Promo 2015)

SECTION B: ISSUES TO DO WITH FAMILY, MARRIAGE & PARENTING

Reading 10: Family members should not have to bear burden of looking after dementia patients alone

EU 1-4 & 6

CNA | 1 February 2023

This reading will help you understand:

- The evolving social measures with regard to the care for the elderly in Singapore
- The pressures faced by families and government as demographics and needs change over time

Initiatives to make Singapore more dementia-friendly have been announced in recent weeks. Under the 2023 Action Plan for Successful Ageing unveiled on Monday (Jan 30), the Ministry of Health (MOH) is increasing the number of community outreach teams that can identify seniors at risk of dementia and link caregivers with resources.

- 5 Yio Chu Kang is poised to be the first dementia-friendly constituency, incorporating features such as colourful murals to serve as location markers for seniors with the condition, and personal alert buttons that allow residents to get assistance in an emergency.

- 10 These are important developments for Singapore's rapidly ageing population - around one in 10 people aged 60 and above suffers from dementia. The provision of infrastructure and services for dementia patients is welcome relief for their families.

But unlike infrastructural adequacy that can be achieved through centrally planned resource management, meeting the caregiving needs of dementia patients is not as straightforward. It requires us to involve not just individual families, but all of society in deliberating on the best care for an expected rise in the number of people with dementia here.

- 15 In researching policies that can support ageing in Singapore, the Lee Kuan Yew School of Public Policy conducted discussions with 72 people of different ages and socio-economic backgrounds. This issue of caregiving especially in relation to seniors with dementia emerged as a critical concern.

The participants' views can be summarised in three points but all allude to one answer - if we do it together, we can be stronger emotionally, physically and fiscally.

The indeterminate burden of caregiving

- 20 First, caregiving is not just physical work, but also emotional work. There are no clear-cut solutions to manage the intangible well-being of individual caregivers even as they think foremost about the welfare

- 25 Participants recounted episodes of frustration and stress due to the seemingly endless tasks they had to complete on behalf of their relative - the number of trips to healthcare facilities, therapy and so on. They shared the torturous dilemma of choosing between the sense of love and responsibility for their seniors, and their anxiety about securing their future retirement if they were to drop out of full-time employment to give that care.

The Home Caregiving Grant from the Government of S\$200 per month, while welcome, does not make weighty decisions easier.

- 30 Though passing off the caregiving burden to hired help may seem like a simple and fuss-free option, participants said that the low standard of care and professionalism available currently means that family members must be on hand to provide supervision.

Second, a good way forward is to re-imagine the responsibility of caregiving as a shared one across the community, tapping on not more dollars and cents but social capital.

35 If family members are not so consumed with thinking that caregiving responsibilities fall solely on them and embrace the role that the community and professionals can play, the task of managing seniors with dementia might feel less daunting.

Our cultural challenges are two-fold: While care facilities are available even if still under-supplied, families grapple with the notion that it is where seniors are “dumped”. And as Asians, we tend to think
40 it is an imposition to have “outsiders” help us with issues that are related to our family.

How can we shift this narrative so that tapping social resources is not seen as a bad thing?

Professional care in such facilities is available but not much is spoken of these centres’ tangible benefits. They serve as places where the elderly can engage one another and share stories of their past, and they pool a community’s resources in caring for people with dementia.

45 To improve the overall quality of care in Singapore, one participant suggested including a basic module on gerontology in all social studies or tertiary institutions’ general curriculum. The course can equip individuals with basic caregiving skills and raise awareness of policy issues on ageing.

Inter-generational interaction, especially in the early stages of cognitive decline, can turn things around for dementia patients too. For instance, there are volunteering programmes where pre-school
50 and primary school students engage seniors in reading and gardening at dementia daycare centres.

Greater public engagement in eldercare centres not only divides the caregiving burden more effectively, but diversifies the support available to seniors beyond the professional care of institutionalised facilities.

Managing the fiscal implications

Third, participants recognised that we all need to prepare ourselves for the fiscal implications of being
55 an ageing society. Again, the load is lighter if we can share it.

From the perspective of public finances, managing the challenge of ageing is part of the Government’s rationale for a 2 per cent increase in the Goods and Service Tax (GST) introduced between 2023 and 2024. This has been portrayed as a highly unpopular move.

However, when the participants of our study were taken through all the public policy and real-life
60 considerations about being an ageing society, it was a surprise to find that more were willing to contemplate saving and contributing more to take on this burden.

Our post-discussion survey indicated that 13 more of our participants were prepared to draw more resources from savings and their family to age well compared to before our discussions began. Also, 11 more of them indicated they were prepared to have the Government generate needed resources
65 through the GST.

Six more participants indicated that those resources should be drawn from the national reserves. We expected this to be higher as it would seem to be the quick-fix to public finances.

We learnt that the younger participants want to know that their support today means that they too will be supported tomorrow as their future seemed more uncertain. Reciprocity is a fundamental
70 tenet of any social compact.

Anticipating the challenges arising from an ageing population and shouldering the costs are critical questions we must address. There will be far more comfort, from households to country, if we know that we can manage them because we can pool our resources to do it together. Significantly, 26 more participants indicated confidence in ageing well in Singapore at the end of our discussions. The government’s refreshed Action Plan provides us with the structure by which to make this a good place
75 to grow old in.

For discussion/reflection:

1. What does this article say about key challenges facing an ageing society today?
2. The article lists several key parties in caring for the weak and vulnerable in society. Is it possible for all to shoulder responsibility equally? Why or why not?
3. How do Singapore's policies to help those suffering from dementia and their families [compare to more progressive ones, such as those found in European countries](#) [video link]? What can Singapore learn from these countries?
4. What are your views on using tax increases to fund services for the elderly in Singapore? What concerns could arise?

Class activity:

- **Pre-lesson preparation:** Divide class into the "expert groups" below to do research on how their assigned group assists the elderly and the challenges they may face:
 - a. *Family*
 - b. *Public sector (e.g. Silver Support Scheme)*
 - c. *VWOs (e.g. Touch Community Services)*
 - d. *Charities (e.g. Dementia Singapore; St Luke's Elder Care)*
 - e. *Community work groups & grassroots (e.g. People's Association; Fei Yu Community Services)*
- **In-class discussion:** Create discussion groups comprising a member from each expert group. The students will share their research. The discussion group will see how their assistance/challenge overlaps and how they can advantage or disadvantage the patient.

Related RI essay questions:

1. How desirable is it for a country to provide free healthcare for all its citizens? (Cambridge 2024)
2. When a government's finances for social welfare are limited, should they be directed towards the young or old? (Cambridge 2015)
3. Should the responsibility of taking care of the elderly fall solely on the government? (RI Y6 CT1 2019)

SECTION C: ISSUES TO DO WITH SOCIAL MOBILITY & INEQUALITY

Reading 11: Rethink governance and institutions to tackle poverty and inequality

EU 2, 5 & 6

*Adapted from To tackle inequality, stop expecting the same rules to make a difference | Sophie Chew
| Rice Media | 17 October 2020*

This reading will help you to understand:

- The moral and political imperative society has in addressing poverty and reducing it to very low levels
- The growing awareness concerning the link between poverty and inequality, as well as the situation of poverty across different domains like education, healthcare, the justice system, and the climate crisis
- The harmfulness of state-sanctioned discourse as well as people's underlying perceptions that deny the hardships associated with being impoverished
- That for there to be real change, the principles by which decisions are made and policies formed concerning poverty need to fundamentally transform
- The justifications for why we should redefine need in the context of poverty to something more expansive
- How the average individual can help tackle poverty by exercising their civic and social responsibilities, by communicating their concerns about poverty to political leaders

We sat down for an interview with Assoc Prof Teo You Yenn, author of This Is What Inequality Looks Like, and Dr. Ng Kok Hoe, who led Singapore's first homelessness survey last year, about poverty and inequality in Singapore today.

This interview is being held to mark the IDEP, or International Day for the Eradication of Poverty. How achievable is this? Is poverty inevitable in Singapore, or is it a failure of imagination to think so?

5 Kok Hoe: We only have to look to the evidence, which is that there is significant variance in levels of poverty and inequality across countries. It's clear that you can do something about it. You can push it to very low levels—or, if you don't do the right things, let it get out of hand.

10 You Yenn: I think if poverty was not seen as inevitable in 1960s Singapore, with all our plans and dreams of development, certainly we should not see it as inevitable today. And if we think of IDEP as an international goal, shared by humanity in all its different contexts, we are in a very good position to make more headway on this as a small and wealthy country. Neither extreme wealth nor extreme poverty are natural phenomena. We know from looking at trends around the world that much of it has to do with laws and policies. Poverty and inequality come about through specific decisions about our societies: what we reward and what we punish, who gets to make decisions on behalf of the collective, and so on.

Traditionally, poverty and inequality have been seen as 'unspeakable', 'invisible' topics, but I do think there's been a shift. These issues have stayed in the spotlight for the last few years. What changes have you observed in public discourse since This Is What Inequality Looks Like was published, or the homelessness survey findings were released?

15 YY: I'm not sure I'm the most objective person to comment on this, because I've been immersed in this for the last few years! But I think there have been two interesting and promising shifts. The first is that when poverty is invoked, so is inequality; they are mentioned in the same breath. I think this

20 signals a growing consciousness that there is something relational about poverty and wealth, that poverty is not ghettoised as ‘poor people problems’, and it has something to do with the way wealth is distributed across our society. I also see shifts—particularly this year, with Covid and the GE—that poverty and inequality are being invoked in different domains. In education and healthcare, certainly, but also in discussions of migrant workers, the justice system, and the climate crisis. There is a growing recognition that you have to see these seemingly different domains as interconnected.

25 KH: Feedback comes to us in very interesting ways, sometimes from people whom you wouldn’t consider traditional consumers of academic research. Our research has come up in conversations with neighbours in the lift, with taxi drivers, students, even banks have written to us because they see applications for our research in their actuarial services. I do think there is a growing community of people who are concerned about poverty and inequality, and this is precious progress. But there’s still a long way to go.

So what has not changed? Which sacred cows have you found most resistant to being slayed, and why are these so troubling?

30 KH: Public discourse and narratives exist at different levels. State-sanctioned discourse, in particular, is often the last to shift decisively. But what’s also hard to shift is people’s underlying explanations for why the problem exists. I also learnt how damaging the denial of people’s hardships can be, particularly when those people begin to internalise narratives about themselves. Then, there’s a different kind of danger when policymakers begin to believe their own narratives. In my research, one of the beliefs which has been most resistant to change is this: that you deserve the housing you can afford. It feels so natural that you don’t even question it, let alone consider the possibility of an alternative. Dominant narratives are complete packages. They don’t just contain a problem statement, but a proposed solution. If people do not own flats, the explanation is probably that you haven’t been wise with money or worked as hard as you should have, so the solution is therefore to be better with money and work harder. These narratives are damaging and divisive. They tear at the fabric of society by rejecting collective responsibility in favour of individual rehabilitation.

Back in March, you jointly wrote a piece for AcademiaSG saying that now is the time to go big with structural changes to tackle poverty and inequality. I wanted to ask how you think things have played out since—say, in the Covid budgets, or in some of the proposals and speeches from the GE and the new Parliament.

KH: I think we need to observe some more, I would say there are few signs that we are drawing the right lessons from this crisis. So far, most of the significant schemes have been time-limited. We’ve seen a huge emphasis on skills and training, and a strong reluctance to move on wages. And in terms of financial assistance, conditionality has made a swift return even though the economy is still completely out of shape. All these signal reliance on familiar strategies, business as usual.

45 YY: I would agree. There are no real signs that the fundamental principles are being rethought. I think the general approach to try to protect jobs is sensible, but broader social protections have to be on the table. And the outright dismissal of minimum wage as a possibility, when eight years after its introduction, the Progressive Wage Model still only covers three sectors making up only about 15% of low wage workers, that’s something I don’t understand. This crisis has prompted us—not just in Singapore, but globally—to think about what it means to have flourishing lives. Reconsidering this cannot be the job of a small group of elites.

It’s ironic that Covid has caused us to rethink so many things we’ve taken for granted—physical contact, offices, essential work— but not others. This is supposed to be a once-in-a-lifetime

pandemic, and yet we only seem content to make tweaks within the margins of what we already know. What would it take to move the needle on poverty and inequality?

50 KH: We have to look at whether the rules for making rules are changing. If the same type of people are making decisions, according to the same metrics of what is desirable, using the same priorities, with the same ideology and entrenched mindsets, how can we expect the outcome to be different?

YY: The rules by which we make the rules—that gets to the heart of it. Evaluating policy cannot be restricted to a narrow ideological or technocratic approach, nor to a narrow elite.

So there are changes to processes, and you’ve also given practical suggestions in terms of policies which should be considered, like better wage protections and delivery of public goods like care services. What needs to change in terms of principles?

KH: At a fundamental level, I would say two things. The first is a greater focus on primary policy goals rather than secondary criteria. Social assistance, like Comcare, is a good example of this. Its primary goal is to help people meet basic needs and achieve a certain standard of living. Then there are the secondary criteria, like fiscal prudence and efficiency. Both these things are important, but the system has become extremely skewed towards secondary criteria, sometimes even at the expense of the primary goal. There is so much talk about gatekeeping that one could be forgiven for thinking that the goal of Comcare is to gatekeep itself. You often hear about the possibility of benefit fraud and so on—without evidence, I should point out—but I have never heard any clear discussion of what changes we would like to see in people’s lives, or what standard of living it’s meant to lift people up to. We hear almost nothing about this, but a lot about costs. This is the other thing: we should be more transparent about social costs. We tend to be very mindful of fiscal costs, but if the system doesn’t work as it should, people end up sacrificing basic needs like food and shelter. We’ve heard so many accounts of people experiencing food insecurity recently. In Singapore! In 2020! The social sustainability of welfare systems—cohesion, mobility, equality—is as important as fiscal sustainability.

YY: We also ought to have some clearer benchmarks as to what the targeted outcomes are. Having standards is critical to evaluating whether something is working or not.

This brings me to your Minimum Income Standards research, which adopts an expansive definition of ‘minimum’: not just getting by at a subsistence level, but including access to opportunities and options, and the security, dignity, and independence these bring. The latter might be thought of as what we need to thrive, not merely survive. Why is it important to reframe ‘need’ in this way?

55 YY: Our focus group participants consisted of people across socioeconomic lines. The definition is reflective of a broad consensus across members of society. It’s not low-income people’s wish lists or high-income people’s sense of entitlement. It is what ordinary people believe is reasonable for everyone in Singapore today: just being alive is not a life.

60 KH: Undergirding the MIS research is an understanding of deprivation and well-being as specific to a time and place, as well as relative to what others in that context have. Participants kept saying: this is Singapore in 2018, not the 1960s or 1980s. To expect us to live without X is not acceptable. That is how everyone in Singapore lives today.

65 YY: It’s true that you see some diversity in people’s preferences. What might matter to someone might not matter to me and vice versa. I don’t think we have much of a book budget, for example. And if I didn’t have books, I don’t think I could live. But the underlying needs, which made the definition, are so profoundly universal. You might not be able to reduce the need for respect to a number, but what

we are trying to show is that there are certain monetary preconditions which allow for participation and belonging and respect. Money cannot directly buy these things, but money is absolutely a precondition to achieving those needs.

70 KH: This is why standards are important, because until you accept that there are basic levels below which people's lives will be affected, how can we begin to think about the generosity of social welfare schemes? How can we say that we are interested in helping people meet their needs if we are reluctant to define those needs?

75 **Many people are deeply concerned about poverty and inequality, but don't see what they as individuals can do to change things. What can the average RICE reader—as an ordinary member of society who is not an activist, social worker, or policymaker—do in their own sphere?**

YY: We've been asked some version of this question many times, and I think there's a way to read that pessimistically and optimistically. The pessimistic version is that it makes me wonder what it says about us: about our fear of collective action; of action that could be seen as political; and perhaps
80 about our sense of disempowerment and alienation from civic engagement, such that there is a presumption built into the question that people cannot act collectively, and all we can do is to make choices as individuals. I think this is a mistake. It is REALLY important that we don't have illusions about what our individual choices, particularly consumer choices, can do to change inequality. Individual choices, made in isolation, cannot change rules and systems.

85 **I think we tend to look to individual choices, because—ironically—having identified the issues as structural tends to make people feel powerless. To that end, isn't there something to be said about how our own choices might perpetuate inequality? For example, the eternal question of whether to send your kids for tuition?**

90 YY: Maybe it's not helpful to think about it as exercising power, and better to think about it as exercising our civic rights and obligations. At the individual level, if we need to feel powerful to act, no one will. A lot of times, we do feel powerless! But if you feel it is your right and your obligation, perhaps that's a lower bar for motivating action.

95 KH: We will not get rid of poverty and inequality by telling people who are anxious about falling behind, or have a mind to get ahead through personal advantage, not to do so. Tackling inequality must involve closing loopholes and taking away incentives for people to act a certain way. So for example, instead of fixating on tuition, why not look at the school admissions system, and see if it gives certain sections of society unfair advantages?

So we should direct our attention at the correct places, at the correct levers of power.

100 KH: The major barriers to tackling poverty and inequality, and the major levers which control them, have to do with governance and institutions. We must block unfair advantage and make sure we don't suppress people who are already disadvantaged while trying to help them. So in terms of what the individual can do, it's to tell policymakers to do these things. Sometimes people say Singaporeans complain a lot. Well, I think Singaporeans don't complain enough! Exercise your right as a citizen. Go see your MP. You're their constituent, they're supposed to represent you in Parliament. So if you're
105 concerned about inequality, go tell your MP and ask them to do something about it.

YY: "Complain more" is great shorthand, but I would like to reframe it a bit. There is a serious message here, which is: citizenship is a duty and a right. So, complain more, yes, but don't let your complaints

be limited to those things that are in your narrow self-interests. Direct complaints to the right people. And partake in community—from time to time, complain collectively!

This feels challenging, given that a lot of what we might think of as collective action—unions, mass demonstrations—are not avenues we have access to.

- 110 That's certainly true, but demonstrations are only the tip of the iceberg even in the places where they exist. I think when the average person hears 'social movements' we think of demonstrations because that's what we see in the news, but it's only a part of collective action. Attending one talk is not going to change anyone's life, and you might not see a line from showing up at a meeting to getting a politician to act on something. But many small encounters, building trust, can build up to more
- 115 significant collective action. Speaking up and working on an issue together can, in turn, put pressure on people who can make decisions and set the agenda. Showing up is important. Engaging is important. Building community is important.

In the afterword to the 2nd edition of *This Is What Inequality Looks Like*, You Yenn suggested that we are experiencing a moment, not yet a movement, where poverty and inequality are concerned. This was in 2019. First, could you elaborate on the difference between the two? Second, where do you think we are now? And third, where do we go from here?

- YY: I think it's far too soon to say where we're at, but also, the journey of how we arrive at the goal of greater equality is supremely important. No single individual or group should have a monopoly on
- 120 deciding what an ideal society should look like. I don't really know how to answer 'where do we go from here', because I don't look at it in terms of a next target. I don't think of democracy and justice as just end goals, but processes. You have to keep building, and contribute to this thing that is larger than the individual. In that process, you build human connections and ideas and ethics that are the basis of solidarity. That's what I mean by a movement.
- 125 KH: It does feel like there is a lot to do. Just gathering evidence and making sense of the world is hard. Then there is evaluating, critiquing, and finally, articulating an alternative. This last part—articulating an alternative—is something that I hope, in the coming years, we can do together.

For discussion/reflection:

1. Teo Yu Yenn spoke about a key shift in terms of how people understand poverty being the recognition that 'seemingly different domains' are in fact 'interconnected' (line 49) when it comes to perpetuating poverty. Identify any two or more domains (such as education and healthcare) and offer some explanation of how these might reinforce each other to worsen poverty.
2. According to both speakers, what are the official narratives often used by the government to define how inequality/poverty can be defined and resolved?
3. What are their criticisms of these official narratives?
4. Summarise the key changes that the speakers pinpointed as being necessary before poverty can be properly tackled as a problem.

Related Cambridge/RI essay questions:

1. To what extent should income equality be a goal in your society? (Cambridge 2019)
2. How far is increased prosperity for all a realistic goal in your society? (Cambridge 2013)
3. To what extent are people in your society treated equally? (RI Y5 TP 2024)
4. Discuss the view that ending poverty is desirable but unachievable. (RI Y6 CT 2021)
5. To what extent is poverty the fault of the individual? (RI Y6 Prelim 2019)
6. Is it always the responsibility of the state to help the poor? (RI Y5 Promo 2011)

SECTION C: ISSUES TO DO WITH SOCIAL MOBILITY & INEQUALITY

Reading 12: Inequality and social good: A new culture of shared wellbeing requires reforming a system that promotes individualism

EU 3-6

Teo You Yenn | Academic.SG | 22 Oct 2022

This reading will help you understand:

- What people need to lead meaningful and flourishing lives
- What social conditions enable people to pursue the lives they would like to lead
- How the aforementioned social conditions vary along class and gender lines

First, what do people need to lead meaningful and flourishing lives? This question can seem subjective. Is it possible to answer it in a general or universal way? Philosophers, political theorists, economists, sociologists have tried.

5 When a team of collaborators and I conducted research on a Minimum Income Standard, we did not start with the language of “a meaningful and flourishing life.” Instead, we used the language of basic needs and basic standards of living. But, in our multiple focus group discussions with ordinary Singaporeans, people emphasised that life should not just be about staying alive, about survival. A “basic standard of living” needs to entail living a meaningful, good life. Thus, our understanding of meaningful and flourishing lives is not plucked from moral philosophy. It emerges from ground realities as expressed by the many ordinary Singaporeans who participated in our project. From these conversations, we crafted this definition:

15 A basic standard of living in Singapore is about, but more than just housing, food, and clothing. It is about having opportunities to education, employment and work-life balance, as well as access to healthcare. It enables a sense of belonging, respect, security, and independence. It also includes choices to participate in social activities, and the freedom to engage in one’s cultural and religious practices. People value both autonomy and interdependence — having individual choices and preferences, but also social respect and belonging. Moreover, as we learnt when we talked to people of different ages, different parts of this definition take on varying levels of importance at different points in the life course. A child of 5 years old; a student finishing up their ‘O’ levels; a single parent of a teenager; a married father with two young children; a retiree at age 70 — they have different priorities and different sources of income for meeting needs. In order for everyone to be able to meet needs and live meaningful, flourishing lives at all points in the life course, a great deal of attention must be given to social conditions that enable this possibility.

Social conditions

25 This brings me to my second question: what social conditions enable or disable people in pursuing the lives they would like to lead? There are many: food systems and their integrity, environmental protections and justice, laws or regulations safeguarding religious participation, political and civil liberties, and so on. Although we often think of the fulfillment of needs as individual quests, it is impossible to fulfill these needs without various kinds of enabling social infrastructure. Since this is where most of my research has focused, I will focus on just these conditions: wage work and care infrastructure. Incomes can come from many sources, and where they come from varies for different types of households and at different stages of our life course. But wage work is crucial, both as a means to an end, and as an end in itself. In a capitalist economy, it is the primary means for most people to

generate income to meet their needs. It is also, on its own terms, something that confers meaning and respect.

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When scholars talk about wage work, we refer to the availability of jobs, the level of wages, and work conditions — schedules, flexibility, security, leave provisions, bargaining power. When people are at the part of the life course when they participate in wage work, they are also responsible for a range of care needs — for children, older persons, or disabled family members. Therefore, the discussion of wage work can never be separated from that of care and care infrastructure. Care infrastructure refers to the constellation of things that allow for care and wage work to be pursued simultaneously: paid caregivers, institutions of care such as childcare centers, caregiver leave and the various laws, subsidies, or regulations that affect the prices of care services or the opportunity costs of leaving wage work to care. That I talk about wage work and care infrastructure does not mean I am primarily interested in the needs of people in the middle part of the life course, or only on dual-wage worker households. This is not just a “work-life balance” problem for working adults. The lives of everyone — the daily rhythms and schedules they live by, the possibilities for their present and future — are tangled up at this intersection of wage work and care.

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Even children are affected. What time they have for homework, tuition and enrichment activities, what kind of leisure they do or do not have, and how and with whom they spend their days — these are all dependent on the constellation created by their parents’ work conditions, the caregivers their parents rely on, and the time and money their parents have or do not have for paid activities. Thus, most people, regardless of age and role in a household, are entangled in the tensions between wage work and the responsibilities of care.

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Social conditions and inequality

The third question is how social conditions vary along class and gender lines. In recent decades, there has emerged globally an increasingly polarised job market, in which the quality of jobs has bifurcated. There is divergence of wages and benefits, schedules (and control over them), stability and predictability, bargaining power, provisions for time off, autonomy, respect afforded to workers. Job quality and employment relations are poor for those with lower levels of educational attainment. Work is precarious and uncertain for people with fewer credentials. Care gaps are also more pronounced for workers with less leverage in the labor market and fewer resources to outsource care labor. On the other hand, those with certain credentials, skills, and cultural and social capital have benefited greatly since compensation for some types of jobs have grown significantly. Additionally, the market for providing care services has expanded for those with the ability to pay.

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Gender also matters: women play larger roles as caregivers and face greater challenges to reconcile wage work and care responsibilities; men play smaller roles in housework and giving care and continue to have larger roles as breadwinners. Women are far more likely than men to adjust their relationships to wage work to carry out care responsibilities, resulting in wage differentials as well as different labor force participation patterns. These are not merely outcomes of some static “traditional culture,” but instead result from the ways in which public policy, by enabling or incentivizing certain gendered parental roles and practices and not others, contributes to the thickening and persistence of inequalities.

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“Money isn’t everything. Money can’t buy happiness. Money cannot buy respect. Dignity is more important than money.” These are tropes often repeated. And they are wrong. It may be true that money cannot directly buy any of those things, but money is a precondition for them. Money can buy

80 a HDB flat so a person can live as a typical Singaporean does, where their children have their own bedrooms as they grow up. Money can buy the clothes that one needs to show up appropriately dressed at a wedding and then others that help one fit in at the office. Money can buy a birthday present so that a child can go to their friend's party and feel happy rather than embarrassed. Money can allow a retiree to donate money to their religious group, helping them feel they still contribute to society.

85 Wage conditions and care infrastructure shape people's access to money. Since social conditions of wages and care vary along class and gender lines, the capacity to earn and accumulate money to meet short and long-term needs, is also variant. This variation is something we should care about because it indicates that the right to live meaningful and flourishing lives — not a controversial right to get behind — is not equally accessible.

90 What do people need to lead meaningful and flourishing lives? The question of social good needs to be posed in this way, placing ordinary people — not experts, or politicians, or ideologues and pundits — in the middle, as protagonists. Certain needs can meaningfully be considered universal in a given society and moment. It is useful, in broad terms that allow for variations, to conceptualise needs this way. It provides a starting point for deliberating how to ensure that everyone can lead meaningful and
95 flourishing lives. To aspire to better, we have to look closely at the present. Whose needs are well beyond met, whose needs are just met, and whose needs are not met at all? Why do these variations exist?

Through various research projects over the years, I have found that people of different class backgrounds have to devise different strategies matching the different conditions they face in the
100 nitty-gritty of everyday life—working, housework, caring for kids, helping them with homework, supporting ageing parents, upskilling and retraining, leisure.

A university-educated professional man has decent odds of navigating life's needs step by step: from courtship to marriage and housing; to career progression and salary increments that go into meeting children's growing needs and demands, while saving, investing, and insuring for old age or poor health.
105 Access to money and time — providing some amount of slack and some degree of flexibility — allows for the pursuit of leisure and family life, and some freedom to pursue individual interests. His counterpart with fewer educational credentials and in low-wage work is less likely to encounter life as a progressive path, and less likely to be able to meet the ideals required and rewarded by employers or public policy — credentials, employment patterns, or particular modes of 'doing family.' [1] With
110 each set of needs, whether housing or children's education or leisure, there is less to spend. Needs are met to a poorer degree (in both quantity and quality).

When we compared household budgets required to meet basic standards of living to actual incomes from work, we found that people's capacity for meeting basic standards of living were highly variant depending on occupation, education level, and type of work. Women and men are faced with different
115 options as they try to pursue meaningful lives. In a context where education has intensified as parental responsibility and become a key component of care labor, mothers and fathers feel compelled to take on different roles. Women, far more than men, reconfigure their own needs, fold down ambitions, step back from wage work and thereby reduce their lifetime earnings and future security, in service of children's educational needs.

120 Variations per se are not a problem and indeed are to be embraced in a diverse society, but we are not talking merely about difference in a horizontal way, but about hierarchy, about inequality in outcomes, the uneven meeting of what people need to lead meaningful and flourishing lives.

At stake

As we go about pursuing needs, we encounter many agents and institutions: markets, schools, employers, hospitals, banks, and various state agencies, including their regulations or human
125 representatives. Through these encounters, we learn about how our society defines who belongs and who does not, who deserves and who does not, what one should do to try to deserve, and what one cannot possibly change if one is not deserving. We learn about individual responsibility, about how no one owes us a living, about the massive spoils that go to winners as well as the cracks losers may fall through. We learn, in other words, how the game is played. We get a strong sense that the game is
130 primarily an individual hustle. Actions have to be oriented toward one's own family and one's own children. There is very little space in this daily hustle for doings, beings that are oriented toward shared wellbeing and long-term societal good.

There is thus a key tension I've noticed while interviewing people across the years: they have a strong sense of society yet also retreat into the individual cocoon of the family. They are conscious of what's
135 needed for social wellbeing, but feel they must maximise their own familial interests. The tension exists, I think, because the turn toward greater neoliberal, market fundamentalist orientations in recent decades has not totally extinguished an older, nation-building and developmentalist orientation. This tension between the social and the individual, between the greater good and self-interest, between social wellbeing and individual gains, exists in every society. Given political
140 polarization and the large-scale, collective action challenges posed by problems such as the climate crisis, a key challenge all societies face is how to develop a political culture that gives the social due salience.

How people meet their needs has an impact on that political culture. The economic, social, political, legal, regulatory and bureaucratic conditions that people encounter shape their perceptions of the
145 game they and their fellow citizens have to play. As people negotiate these conditions, certain commonsense beliefs and practices form. That is the material that makes up our social and political culture.

At present, that material builds individualistic rather than solidaristic orientations. As Singaporeans navigate the system to try to meet their needs, they focus on questions like how to plan my life so
150 that I can secure housing; how to help my child so they can keep up in school; how to upgrade my skills so I can stay relevant; what insurance I need to buy in case I fall ill and cannot work; how to save enough money for my own retirement.

There are macro political economic ways to think about this private/societal tension. The problems to be addressed in the world today include: extreme income and wealth inequality; the resulting
155 disproportionate power of the wealthy and unelected to influence political decisions and the intensification of political marginalization and precarious lives of the middle class and poor; environmental devastation, including again inequality shaping both its causes and impacts.

After decades of neoliberalist reform and market fundamentalism, the institutions that currently exist to solve these problems — states, global governance institutions, banks, corporations, universities and
160 think tanks, civil society — are organised in ways that make it hard to resolve the problems. Powerful and narrow interests prevent a shift of orientation toward ordinary people's interests and broad social

good. Tackling these problems requires radical changes to existing institutional arrangements. We can think of what's needed in terms of stasis versus dynamism: a system that does not reconsider and revamp its fundamental assumptions and principles in light of changing material realities, versus a system that can.

An analogue exists when we refocus on the case of Singapore and on ordinary people trying to meet needs. People have universal needs but face uneven conditions when they try to meet them. These inequalities are not problems of marginal outliers, nor problems we can ghettoise as problems of a small minority. They cannot be fixed by plugging gaps. Certain things have changed in recent decades that affect the distribution of things and the meeting of needs: the constitution of households and family; the educational level of workers and the constitution of firms; the ethno-national make-up of the country; the sheer scale of movement of wealth, and not just capital, into the city.

To wonder about the risk of stasis versus the possibilities for dynamism is to ask about the institutional arrangements that exist to tackle the challenges that arise with these changes. Several other questions logically follow. What is the economy for and whose interests should it serve? What are the presumptions about the causes of inequality that undergird current policies and institutional practices? Whose perspectives are represented and whose are left out in decision-making processes? What types of solutions have become entrenched and continue to be pursued even as they no longer serve? What barriers exist that suppress the expression of ideas and positions that depart from orthodoxy? What avenues exist for bringing about institutional reform and leadership renewal?

Since this forum is in support of 'Forward SG,' and given what the 4th generation PAP leadership has said about the need to forge a new social compact for a challenging new world, I hope they are willing to place these questions on the agenda. In varying forms, these are the questions Singaporeans are already asking and worrying about. As we confront that tension between individual and social, between self-interest and solidarity, I think it is possible to temper the former and strengthen the latter, but not without departing from business as usual. A strong state with capacity and moral vision, in tandem with a robust society built on solidarity, are crucial for the wellbeing of a country and the people living in it. For such a polity to exist, considerations of institutional underpinnings, including considerations of power and representation, are critical.

For discussion/reflection:

1. Teo argues that we need to go beyond 'the language of basic needs and basic standards of living' (lines 5-6) in understanding how people may live 'meaningful and flourishing lives' (line 9). What is the contrast between helping meet people's basic needs and helping them live flourishing lives? What other areas of need or fulfilment did she use to develop her point further? Do you consider these other areas to be entitlements that all Singaporeans should possess, or are they more like privileges, which are good to have, but not essential? Why?
2. Teo focuses on 'wage work' (line 29) and 'care infrastructure' (lines 29-30) as two key 'social conditions [that] enable or disable people in pursuing the lives they would like to lead' (lines 24-25). What are some obstacles that might prevent us from improving these conditions? To what extent is the overcoming of such obstacles a matter of individual responsibility rather than society's collective responsibility, or vice versa?
3. With reference to lines 56 to 72, summarise the ways in which 'social conditions vary along class and gender lines' (line 56). In your opinion, how fair is it that some social groups must contend with far more challenging social conditions compared to others? Should it be left to such social groups to catch up to the rest of society as much as they can, or should we attempt to 'level up the playing field'? List justifications for each and weigh them against each other. Which position is more justified or fairer to you?

4. Why does Teo argue that ‘the right to live meaningful and flourishing lives’ (line 88) is ‘not equally accessible’ (line 89)? What justifications can you think of for why Singapore should endeavour to make this right as equally accessible as possible? Consider both moral and practical reasons in your answer.
5. Teo asserts that there are two kinds of ‘variations’ (line 96) in terms of different social groups ‘devis[ing] different strategies’ to cope with the ‘different conditions they face’ (line 99) – those that are ‘horizontal’ and those that are ‘about hierarchy’ (line 121). What is the distinction between them, and why does Teo suggest that variations due to hierarchy are unacceptable?
6. What compromises or drawbacks may ‘agents and institutions’ (lines 123) have to face if they wanted to move away from individualism and focus on more collective good?
7. Teo argues that the ‘economic, social, political, legal, regulatory and bureaucratic conditions that people encounter shape their perceptions’ (lines 143-144) such that there is a personal stance that is ‘individualistic’ rather than ‘solidaristic’ (line 148). Provide examples of how prevailing conditions may have emphasised the individual over the collective based on any three out of the five areas listed by Teo.
8. Teo uses the term ‘stasis versus dynamism’ (line 163) in her analysis. Consider the characteristics and conditions that make Singapore what it is today. Which is more preferable, and why?
9. In your opinion, how can Singapore prompt a shift from viewing the attainment of a flourishing life as a personal responsibility, to one of collective responsibility?

Related Cambridge/RI essay questions:

1. In your society, how far is equality for all a reality? (Cambridge 2012)
2. ‘The family no longer plays an influential role in raising teenagers.’ How true is this of your society? (RI Y6 CT 2023)
3. To what extent are different genders valued equally in today’s society? (RI Y5 CT 2023)
4. ‘When a government’s finances for social welfare are limited, the poor should be given the highest priority.’ What is your view? (RI Y5 Promo 2020)
5. ‘Women have never had it better.’ How true is this? (RI Y6 Prelim 2018)

SECTION C: ISSUES TO DO WITH SOCIAL MOBILITY & INEQUALITY

Reading 13: Soul searching required to solve Singapore's foreign workers problem **EU 2, 3, 5 & 6**

Adapted from Solving Singapore's foreign workers problem requires serious soul searching, from top to bottom | Ng Jun Sen & Justin Ong | Today Online | 11 May 2020

This reading will help you understand:

- The economic and ethical tensions inherent in the reliance of migrant workers to fill low-wage jobs
- The moral justifications for committing to an overhaul of the status quo with regard to Singapore's foreign workers situation
- The different roles and responsibilities of different stakeholders, including the government
- The multitude of challenges and obstacles to be overcome before there can be positive change
- The discriminatory attitudes the majority of Singaporeans hold towards migrant/foreign workers

Mr Syedur Rahman Liton, 34, pines for his wife back home in Dhaka, Bangladesh, as he tries to put on a brave front about possibly contracting COVID-19. For the past month or so, the lifting supervisor has been isolating himself along with 100 other company workers at a factory-converted dormitory in Senoko Loop, part of a precautionary move to socially distance migrant workers living in similar accommodation from the community at large to prevent the further spread of the novel coronavirus.

It is a sacrifice that these foreign workers are making for the rest of Singapore society, experts say. As a result, the country owes migrant workers a debt of gratitude, and possibly, a concrete commitment to change when the pandemic is over. For the 400,000 migrant workers living in Singapore, their future could remain shrouded in uncertainty for some time. Their livelihoods here will hang in the balance even after COVID-19 has been eradicated in the Republic, experts said.

Amid the crushing impact of the circuit breaker measures and the drastic blow to the construction industry, will Mr Liton's employer survive the economic drought that has already started? While Mr Liton ponders over the future, his host country - Singapore - will also have to reassess its whole relationship with migrant workers like him, especially its "addiction" to cheap migrant labour, and examine whether the lessons learnt from the explosion of COVID-19 cases in the workers' dormitories could be used to implement meaningful changes.

THE STATUS QUO

There are about 200,000 migrant workers housed in 43 purpose-built dormitories around Singapore. These are licensed dormitories housing more than 1,000 workers each and are required to comply with the requirements under the Foreign Employee Dormitory Act (FEDA), such as providing facilities that include sick bays and isolation rooms.

Despite this, around 20 of the purpose-built dormitories - nearly half - flout the FEDA licensing requirement on average each year, Manpower Minister Josephine Teo revealed in Parliament on Monday (May 4). Operators face fines of up to S\$50,000 and up to a year in jail for Feda offences.

Another 95,000 workers are housed in the 1,200 factory-converted dormitories; 20,000 in construction temporary quarters; and 85,000 work permit and S Pass holders in the construction sector housed in Housing and Development Board (HDB) flats, private residential premises and others. These are not covered under the FEDA due to their smaller size, though they have to comply with other regulations such as the building and fire safety codes. By law, the Urban Redevelopment Authority (URA) prescribes a minimum of 4.5 sq m per dorm resident for living space, which includes the sleeping quarters, kitchen, dining and toilet areas.

While the purpose-built dormitories have met the needs of the workers during “normal times”, dorm operators said these large facilities were not built nor regulated to cater for a pandemic of such a scale. A spokesperson from Mini Environment Service (MES), which oversees operations at Jurong Penjuru Dorm 1, Jurong Penjuru Dorm 2, Blue Stars Dorm and The Leo, added that a dormitory “by nature is dense”. “The
35 older specifications and designs of a dormitory were based on a functional approach and pandemic management was not a consideration in the design and use,” the spokesperson added.

FUTURE HOPES FOR DORMS

The operators hope that the next couple of years will bring improvements to the conditions and living standards within the dormitories. “A review of standards for dormitory operations can only be good for the foreign worker community as it will help to raise quality levels across the industry,” said Mr Kong.

40 Agreeing, the MES spokesperson said that the ability to “tear down” the dormitories with older specifications and update them will “benefit all stakeholders”. The issues which the operators would like to address include the long-standing conundrum of safe distancing. “If we are to prepare for future pandemic situations, the density of the dorm population needs to be addressed and employers need to set aside higher budgets for rentals, for instance,” said Mr Cheah of S11 Dormitories.

MORE SPACE WILL COME AT A COST

45 While migrant workers are covered by Singapore’s main labour law, the Employment Act, employers of migrant workers also generally assume a greater responsibility for their welfare, including food accommodation and healthcare, than if they had hired a local resident to do the same job.

But while employers in the construction sector agree that changes to how migrant workers are housed are needed, several said the influence they have on their workers’ living conditions is limited. It is largely not up
50 to the employers to dictate the density or the living conditions within the dormitories, but for the operators to decide and the authorities to regulate, they claimed.

Should new guidelines cause housing to be more costly, not all contractors may be able to stomach this, the employers said. “When the new guidelines come in... it will affect (employers’) cashflow.” At the end of the day, some employers think it boils down to who would be willing to shoulder and split the extra costs.

GOVERNMENT: ROLE AS REGULATOR

55 As the authorities hunker down to mitigate the viral spread, the Government is also looking into new housing arrangements for migrant workers who have recovered from COVID-19 through a pipeline of short, medium and long-term plans, said National Development Minister Lawrence Wong. While details of these plans are not yet known, several suggestions have been raised, most notably, to increase the minimum standard for living space specified in FEDA.

60 After all, it is too much to expect private operators and employers to do so on their own, said Mr Alex Au, vice-president of migrant worker rights group Transient Workers Count Too (TWC2). “Employers and dorm operators have to watch their bottom lines. They are not welfare services. If the legal standards are low - which we feel they are currently - they would be foolish as profit-making enterprises to over-provide and drive up their own costs.

65 “That’s what the Government is for - to ensure socially-conscious minimum standards, but to do so in an across-the-board way so that a level-playing field for all businesses is maintained,” he said. Mr Au called for a doubling of the living space per occupant to 9 square metres - equivalent to 10 workers living in a four-room HDB flat. Assoc Prof Theseira, a Nominated Member of Parliament (NMP), said a proper study is needed to determine what construes a reasonable standard for living space. “If we come up with one set of
70 standards for living for Singaporeans in a similar situation, for example, a long-term hostel, dormitory, or

army camp residents, it would be quite unjust to apply a lower standard to migrant workers just because they are migrant workers,” he said.

TWEAKING SINGAPORE'S ECONOMIC MODEL

75 A more fundamental question would be whether Singapore should continue to rely heavily on low-cost migrant workers, said experts. In Singapore, past crises have historically led to a rethinking of the Republic's social compact - the combined series of unprecedented crises such as the 9/11 terrorist attacks in the United States in 2001, the SARS outbreak in 2003 and the global financial crisis of 2008 required national responses that “threw our planning out of gear” and necessitated the 2013 Population White Paper, said then Deputy Prime Minister Teo Chee Hean.

80 With Singapore now facing what has been touted as “a crisis of a generation”, some, like Assoc Prof Theseira and fellow NMP Anthea Ong, have called for a committee of inquiry into the foreign worker dormitory outbreak to work out the structural changes that Singapore sorely needs. One silver lining, from a policymaking perspective, is that the current worries about Singapore's overreliance on migrant workers are aligned with the Government's goal of raising the productivity of the resident workforce.

85 This dates back to 2012, when then Finance Minister Tharman Shanmugaratnam said the easy availability of foreign labour will reduce the incentives for companies to raise productivity. Since then, Singapore has taken steps to progressively reduce this reliance, such as tightening the foreign worker dependency ratio ceilings, said Dr Seah. “There is scope to reduce this reliance even further. By encouraging companies to rely less on foreign labour in their production processes, we can in fact nudge them to adopt smarter and less
90 costly methods of production,” he added.

Associate Professor Kenneth Paul Tan, from the Lee Kuan Yew School of Public Policy, said he hopes the review on dormitories, when it comes, will take in diverse voices from civil society in policy discussions. “And I hope, most of all, that we have deeper discussions with a view to minimising our dependency on low-waged migrant workers, investing in productivity-enhancing technology, redesigning essential jobs to
95 overcome unnecessary stigma, and designing more generous social safety nets for the many who will have difficulty integrating into a new and more resilient economic society.”

PEOPLE: SOCIETY'S APPETITE FOR CHANGE

IPS' Mr Gee said that this traditional mindset of relying on lower-skilled and low-wage labour has created a “category of residents who have limited rights as a non-permanent resident foreigner and are treated differently”. If Singapore decides that in a post-pandemic world, it needs to elevate their living standards to
100 a decent level that Singaporeans can accept for themselves, then another question will be what level would Singaporeans be comfortable with, said Mr Gee. “The same level as the lowest-paid Singaporean household? Or lesser? We have to negotiate and discuss this,” he said.

In this fundamental re-think of the role migrant workers play in Singapore's prosperity, TWC2's Mr Au urged the authorities to also look beyond living standards in dormitories, such as long-standing issues on the
105 recruitment fees that migrant workers bear and the non-payment of salaries.

Assoc Prof Theseira said: “Fundamentally, the current structure is low-cost, and as a result, generally Singaporeans benefit in the narrow sense that we pay lower prices for anything produced by foreign workers. Either our costs would go up, meaning more taxation, or standards would fall, meaning more potholes, uncleared fallen trees, et cetera, without so many low-cost workers. That means that we have collectively
110 contributed to current conditions for foreign workers, because we have found these low costs and high standards of service too compelling to raise too many questions about their treatment and the market structure,” he added.

SINGAPORE ATTITUDES TOWARDS MIGRANT WORKERS

So, are Singaporeans willing to pay for the higher costs that will inevitably arise from offering migrant workers a better deal? The jury is still out, based on past experience, according to the experts interviewed.
115 The empirical evidence suggests that the mindset of Singaporeans towards migrant workers has not changed, despite an outpouring of sympathy whenever a major incident occurred.

At the IPS webinar, MWC executive director Bernard Menon lamented that despite past events such as the SMRT bus driver strike in 2012 and the Little India riot the following year, the momentum arising from the online discourses on worker welfare would eventually peter out. “We have a lot of people coming up and
120 saying ‘you should improve this, you should improve that’,” said Mr Menon. But unfortunately, though you can obviously tell that there’s been a gradual increase over time of interest and concern ... this has lagged behind the expectations I’ve had during these crises.”

Most recently, in December last year, the International Labour Organization and the United Nations Entity for Gender Equality and the Empowerment of Women jointly published a detailed study into society
125 attitudes towards migrant labour in Japan, Singapore, Malaysia and Thailand. The study included both work permit holders working in the construction industry and foreign domestic workers as part of their report.

It found that overall support for migrant workers had decreased in the past nine years, when a similar study was conducted in 2010. “Knowledge regarding migrant workers across the four countries remains low, and discriminatory attitudes prevail with significant numbers of members of the public in migrant destination
130 countries stating that migrant workers should not enjoy equal working conditions with nationals,” the report stated.

The study found that 36 per cent of the 1,005 Singapore respondents believed migrant workers should not receive the same work conditions as local workers, or be entitled to join a union. Around 40 per cent said migrant workers who end up exploited only have themselves to blame, a majority - 60 per cent - disagree
135 that migrant workers should receive the same pay and benefits as nationals, and 53 per cent said migrant workers threaten the country’s culture and heritage. Nevertheless, a majority of the Singaporean respondents (58 per cent) recognised that migrant workers had a net positive effect on Singapore’s national economy.

A ROUND OF SOUL-SEARCHING

With the pandemic forcing Singapore - as a collective - to pay the price for years of apparent neglect, commentators said that after COVID-19 is eliminated, Singapore needs to openly embark on some serious
140 soul-searching. For a start, the society’s mindset and attitude towards migrant workers need to “undergo a sea change”, said Associate Professor Eugene Tan from the Singapore Management University.

“SG United must include migrant workers from the get-go ... We cannot, as a society, seek to harness the benefits of their being here and yet not prepare to bear the costs of their being in our midst. We cannot
145 continue to have the gains privatised but the costs socialised in our migrant worker policy,” the law don said.

Having spent more than a decade working in Singapore, Mr Liton is keenly aware of the value of social inclusion. Like his friends Asit and Zakir, Mr Liton is a poet, who often pens his thoughts about crises and conflicts around the world, and attends poetry events with Singaporeans such as those organised by Sing Lit
150 Station and local Bengali publication Bangla Kanthar. On Apr 17, he wrote in Bengali: “The whole world drowned in darkness today / Every person surrounded by death, disorder and the virus / Humanity is counting down the hours of waiting / For when the end comes - A new dawn.”

For discussion/reflection:

1. The authors describe Singapore's reliance on foreign labour as an 'addiction' (line 14). What are they implying about the nature of our dependence on foreign workers? Based on appropriate reading and research, explain why our dependence on foreign workers can be seen as an 'addiction'.
2. The MES spokesperson suggests that 'tear[ing] down' (line 40) older dormitories and building new ones would 'benefit all stakeholders' (line 41). Identify all the different stakeholders, and explain how each would benefit from new dormitories (with updated specifications).
3. From lines 60 – 66, what are the key justifications Alex Au provides for why the government should play a regulatory role? How convincing do you find his reasoning?
4. What is the authors' purpose in including past crises like the 9/11 terrorist attacks, SARS outbreak, and the global financial crisis (lines 75-76)?
5. Explain, in your own words, how a new 'category of residents who have limited rights as a non-permanent resident foreigner' (line 98) has been created in Singaporeans' minds. Why is such thinking concerning?
6. Eugene Tan argues that Singapore 'cannot continue to have the gain privatised but the costs socialised in our migrant worker policy' (lines 144-145). Explain what he means in your own words.

Related Cambridge/RI essay questions:

1. 'People who do the most worthwhile jobs rarely receive the best financial rewards.' To what extent is this true of your society? (Cambridge 2016)
2. In your society, how far is equality for all a reality? (Cambridge 2012)
3. To what extent are people in your society treated equally? (RI Y5 TP 2024)
4. Is diversity of people and their viewpoints truly celebrated in your society? (RI Y6 CT 2021)
5. To what extent does your society truly care for its underprivileged people? (RI Y5 Promo 2021)
6. Have we paid too high a price in our pursuit of economic growth in Singapore? (Y5 Promo 2010)

Supplementary resources:

- ST CloseUp video. [Migrant Burden: How foreign workers are illegally recruited in Singapore](#)

SECTION C: ISSUES TO DO WITH SOCIAL MOBILITY & INEQUALITY

Reading 14: America's cities are staggeringly unequal

EU 2 & 3

Ronald Brownstein | *The Atlantic* | 23 July 2020

This reading will help you understand:

- Even if countries like America have experienced high levels of economic growth, inequality caused by racial divides and educational shortcomings are exacerbating the divide.
- Policies aimed at tackling poverty and boosting economic growth are not uniformly distributed and do not necessarily benefit everyone within a nation.

The rising tide of economic revival in many of the nation's largest urban centers has definitively not lifted all boats. And that may help explain why so many cities have faced waves of protest this year. In every major American metropolitan area, including many of those that have prospered most since the 2008 financial crash, huge gaps still separate white people and people of color—not only in terms of average hourly wages, but in terms of educational attainment too.

"No place is actually doing well. Even the best performers ... have racial inequities that are unconscionable," says Sarah Treuhaft, the vice president of research at PolicyLink, an Oakland-based research-and-advocacy group. "Economic growth is not enough. Many prosperous places are not doing well on sharing that prosperity."

These sobering findings are contained in today's new release of the National Equity Atlas, a massive online compendium of census and other federal data about cities and metropolitan areas. The Atlas, based mostly on data through 2017, is produced by PolicyLink and the Equity Research Institute at the University of Southern California. It allows users to assess different areas' performance along dozens of indicators, including wages, education, and housing costs, and then compare the standing of different racial groups.

Taken together, the new findings highlight the underlying inequities, beyond the immediate questions of police reform, that brought thousands of Americans to the streets after the killing of George Floyd in Minneapolis. They map the central internal fissure—racial inequality—that's dividing the nation's largest metropolitan areas, even as those areas come under intensifying external pressure from President Donald Trump and other Republicans.

The Atlas's architects say the data all point to the same conclusion: Growth alone won't eliminate racial disparities. No city anywhere in the country, no matter how prosperous, stands out for achieving both rapid growth and effective racial inclusion, Treuhaft told me. That underscores the need for education, housing, and wage policies—among others—specifically targeted at closing these gaps, the authors argue. "What that means for me is the need to even more consciously center racial equity in our economic policies," says Manuel Pastor, a USC sociology professor and the director of the Equity Research Institute.

Among the key disparities:

In all of the 150 largest metropolitan areas, white workers earn higher median wages than workers of color. The widest gap exists outside New York City in the affluent Connecticut suburbs of Bridgeport, Stamford, and Norwalk, where white people earn almost \$16 an hour more than people of color. The gap exceeds \$10 an hour in 12 more metropolitan areas (including Los Angeles and Houston) and stands at \$5 an hour or more in over 100 metros.

35 In all but one of the 150 largest metros, the share of white adults holding at least a four-year college degree exceeds the share among people of color. (The sole exception is in the Manchester and Nashua area in southern New Hampshire, which has a small minority population.) In many places, these gaps are enormous: The share of college-educated white people is at least 25 percentage points higher than the share of college-educated minorities in Washington, D.C.; Los Angeles; Denver; and Durham, North Carolina, among other places. Even that comparison can understate the divergence, because
40 Asian Americans achieve advanced education at high rates. Looking directly at the gap between white people and Black people or white people and Latinos produces even starker contrasts. In San Francisco, the share of white adults with a bachelor's degree is more than double the share of Black adults, and more than triple the share of Latino adults.

45 In each of the nearly 140 metropolitan areas for which data are available, students of color are more likely than white students to attend K–12 schools where at least three-fourths of the kids are poor or low-income. Again, these differences can be enormous: In more than 50 metropolitan areas, the share of minority kids who attend high-poverty schools is at least 30 percentage points higher than the share of white kids who do. Studies have consistently found that students in high-poverty schools are less likely to succeed academically.

50 Two crosscutting trends in the results underscore the magnitude and durability of these racial disparities. One is that they persist in cities from the most to the least affluent. Neither weathered urban centers in the Rust Belt trying to emerge from post-industrial decline nor the high-flying “superstar cities” along the coasts and through the Sun Belt are exempt from these inequities. In fact, because Sun Belt cities have created so many high-paying information-age jobs, which are filled mostly
55 by white people, the gaps tend to be wider in those places. In Cleveland, Detroit, and St. Louis, for instance, the median wage for white residents is about \$6 an hour greater than that for people of color. That white advantage is more than \$8 an hour in Denver and Dallas, nearly \$10 an hour in San Francisco, and more than \$14 an hour in San Jose. Additionally, the education gap between white and nonwhite adults tends to be wider in the cities that are thriving than in those that are struggling,
60 largely because many more white people in prosperous cities hold degrees.

Pastor says the performance of the leading information-economy cities (which include traditional powerhouses such as Boston and New York) signals a departure from the urban experience of the previous few decades. Through the late 20th century and into the early 21st, overall economic growth was greatest in the metro areas that did best on measures of racial inclusion. Not now. “The new
65 economy, [which] emerged out of the Great Recession being so information-driven and oriented to higher-educated individuals, may be changing our metropolitan areas” in a way that produces greater inequality, Pastor told me. “In the past, we could say that as a region was more equitable, it might grow more sustainably over time ... But what we can see here with this data is that you can have robust economic growth and still be falling pretty short on racial equity and inclusion.”

70 The second ominous trend in the new results is that even with steady growth from 2009 until the onset of the coronavirus pandemic this spring, many of these disparities are wider than they were 10, 20, or even 30 years ago. In 65 of the 150 metropolitan areas, the gap in the median hourly wage between white workers and workers of color has widened since 2000 by at least \$1 an hour; the gap has narrowed by at least \$1 an hour in only six of the metros. (The rest saw small changes in either
75 direction.) The trend in adults’ educational attainment is only slightly more optimistic: Since 2000, the college-degree gap between white people and people of color has widened substantially in 50 of the metros, narrowed appreciably in just 15 of them, and changed little in the other 85.

The persistence of these disparities underscores how local trends reflect changes in the larger economy, particularly the increase in inequality that’s tilted gains toward the wealthy, and the low wages that still define the service sector, “where people of color are concentrated,” Treuhaft said.
80

Perhaps even more daunting is the endurance—and, in many instances, the exacerbation—of racial and economic segregation in schools. In several metro areas—including Boston, Charlotte, Houston, and Los Angeles—the gap between the share of white children and the share of children of color attending high-poverty schools is wider than it was in 2010. Even in the few big metros that have
85 narrowed this gap since 2010, a huge racial chasm still remains. In Chicago, about half of kids of color attend high-poverty schools. Just one in 20 white kids attends such schools.

Justin Scoggins, the data manager for the Equity Research Institute, says the durability of school segregation is one of the most formidable barriers to creating more equitable cities. “It is really disheartening to see that is where we have some of the largest racial gaps,” he told me. “In terms of
90 actual economic outcomes, it’s very important.”

As daunting as they are, these results may not even capture the full dimensions of the challenge today. Most of the data in the Equity Atlas, as I noted, run through 2017, when the economy was still growing steadily. But now, as the coronavirus burns through the country, the economy faces a potentially prolonged recession. And historically, low-income, Black, and Latino workers have suffered the most
95 during extended downturns. Which means that absent a specific policy focus on closing these gaps, the disparities that helped fuel this year’s protests may widen, not narrow, in the months ahead.

“Through the recovery period, we did see that people were doing better in terms of employment and wages, but it was taking way too long for Black and Latinx workers to catch up,” Treuhaft said. “And now we are in a new recession and we face the same challenge of inclusive recovery.”

For discussion/reflection:

1. What are some key disparities highlighted in the article, and how do they affect people of colour in Metropolitan areas?
2. According to the text, why is economic growth alone insufficient in eliminating racial disparities in metropolitan areas, and what specific policies are needed to address these gaps?
3. Based on your observations, how do you think the pandemic affected the level of inequality in the cities highlighted in the article?
4. How does the type of inequality raised by the writer compare to what has been observed in Singapore? Assess some of the policies that the government in Singapore has put in place to try to address inequality.

Related Cambridge/RI essay questions:

1. To what extent is human life in general about the survival of the fittest? (Cambridge 2020)
2. How far is increased prosperity for all a realistic goal in your society? (Cambridge 2013)
3. Discuss the view that ending poverty is desirable but unachievable. (RI Y6 CT 2021)
4. ‘Technology is key to reducing inequality.’ How far do you agree? (RI Y5 Promo 2021)
5. ‘Inequality is a fact of life.’ To what extent should we accept this? (RI Y6 Prelim 2010)

SECTION C: ISSUES TO DO WITH SOCIAL MOBILITY & INEQUALITY

Reading 15: Education reforms, and more, needed to fix inequality

EU 2-4

Adapted from Education reforms, and more, needed to fix inequality | Linda Lim & Pang Eng Fong | Channel News Asia | 2 June 2018

This reading will help you understand:

- Why education, instead of being a social leveller, is contributing to worsening inequality in today's world
- How the Singaporean ideology of “meritocracy” potentially compounds the problem of inequality
- Suggested approaches to mitigating inequality

Combating inequality has been declared a “national priority” in Singapore. This makes sense, given the pernicious effects that persistently high inequality can have on economic growth, political stability, social cohesion, quality of life, and even national security.

5 The 2016 Brexit and Trump votes occurred in the two major developed countries with the greatest income inequality — the UK and US respectively. Studies suggest that socio-cultural as well as economic divides resulting from inequality contributed to these electoral results, which have since led to populist and protectionist policy proposals that will slow growth in the long run.

10 Inequality itself also directly lowers economic growth through under-realisation of scarce talent, and weaker consumption demand — both are of particular concern to Singapore given our small labour force and market size.

15 As an already mature, high-income and thus slow-growing economy, we can also no longer expect rapid growth to mask the economic effects and social challenges of rising inequality, as it did in previous decades. Instead we need to boldly confront the root causes of inequality, which lie in how our economic and social institutions actually work. Focusing on education policy as the main solution can actually worsen inequality.

How does education contribute to inequality?

In developed economies like the UK, US and Singapore, education, especially university education, contributes to the widening skills premium (excess of skilled over unskilled labour income), and parents and students naturally clamour for more of it.

20 This is where education and inequality are mutually reinforcing. Higher-income families invest more in private tuition for academic subjects, extracurricular enrichment activities, and parental attention. This enhances their children's school performance and chances of getting into “good” (elite, brand-name) schools and universities, thus achieving credentials that employers value and reward with “good jobs” and high salaries.

25 Employers are known to use educational certification and school reputation as “screening devices” that differentiate between job candidates, and as proxies for behavioural characteristics and social networks they believe enhance employees' contribution to the enterprise.

30 Expansion of higher education has been accompanied by a widening “college premium” — or gap between graduate and non-graduate incomes — even as the supply of graduates increases. Recent studies in the US and UK suggest that this is due to losses to non-graduates, as well as gains to graduates, as employers start requiring degrees for work that did not need it 30 years ago.

And as university degrees become more common, institutional reputation becomes more important, intensifying competition for places at the most selective institutions, and widening their graduates' salary premium over graduates of less selective institutions.

Can education reforms reduce inequality?

35 Policy-makers in developed countries have focused on reforms in education to reduce inequality. In some countries, particularly the US, unequal resource allocation between "rich" and "poor" school districts is a major factor contributing to unequal educational, employment and income outcomes. This is less of a problem in Singapore, given the Ministry of Education's worthy efforts to equalise the allocation of resources — including the "best" teachers and administrators — between "neighbourhood" and "elite" schools. But it is hard to improve already high-performing, well-
40 resourced schools.

More importantly, as we noted in the *New Nation* in 1976: "The effect of any school variable which can be manipulated by decision-makers is small relative to other determinants of student performance... Family background is a very important variable affecting educational performance and earnings of individuals... changes within the school system itself will not necessarily bring about more
45 equal performance of students in school or greater income equality among them when they are employed."

Recent, separate research by NTU associate professor of sociology Teo You Yenn, and NUS associate professor of social work Irene Ng, confirms the dominant impact of family circumstances on student performance in Singapore today.

50 The PISA test which we regularly top shows that 15-year-old students in Singapore on average perform better than those in OECD countries, but here the gap between the top and bottom scorers is wider and the dependence on parents' socio-economic status higher.

Another popular policy is to increase lower-income students' access to more selective schools, including through priority admissions, as Singapore plans to do in Primary One and post-PSLE student
55 assignments to elite schools. But at best this can cater to only a small subset of low-income students, probably those already best qualified. This could widen the student performance gap between elite and neighbourhood schools, and subject more families to "exam stress".

Since school performance is heavily dependent on family resources, lower-income children could underperform relative to higher-income classmates in elite schools, reinforcing stigmatisation from
60 priority admission, and lowering self-esteem which research shows is a major determinant of individual performance.

Priority admission for lower-income children would also intensify competition among higher-income students for "fewer" elite school places, thus worsening the "education arms race".

65 In the US, such competition has worsened inequality and increased social stratification by increasing home values (hence family wealth) in residential neighbourhoods in the top public school districts. Tweaking Singapore's education system will not reduce inequality because it does not change the underlying unequal socio-economic structure to whose incentives families of all income levels rationally respond.

70 Parents naturally seek for their children entry into secure, well-paid employment in large corporate and government bureaucracies, and cartelised high-earning professions, which still use traditional academic credentials to screen candidates and remunerate employees.

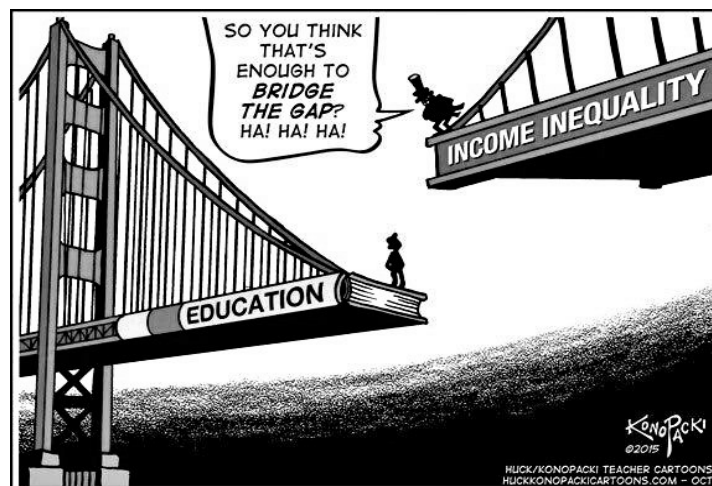
The impact of meritocracy

The Singaporean ideology that we are a “meritocracy” where economic success based on hard work and the right academic credentials justifies unequal returns, poses some problems.

75 It entrenches hierarchy, and hence a systemic inequality to which social mobility can at best contribute slightly more diverse members at each level of the pyramid. Overall inequality does not decline, and at worst, those who fail to “make it” up the ladder are considered to “deserve” their inferior position on the social as well as income scale.

80 Beginning with the competitive “streaming” of students by exam results at an early age, such stratification has stigmatising and demotivating effects which limit educational attainment and reduce intergenerational mobility.

85 Meritocracy as currently construed in Singapore, and served by the educational system, is arguably the problem, not the solution, for both economic development and inequality, as it is in other highly unequal rich societies. A UK study shows that students from higher-income families are more likely to go to university, and to more selective universities. They also earn more than students from lower-income families who graduate from the same institutions in the same subjects, and with similar other characteristics.



Reducing inequality through redistribution need not harm growth

90 We need to look outside the education system for policies that do work to reduce income and wealth disparities. They include higher tax rates on high income earners, levies on capital gains, estates and inheritance, and a stronger social safety net — all of which Singapore has eschewed, believing these would reduce the incentive to work hard, save and invest, and thus harm economic growth.

95 But high-income Scandinavian countries, Switzerland and Germany, have reduced inequality over decades through progressive universal tax-and-transfer systems that included labour market policies, spending on healthcare and social protection while growing at respectable rates and ranking high on productivity and innovation indices — some even while maintaining budget surpluses and strong currencies.

100 Some high earners may resent high tax rates, but all citizens benefit from subsidised public services, including health and education, and receive unemployment insurance and retirement pensions. Besides reducing economic and social divides, these policies may also encourage savings for growth-enhancing investments in business enterprises (rather than housing consumption, as in Singapore). Recent improvement in Singapore’s still-high Gini coefficient also results not from

educational policy, but from increased social transfers to vulnerable groups — subsidies for low-wage workers, the elderly and elderly poor.

105 But these have been insufficient to narrow the cumulative wide income and wealth gaps created by past policies and market forces. Our post-tax-and-transfers Gini still ranks with the highest among developed countries (lower than the US but similar to the UK), is much higher than those of other small high-income economies (in Scandinavia), and is unlikely to be fiscally sustainable.

110 However, we have run large budget and current account surpluses for decades, piling up huge foreign exchange reserves that have been well-invested by our sovereign wealth funds. More of these could be converted into social spending that could both increase productivity and reduce inequality.

115 Reforming the education system — by equalising resources, eliminating streaming, increasing curricular flexibility and minimising social segregation — can reduce inequality and social stratification, and foster the innovation and entrepreneurship required for post-industrial economic growth, only if the deep-seated institutional roots of inequality are addressed.

The political will to do this is what matters in the struggle for a more just and equal society that will benefit all of us.

For discussion/reflection:

1. Read paragraphs 2-3 of this article. According to Lim and Pang, why is it an imperative for societies to address inequality?
2. In your own words as far as possible, explain how education and inequality can be 'mutually reinforcing' (line 19). To what extent have you observed this in the context of Singapore?
3. In what ways might meritocracy in Singapore further exacerbate inequality?
4. Why is social redistribution, explained in lines 88 – 96, un-meritocratic, but perhaps more just?

Related Cambridge/RI essay questions:

1. To what extent should income equality be a goal in your society? (Cambridge 2019)
2. To what extent should the rich be expected to help the poor? (RI Y5 Timed Practice 2020)
3. To what extent is education still the key to a nation's success? (RI Y6 CT1 2019)
4. 'Success is determined by one's intelligence.' Discuss. (RI Y6 Prelim 2012)
5. 'Inequality is a fact of life.' To what extent should we accept this? (RI Y6 Prelim 2010)

SECTION C: ISSUES TO DO WITH SOCIAL MOBILITY AND INEQUALITY

Reading 16: “Good enough”: The risks and responsibilities of choosing a primary school

EU 3-6

Jacqueline Ho | Academic.SG | 16 June 2022

This reading will help you understand:

- The intentions behind the evolution of the focus of Singapore’s education system from ‘brand-name’ schools to the vision of ‘Every School a Good School’
- Factors influencing parental decision-making concerning primary school selection, including security and assurance
- How parents interpret the risks associated with school choice and construct narratives of responsible parenting
- That notions of risk and responsibility are shaped by parents’ social positions and experiences, leading to diverse perspectives on what constitutes good parenting in school selection
- Parental risk management strategies contribute to educational inequality

Registration for Primary One is about to begin, and with it, another round of hand-wringing about whether parents should try to send their children to “brand-name” schools. The now-familiar phrase “Every School a Good School,” introduced a decade ago by then-Education Minister Heng Swee Keat, insists that this is unnecessary. Part marketing slogan and part policy direction, it represented a vision that every school would have its unique strengths and that parents and students should recognise these.

“Every School a Good School” is in line with the Ministry of Education’s efforts to build “multiple peaks of excellence” — to develop pathways and evaluation metrics that reward not only academic achievement, but also talent in non-academic domains, character development, and more. The vision is of an education system where there is no single definition of “goodness.” Rather, each student finds a pathway and school that is best for them. Parents should therefore feel no need to compete for “elite” schools.

There have been real changes in the information available to parents about schools. PSLE results are not easily available, school websites offer rich information about extracurricular and distinctive programmes, and mainstream media describe schools as “popular” rather than “good,” recasting “goodness” as subjective rather than absolute. Yet the competition for primary schools continues and has perhaps even increased, as MOE recently noted when announcing changes to the P1 registration framework.

During last year’s registration exercise (July-October 2021), I interviewed 50 parents to understand how they went about choosing a primary school. The vast majority were middle-class but they varied in terms of their educational backgrounds. Given that the intent of “Every School a Good School” is to eliminate the perception that there is a hierarchy of schools — a single dimension along which all schools can be compared — I especially wanted to understand whether, and why, parents drew on hierarchical criteria to evaluate schools.

Searching for schools, searching for security

I remember telling a friend, a week before I conducted my first interview, that I was nervous about alienating the “kiasu parents” I was sure I would encounter. I was concerned that interviewees might feel I was judging them.

Thinking back, I realise my concern was likely a product of how we as a society imagine this “type” of parent. To explain why the competition for coveted schools continues year after year — and more

generally, why MOE's attempts to deemphasise exams and grades have met with resistance — we commonly call to mind pathologising images of parents who “jostle for” and “hanker after” top schools by volunteering or moving, who define success as “being in the top fifth percentile,” or who are simply “kiasu-as-heck.” The stereotypical “kiasu parent” is overbearing, incomprehensibly competitive, and will not settle for anything but the “best school.”

Yet in analysing the words parents use to describe their feelings throughout the P1 registration process, I find that they are more often looking for schools that are “good enough” or “not too shabby,” and that make them feel “safe” or “reassured.” They worry about their children “losing out,” and want to prepare them to “enter society with maximum armour.” Parents also use the language of “enough” to describe their own actions during the registration process: some fret about whether they are “doing enough,” others feel assured that they have done “a reasonable amount.”

These words suggest that for many parents, choosing a primary school may be more about seeking a basic sense of security than about moulding their children into doctors and lawyers (though one parent did explicitly say that this was her wish). Kiasuism, then, is not so much a psychological malaise, but rather one of several ways that parents establish a feeling of security — about their children's futures, and about the things they are doing as parents to guide these futures. But why must parents do this work?

At the broadest level, this need to construct a sense of security is simply an attribute of modern societies: when one's future is no longer guaranteed by one's position at birth, this heightens the perception of risk. Systems like mass education, infused with the meritocratic ethos that “one must do something to make one's fortune” (Beck-Gernsheim 1998), insist that these risks can be controlled through careful planning. Thus individuals begin to develop their identities around the things they are doing to build a secure future amidst uncertainty (Silva & Corse 2018).

Systems within society, such as the P1 registration process, also govern how these risks are managed. That parents must choose a school means they are designated to manage the risks associated with school (Ball 2003). Given the complexity of Singapore's P1 registration system, the sheer number of things parents can do to exercise this choice (Debs & Cheung 2021) reinforces the notion that parents are agents with the ability to minimise uncertainties regarding their children's futures. How parents experience these risks and interpret their responsibility for managing them depends on their social position, including their social networks and past experiences of the education system.

How parents interpret risk and responsibility

Eva and her husband both attended an “elite,” “super hot” primary school. When friends questioned why they were not using their alumni advantage to register at their alma mater, Eva “struggled” for some time about the choice: “It makes me anxious, oh, so my kid is just going to a neighbourhood school, does that affect him negatively [...] Will he be missing out on better teachers, better materials, better exams? And ultimately, tsk, am I being a good parent if I don't maximise his potential?”

After reflecting extensively on her “values” and “definitions of success,” she eventually opted for a new school near her home. During the interview, she was able to share a coherent list of what she prioritised in her children's education. These included developing character traits like “resilience” and “kindness,” and nurturing a love of learning that would help her children find their passions and skills, rather than “how much money [they're] going to earn next time.”

Siew Ling also chose a neighbourhood school near her home, but the decision process caused her less angst. Once she registered her son at the school's affiliated MOE Kindergarten, she saw no need to look into other schools (“case closed”). She does not believe that primary school matters to a child's outcomes, because “even if you have the best teacher in the world, [if] the kid really doesn't want to study, you can't force a horse to drink.” Guided by her belief that “ultimately it's still depending on

the kid,” she says that she will “of course [...] try to encourage and help the kids to learn and to complete their homework,” but also says she will “just kind of leave it to fate lah.” Describing her approach to parenting, she said she believed in “放羊吃草¹. By allowing her children to explore and mix with different people, she believed they would learn the “EQ” that would serve them well in the workplace, as she had experienced herself.

Some parents interviewed believe that that a school should help their child grow in qualities like kindness and resilience, and not just gain good grades. This comparison offers a couple of takeaways. First, parents experience the choice of a primary school as either risky or not. This depends on how they interpret the school hierarchy. That is, when they look at indicators of hierarchy — say, a school’s balloting history, or its reputation in the neighbourhood WhatsApp group — do they see these as indicators of risk? Whereas Eva worries her child might miss out on better opportunities if she sends him to a neighbourhood school, Siew Ling does not believe that differences between schools will matter to her child’s educational outcomes.

Digging deeper, we see that for parents like Eva, their interpretations are built from everyday encounters with social difference. As they narrate these experiences, they come to believe that the inequalities between schools are consequential. Molly, for instance, avoided choosing a less popular school despite being impressed by its website, CCAs, and niche programmes, because her “anxiety as a parent kicked in.” Having previously taught at a school that was the “lowest ranked” in its neighbourhood, she said she used to feel “very shy” when asked where she taught. Her teaching history at this school also lost her prospective clients when she worked as a private tutor. She worries that her “shy and awkward,” “not very confident” son might feel even less confident if he receives similar reactions when introducing his school.

Depending on parents’ experiences, however, less popular schools can also signal security, while elite schools can signal risk. Justine has heard about a parent being told by a teacher at a well-known school that if their child could not cope, they could transfer her to another school. She avoids choosing popular schools, for fear that she as a parent “can’t keep up” with the homework load and that her child will be “left behind.” Lisa also avoids “top brand schools.” She does not want her children to become “arrogant” or “yaya papaya,” like the students at such schools whom she encountered during her schooling years.

Whether they target schools that are higher or lower on the hierarchy, it is narratives of how school inequalities matter that lead some parents to derive their sense of security from a school’s hierarchical position. By contrast, Siew Ling draws on a meritocratic narrative that outcomes depend on the individual child. Since the differences between schools do not matter to her, she pays no attention to the school hierarchy when making her choice.

Second, as parents make sense of the risks facing them, they develop varied understandings of what it means to be a responsible parent. Among parents who interpret the school hierarchy as a measure of risk, being responsible means judiciously choosing the schools that will minimise these risks. They are “proud” of the “homework” they have done, “scold” their friends for not acting sooner, or comfort themselves that even if they do not succeed in getting into a certain school, “at least [they] did something.”

Given how dominant this definition of responsible parenting is, parents who do not do this “something,” like Eva and Siew Ling, must develop alternative narratives of security to affirm that their children’s futures will be secure regardless of their choice of school. These narratives contain different notions of parental responsibility, and which ones parents draw on is partially shaped by their class-

¹ Chinese idiom that has the literal meaning of “letting the sheep out to graze in the pasture”. It means to allow children to go unchecked.

120 differentiated experiences of the education system. Siew Ling believes her choice of school does not matter because “it depends on the kid.” This was a common refrain that I heard. For some parents, this notion is appealing because it reflects their own experience of social mobility. Charmaine, who attended neighbourhood schools and was raised by a single mother, qualified for the Express stream despite not receiving homework help and being “very very much on [her] own.” This leads her to believe that “it’s very much based on character or your interest in studies.” Her sister also embraces this notion and incorporates it into her parenting approach. As she tells Charmaine, “Why worry? Just let them be what they want to be, they will do well if they can do well.” In this, she echoes Siew Ling’s emphasis on allowing her children to explore on their own.

130 In contrast, the narrative that Eva draws on involves her playing a more active role as a parent. While Eva believes primary school does make a difference for certain outcomes, she anchors her sense of security in alternative “values” like character development and joy in the learning process. She comes to understand her “job” as “[helping] them see what are their options” given what they enjoy doing, in order that they may have a “fulfilling career.” Stella is another parent who believes that “it’s ok if a child is mediocre in results,” as long as they “find something that they will enjoy and be passionate about.” As students, both Eva and Stella felt they were pushed to do well academically but did not enjoy their studies, explaining their current emphasis on finding joy and passion in the learning process.

Some parents who do not compete for good schools believe children should be allowed to explore at their own pace.

Inequalities, old and new

140 This competition for primary schools persists not simply because of the “mindsets” or “parenting styles” of grade-obsessed kiasu parents, but because P1 registration is a social process through which parents learn to be responsible for managing risk.

145 By comparing parents who choose schools in different ways, we see how it is narratives of how schools matter, built on lived experiences of inequality, that lead many to interpret a school’s hierarchical position as an indicator of risk. As these parents tap into their own memories of school and canvass their friends for “live reviews” or informal rankings, they hear about their friends’ children “turning 360” because of “bad company,” remember how “very proud” they were when their “normal” secondary school was granted autonomous status, and regret not receiving better language training when they struggle to write grammatically correct work emails.

150 Having grown up in a hierarchical school system, parents have learned the meanings of fundamental social differences — “neighbourhood” and “elite,” “disciplined” and “paikia,” “autonomous” and “government,” “EM3” and “EM1,” “EQ” and “IQ” — through experiences that have made them feel anxious, proud, or ashamed. These emotions remind them that certain schools carry risks while others afford security, driving them to sort into different schools, and fueling the unequal competition that continues to stratify schools.

155 Yet this sorting, while the focus of much public discourse, may not be the only way that parents’ risk management strategies contribute to educational inequality. Choice processes like the P1 registration system hold parents responsible for managing educational risks. Parents therefore learn to account for their choices to their friends, themselves, and sometimes even their children. In the process, they develop varied understandings of responsible parenting, which could shape their involvement in their children’s education outside of choosing a school.

For some parents, being a “good parent” means doing the necessary “homework” to secure a “good school.” Others who do not participate in this competition develop alternative narratives of security: that it “depends on the child,” that it is more important for children to find their “passion,” or that

165 they will be able to “make do” with any school because they can seek out enrichment courses elsewhere. This narrative work is particularly necessary for parents like Eva, who do believe that school inequalities are consequential and who face pressure from friends to choose a “good school.”

170 As discourses like “Every School a Good School” and “Life Beyond Grades” draw some parents away from conventional definitions of responsible parenting, like gunning for good schools and grades, this raises new questions about how such parents are channeling old anxieties into alternative enactments of good parenting, and how this might contribute to new types of inequality in parental involvement and educational outcomes.

For discussion/reflection:

1. Ho began by referencing the well-known MOE vision of ‘Every School a Good School’ (line 3). In what ways might this be a deliberate attempt by MOE to redefine enduring beliefs about schooling success in Singapore?
2. Based on lines 12-17, how do we know that this move has not been entirely successful?
3. What makes it apparent that ‘parents [often] drew on hierarchical criteria to evaluate schools (line 22)? Should this trend be of concern to other stakeholders involved in Singapore’s educational system? Why or why not?
4. Ho asserts that school selection has become a primary means for parents to ‘establish a feeling of security’ (line 42). What does this reveal about parental beliefs concerning the wider environment beyond the school system?
5. Consider the rationalisations employed by Eva and Siew Ling respectively in working through the choice of school for their children (lines 58-77). Explain how their choice of school was ultimately based on contrasting appraisals of the downsides and upsides of selecting ‘elite’ (line 58) versus ‘neighbourhood’ (line 60) schools.
6. Compare the upsides and downsides of opting for ‘a less popular school’ as defined by Molly (line 88) against that as perceived by Justine (line 92) and ‘Lisa’ (line 98).
7. What are the two contrasting perceptions of parental responsibility as explained by Ho between line 105 and line 131? Explain how the contrasting perceptions might be strongly linked to the parents’ own unique and often disparate experiences.
8. Explain what ‘indicators of risk’ (line 83) mean in the context of school selection. How do these terms challenge state narratives about Singapore schools?
9. What does Ho mean by the label ‘narrative work’ (line 159)? Why is it essential ‘for parents like Eva’ (line 159), who have decided to attach greater worth to helping their ‘children to find their “passion” ‘ (line 157)?
10. Identify and explain possible factors that contribute to parents assigning high stakes to the choosing of a primary school. How do you think this issue might develop, in light of Singapore’s evolving demographics as well as social and political landscape?

Related Cambridge/RI essay questions:

1. Assess the extent to which all people in your society have the opportunity to achieve their full potential. (Cambridge 2023)
2. ‘Parents have no right to impose their own values and beliefs on their children.’ Discuss. (Cambridge 2015)
3. ‘Parents have too much control over their children’s lives.’ How far is this true of your society today? (RI Y5 Promo 2020)
4. ‘Education has resulted in only more inequality.’ Do you agree? (RI Y5 CT1 2011)
5. ‘Education is the great leveller.’ How far is this true? (RI Y5 CT1 2010)

SECTION D: INTER-GENERATIONAL ISSUES & AGEING

Reading 17: Many millennials are worse off than their parents – a first in American history

EU 2, 4-6

Tami Luhby | CNN | 11 January 2020

This reading will help you understand:

- Understand the challenges the millennial generation faces with regard to job security and wealth generation
- The underlying reasons why these issues are not talked about more

On paper, it looks like Scott Larsen is doing better than his father was at the same age. At 29, Larsen has a college degree and earns more money, but he doesn't feel he's moving up in the world.

5 When his father, Craig, was 29, he was already married, owned a home in Payson, Utah, and had two of his five children. Now 64, Craig Larsen worked as a mechanical engineer, earning about \$20,000 a year at the time, or about \$50,500 in today's dollars, even though he hadn't finished college. His wife, Kathy, was a stay-at-home mom.

10 Scott, the youngest of the kids, is a marketing manager for a health and beauty company based in nearby Provo, Utah. Though he earns around \$60,000 annually – about 20% more than his dad did at his age – he is living with his parents, because he doesn't feel he can afford to buy a place of his own thanks to soaring housing prices. While his dad was able to purchase a house for a little over twice his annual salary, Scott Larsen says he'd have to spend more than five times his yearly paycheck.

15 “The prospect of taking care of a family or buying a normal, decent home seem like far-off dreams that I'll have to reconsider in another five years,” said Scott Larsen, noting that living at home is “horrible” for his social life but is a “financially sound idea”.

Even though the US economy is growing – according to a recent CNN poll, 76% of Americans think it's doing better than it has in decades – not everyone is prospering. Millennials are on track to be the first generation not to exceed their parents in terms of job status or income, studies show.

20 Democratic presidential candidates have seized on that reality, rolling out plans for erasing crippling student loan debt and guaranteeing health care, designed in large part to appeal to a generation that feels it can't get ahead. “

Coming of age in a financial crisis

25 Millennials – which the Pew Research Center classifies as the generation born between 1981 and 1996 – have faced challenges. They came of age at the worst possible moment – when the economy collapsed in the Great Recession, said Michael Hout, a sociology professor at New York University. The US economy is not supporting a continuing increase in occupational status to the extent it once did. Compounding the problem is that millennials' parents did benefit from an upward shift in job status, making it even harder to surpass their accomplishments.

30 Among Americans born in the late 1980s, only 44% were in jobs with higher socioeconomic status than their parents when both were age 30, while 49% had positions of lower status, according to Hout, who published a study on millennials in the 2019 Stanford Center on Poverty & Inequality Pathways Magazine.

That's a far cry from those born in the late 1930s, some 70% of whom did better than their parents. The rate has drifted downward since, but millennials are the first to fall below 50%.

35 Another study found that only half of those born in 1984 earned more than their parents at about age 30, compared to 92% of those born in 1940.

“A big part of the American dream is that each generation will do better than the one that preceded it,” said David Grusky, a sociology professor at Stanford and one of the authors of the second study, which was published in the journal *Science* in 2017. “That has been part of what’s supposed to make this country special and distinctive. When it’s just a coin flip, we’re not living up to that commitment. It’s a pretty fundamental part of what we say this country can deliver and we’re not.”

Rising house prices and college costs

More than a dozen millennials told CNN of their struggles to meet or exceed their parents’ job status or lifestyle. Some had trouble landing good-paying jobs, while others found that housing prices, student loans and other expenses were dragging them down.

40 Take Brianna Garcia, 26, of San Antonio, Texas. The first in her family to graduate college, she earned a bachelor’s degree in education two years ago from Our Lady of the Lake University in her hometown. She had hoped to become an elementary school teacher, but districts were downsizing at the time she was applying.

45 She broadened her search, looking for “something a little higher paying to help me work my way up”. But she was repeatedly thwarted by a lack of experience. Finally, with the help of her mom, she landed a job in March at a medical clinic, doing filing for \$11 an hour.

While her parents had their struggles and relied on government assistance for a time, they were able to buy a house by the time her dad was 30 and raise two children. Her father, 51, was an accountant at a bakery and is now a payroll supervisor at a shoe company. Her mother, 49, worked in medical records.

50 “My parents made it for the most part, but they’ve always wanted better for me,” said Garcia, who lives at home and hasn’t started paying off her \$27,000 in student loans because her income is too low. “I’m trying to do so and work hard but with this job market that doesn’t feel very open and the housing costs that are unrealistically high, it feels impossible sometimes to do better than my parents.”

“All I want to do is have a stable job so that when my parents need my help, I can do it,” she said.

For Sarah Clinton, 34, the problem isn’t with her career. She feels that she and her husband both have good, stable jobs with decent salaries and the ability to advance – she works with the homeless after earning a master’s in social work and he sells long-term care insurance while pursuing his MBA. But the Waltham, Massachusetts, couple barely make enough to afford their \$2,300 monthly rent and other life expenses.

55 Home prices have risen faster than inflation. In 1980, the typical home sold for about \$197,500, adjusted for inflation, according to US Census Bureau data. Now, it’s more than \$325,000.

60 Saving to buy a house or start a family doesn’t seem feasible at the moment, Clinton said. Her parents, meanwhile, served in the military and received housing allowances. Eventually, they bought a home off the base in New Hampshire. After they left the service, her dad took another government job and her mother became a nurse.

“They want me to have a child, purchase a home, but I can’t do that now,” Clinton said. “It’s a goal that we feel that much further away from reaching.”

Wealth creation is lagging, too

65 When it comes to wealth, millennials are falling behind, as well. They typically have much less net worth than Generation X households did when each generation was between 25 to 34 years old, according to a recent Government Accountability Office study of Federal Reserve Bank data. The median wealth of millennial households was just over \$20,000, while Gen X had about \$31,250 according to the GAO.

Part of the reason is that millennials are less likely to be homeowners at that age. Some 43% of millennial households owned homes, compared to 51% of Gen X, according to the GAO.

70 Student loans are also an issue. Several millennials told CNN that their college debts are crushing their ability to advance – an issue their parents largely didn’t have to contend with. Young families had \$1,415 in education debt, on average, in 1989, according to an Urban Institute calculation of Federal Reserve Bank data, which looked at those aged 18 to 29. That burden soared to \$13,039 by 2016.

75 If it weren’t for her student loans, Kathy Israel would be able to live on her own. Though she purposely attended a state law school to keep costs in check, she has still accumulated \$120,000 in student debt.

The 30-year-old works in compliance for a Big Four auditing firm, but she had to move back with her parents because of her \$1,200 monthly student loan payment.

80 Her parents didn’t initially finish college, but grew her mother’s family costume jewellery business into a successful company while raising four children. Her dad later earned his bachelor’s degree at a state college – incurring no debt – and got a job as a statistician. His master’s degree was paid for by his employer.

“They were building a life,” said Israel, who lives in St Petersburg, Florida. “I am stagnant. You can’t get ahead. You can only get behind if you aren’t conscious.”

For discussion/reflection:

1. According to the reading, what factors are contributing to the struggles of millennials in the US?
 2. Consider millennials in Singapore. What similarities and differences do you see in term such struggles? Can you explain why there are differences?
 3. What do you think ‘building a life’ entails in your society? Are a house and family considered important in your society today?
 4. How have normative notions of what is considered a ‘good life’ evolve across different generations here in Singapore? Can you provide possible explanations for key shifts in such notions?
 5. Think about the wider impacts of economic and material challenges on Singaporean youth: one area of attention and concern in recent years is mental well-being. How might the Singaporean context contribute to this concern or exacerbate the situation?
- Further reading: <https://www.todayonline.com/singapore/today-youth-survey-cost-living-mental-health-worries-healthcare-expenses-2033126>

Related RI essay questions:

1. To what extent can individuals shape their own lives when the world is so unpredictable? (Cambridge 2022)
2. How far is the pursuit of happiness the most important human goal? (Cambridge 2021)
3. To what extent are young people in your society prepared for a world that is constantly changing? (RI Y6 Prelim 2019)
4. ‘Young people today think of nothing but themselves.’ Is this a fair description? (RI Y6 Prelim 2014)

SECTION D: INTER-GENERATIONAL ISSUES & AGEING

Reading 18: Pandemics – Youth in an age of lost opportunity

EU 2-4 & 6

Adapted from Chapter 3 of The Global Risks Report 2021 | World Economic Forum | 16 January 2021

This reading will help you understand:

- The challenges today's youth around the world were already exposed to before the Covid-19 pandemic
- The new or elevated risks the youth would have to overcome, ranging from unstable educational environments and dwindling pathways in the employment landscape, to increased risks of disenfranchisement
- The improvements and investments that are necessary to ensure the flourishing of the generation of youth currently experiencing the pandemic

Young adults (ages 15–24) around the world are experiencing their second major global crisis within a decade: they entered youth in the throes of the financial crisis, and are now exiting at the outset of a pandemic not seen in generations. They will face serious challenges to their education, economic prospects and mental health.

- 5 The outlook for this generation had already been diminished by environmental degradation, rising inequality (of many types – gender, intergenerational, economic and ethnic), varying degrees of violence, and social disruption from the tech-enabled industrial transformation. While the digital leap forward unlocked opportunities for some youth, many are now entering the workforce in an employment 'ice age'.
- 10 In May 2020, the World Economic Forum's *COVID-19 Risks Outlook* warned of a "next lost generation". According to the Global Risks Perception Survey (GRPS), "youth disillusionment" is a top neglected risk that will become a critical threat to the world over the next two years. Hard-fought societal wins could be obliterated if the current generation lacks adequate pathways to educational and job opportunities.

Fragile education systems

- 15 The year 2020 saw unprecedented challenges to the global education system. During the first wave of pandemic lockdowns, 80% of students globally were out of school, as traditional classroom teaching was rendered mute. Despite worldwide adaptation for remote teaching via television, radio and internet, there were stark regional differences in capacity; at least 30% of the global student population lacked the technology to participate in digital and broadcast learning. While adaptive measures allowed schools to re-open eventually, many challenges remained throughout subsequent
- 20 waves of COVID-19 because of ineffective or slow government responses.

- 25 School closures aggravated youth inequalities between and within societies because young women and those of disadvantaged socio-economic statuses were hit hardest. Students in high-income households potentially benefited from more targeted and individualized learning arrangements, but resource-strapped youth struggled to participate in educational opportunities in the absence of digital connectivity, adult support or adequate space to study at home. For others, border closings complicated educational mobility.

- 30 Home schooling and home working increased household stress and the incidence of violence against young adults. In areas where school provides access to food and a safe space, school closures put students at higher risk of child labour, recruitment by organised crime, human trafficking, and gun violence.

School closings have had devastating consequences on young women. Gender-based violence has increased globally during the pandemic, and rapes rose in advanced and developing countries alike. Teenage pregnancies are expected to increase, from Latin America to East Asia and Africa—previous health crises suggest that some of these girls might be prevented from returning to school. Globally, COVID-19 and its “shadow pandemic” on girls and young women risk reversing 25 years’ worth of global gains in girls’ education, exposing girls to a higher chance of underage marriage.

Employment turmoil

Although many economies recovered from the 2008–2009 Financial Crisis, those hit hardest by the Great Recession never did fully. As a result, youth unemployment has risen globally since 2008. National policies still fail to lift up youth in many cases. Weak structural transformations have largely failed to reduce stubbornly high, systemic youth unemployment, particularly in the Middle East and North Africa.

The increase of unbound job schemes originating from the ‘gig’ economy, unpaid or low-paid internships and continued high numbers of youth in the informal market have spurred young workers to jump between low-paid short-term jobs. At the same time, labour market distortions narrowed employment opportunities for young adults: a deficit of employment opportunities for highly educated youth in some sectors, and a “skills crisis” in others.

Policy responses to COVID-19 further exacerbated the marginalization of young workers. The global economy plummeted in the second quarter of 2020, disproportionately affecting the incomes of young adults. In many economies, they were the first to lose their jobs to lockdowns. Many young adults work in the sectors hardest hit by the pandemic—such as the service industry and manufacturing—often on part-time or temporary contracts with limited job protection. The informal sector, where almost 80% of the world’s young workers are employed, was particularly impacted. Altogether, the number of young people who are not in employment, education or training (NEET), already at 21% in early 2020, is likely to rise in the coming year.

Young adults’ employment prospects were being challenged by automation, as well as by disruption from the Fourth Industrial Revolution, before interrupted education opportunities and job losses set them further behind. Youth unemployment may increase across regions, given that more sectoral restructuring and shifting consumer habits are expected to trigger mass layoffs.

“Pandemics” are at risk of becoming the double lost generation of the 21st century. Lack of opportunities for future economic, societal and political participation could have long-lasting global consequences.

A narrowing pathway for youth

Lockdowns may cause an education loss of at least one semester, which, like absenteeism, could affect future academic performance, increase dropout rates and induce riskier health behaviours. This could make it harder for students at the secondary and tertiary levels to acquire the necessary skills to pursue further education or vocational training, or even to secure entry-level jobs. And such further education or training is even more important for “jobs of the future”.

Young women face the risk of being kept out of school for household or agricultural work, not being able to finish their secondary education, or not being able to return to work after leaving during the pandemic for caregiving responsibilities; young men could face increased financial pressure in societies where they are the sole financial contributor of the household. A widening of educational, socio-economic and gender inequalities can be expected.

The 2008–2009 Financial Crisis has shown the persistence of youth unemployment—young adults have continuously struggled to integrate into and align their skills with a grim job market. This struggle can leave long-lasting marks on their livelihoods. As the world starts to recover from COVID-19, young adults are likely to face such challenges again, this time amplified by the world’s digital leap forward. Entry-level jobs today require more skills than they did a decade ago, and, at the same time, there are fewer available because of automation.

The consequences of rapidly changing markets make youth more vulnerable to unstable contracts, career instability and limited promotion prospects. This can lead to a higher risk that they will miss out on social safety benefits, job protection and re-skilling opportunities. More importantly, a stunted employment outlook complicates young people’s ability to consolidate economic capital and social mobility. Young students are expected to face increased debt burdens as student loans continue to reach record levels, and graduates entering the workforce in an economic crisis are more likely to earn less than their peers. In economies where informal work is predominant—mostly because of high shares of agricultural and services industry professions—lack of social protection increases youth’s risk of sliding into poverty quickly.

Fear, anger and backlash

Young people have become more and more vocal in the past decade, in the streets and in cyberspace. Their concern and proactivity with key issues such as economic hardship, persisting intergenerational inequality, failure in governance and rampant corruption is inspiring; but they have also expressed anger, disappointment and pessimism. The multitude of youth protests embody an increased sentiment of betrayal by the generation in power over insufficient action on social and climate justice, political change and corruption. COVID-19 has added a new criticality to youth disillusionment with their dire economic outlook, missed educational opportunities and disapproval of government emergency response. These confrontations and the associated potential disruptions could become constant if the underlying causes are left unaddressed.

Limited economic and educational prospects are likely to exacerbate youth frustrations. The compounding trends of lower intergenerational mobility and widening socio-economic inequalities, exacerbated by the COVID-19 crisis, have markedly deteriorated youth’s mental health. Loneliness and anxiety among youth in developed economies had already been described as an “epidemic”, but since the start of the coronavirus pandemic, mental health has deteriorated for 80% of children and young people across the globe.

Such discontent risks exploitation by reactionary actors. Prolonged lockdown loneliness and job loss stresses—resulting in higher rates of depression, anxiety, and post-traumatic stress disorder (PTSD)—could make youths more susceptible to alluring but divisive ideas in developed economies. More radical youth movements could lead to heightened inter-generational tensions and deepen societal fragmentation along new fault lines. “Social cohesion erosion” compounded by “youth disillusionment”—critical short-term threats to the world in the GRPS—would challenge fragile national institutions or even destabilize political and economic systems altogether.

At the same time, dire prospects for economic and social mobility will likely force more young workers to migrate abroad in search of better opportunities—adding to the current 31 million youth migrants across the world. This would induce the real brain drain of the 21st century. However, young migrant workers could see such opportunities diminished if stricter migration policies implemented during the pandemic are slow to relax or become permanent in receiving countries.

Passing the baton

115 The pandemic has exposed youth's vulnerability to widespread economic and societal shocks. Political and economic systems will need to adapt globally to directly address youth's needs and minimize the risk of a lost generation. Investment in improving education sectors and in upskilling and reskilling, ensuring adequate social protection schemes, closing the gender gap and addressing mental health scars should be at the centre of the recovery process.

120 New ways of learning have the potential to be more inclusive, adaptive and comprehensive, enabling students to develop 21st century skills such as creativity, innovation and advanced inter-personal skills. However, it is more critical than ever for the public and the private sector to invest jointly in ensuring connectivity for all youth. Given the fast-changing nature of the job market, more investment is also needed in vocational and on-the-job training. Investment in educational technology must be
125 accompanied by adaptations of the physical educational infrastructure so schools can continue to offer in-person services while harnessing the potential of the Fourth Industrial Revolution.

The current crisis has also revealed and exacerbated gender inequalities in education and work. Recognizing this gap is the first step in closing it. Schools and employers need to adopt measures to close the gender gap, such as adopting flexible and remote work, ensuring that young women can
130 return to school or the workplace after lengthy absences for caregiving, and implementing support programmes for victims of gender-based violence.

The mental and physical health situations of youths need to be addressed from the outset of economic and societal recovery to minimize the yet-unknown long-term effects of the pandemic and its consequences. The digital leap forward and emerging digital tools can increase youth accessibility to
135 support measures and reduce the stigmatization of mental health issues originating from these chaotic and uncertain times.

Beyond these short-term investments, more needs to be done in the long run. Young people are demanding more egalitarian, equitable and sustainable societies, yet they continue to face unnecessary barriers and blocked pathways. Channels must be strengthened to enable youth to make
140 their voices heard in all levels of government, on company boards and in multilateral organizations—which will in turn foster an intergenerational transfer of experience, knowledge and skills; serve as a bridge builder against societal frictions; and decrease youth frustrations. Youth must be guaranteed a say in the global recovery. Failure to ensure youth a seat at the table risks entire societal and economic systems being rejected by this generation.

For discussion/reflection:

1. What are the authors implying by the use of the phrase "employment 'ice age'" (line 9)?
2. Explain why the authors warn that 'hard-fought societal wins could be obliterated' (lines 12-13) in the context of the Global Risks Perception Survey findings that 'youth disillusionment' would become a serious threat (line 11).
3. Critique whether the government response here in Singapore in terms of re-opening schools after the outbreak of Covid-19 was similarly 'ineffective' or 'slow' (line 20). What are some possible explanations for a sluggish government response?
4. The authors suggest that 'the absence of digital connectivity, adult support or adequate space' (lines 24-25) affected the ability of some youth to cope with school closures due to the pandemic. In the context of a similar group of youth in Singapore, what other factors can you think of that reduce students' ability to learn without physically going to school?
5. According to the authors, youth tend to fill jobs in the 'gig' economy, or the 'informal [job] market' (line 42 & 43). Why is this phenomenon undesirable?

6. Who are the 'pandemics', and what do the authors mean by describing them as the 'double lost generation of the 21st century' (line 59)?
7. The authors believe that there is an 'increased sentiment of betrayal by the generation in power' (lines 90-91) amongst the youth. Identify as many real-world examples as you can, of such a sentiment being expressed.
8. In the last section (lines 114-141), a number of solutions to mitigate the risks faced by the 'pandemics' are offered. Identify the solution that is likely to have the greatest impact, and explain why this is the case.

Related Cambridge/RI essay questions:

1. To what extent do young people have a significant voice in political affairs? (RI Y6 Timed Practice 2020)
2. To what extent are young people in your country prepared for the future? (RI Y5 Timed Practice)
3. 'Young people today think of nothing but themselves.' Is this a fair description? (RI Y6 Prelim 2014)
4. With reference to the developments in the world today, to what extent would you agree that the future holds much promise for young people? (RI Y6 CT1 2013)

SECTION D: INTER-GENERATIONAL ISSUES & AGEING

Reading 19: What is 'lying flat', and why are Chinese officials standing up to it?

EU 2, 5 & 6

Ji Siqi, He Huifeng, and Brian Peach | SCMP | 24 October 2021

This reading helps you understand:

- How/why the 'lying flat' phenomenon is an attempt, chiefly amongst younger Chinese, to provide a counter-narrative to the 'Chinese dream' ideology championed by the government
- Why this mindset of striving for no more than what is utterly necessary to secure one's survival has resonated amongst ordinary Chinese youth, mainly as a form of resistance against the perceived false promise of attaining success through hard work
- Why the movement is seen by the government as a huge threat not just in terms of a stagnating economy, but also overall demographic and mental well-being of Chinese society, as well as sociopolitical stability
- Specific vulnerabilities that the Chinese society has that makes the 'lying flat' movement more worrying compared to similar trends seen in other advanced economies like the US and Japan

"Lying flat" is a movement about doing nothing. And that makes it about everything. For months, the chatter surrounding lying flat, or tang ping, has permeated Chinese society, sowed discourse and become ubiquitous enough to finally warrant a public condemnation by President Xi Jinping. "It is necessary to prevent the stagnation of the social class, unblock the channels for upward social mobility, create opportunities for more people to become rich, and form an environment for improvement in which everyone participates, avoiding involution and lying flat," Xi said in comments published on October 15 by the Communist Party's flagship journal on political theory, Qiushi. His words address a trend that strikes at the very heart of his "Chinese dream" ideology, which he has described as the "great rejuvenation of the Chinese nation".

So what does 'lying flat' mean?

"Lying flat" essentially means doing the bare minimum to get by, and striving for nothing more than what is absolutely essential for one's survival. It represents the mindset of lying down instead of being a productive member of society. Rather than striving to study hard, buy a home, or even start a family, a subsection of society is rejecting it all to lie flat. Some have dubbed it a manifesto against materialism, some suspect it is simply being lazy, and others say this type of defeatist attitude is an inevitable result when people become so overwhelmed and dismayed by the notion of working themselves to the bone that they feel there is no other option but to give up.

Where did 'lying flat' come from?

Unlike many buzzwords that have come before it, "lying flat" does not represent a new fad. But a viral online post in April 2021 brought it to the forefront of many minds, especially the younger generation, and it has since gained immense traction in China. On the Baidu Tieba social media platform, a man named Luo Huazhong, in his mid-twenties, wrote about how he had embraced this lifestyle of minimalism for two years. "Life is just lying down, lying down and lying down," he said in the post, titled "Lying flat is justice". Luo explained how he was living a low-desire, zero-pressure lifestyle without stable employment, while staying with his parents in Zhejiang province. When he was feeling up for it, he would travel three hours to Dongyang, Zhejiang, where the world's largest film studio is located. He found work there that he considered perfect – acting as a dead body in movies. His post included a picture of himself lying down, dressed in an ancient Chinese assassin costume for one of his roles. The photo and post spread like wildfire online. "When I say lying flat, I don't mean that I just lie down every day and don't do anything," Luo later said in media interviews. "Lying flat is a state of mind – that is, I feel that many things are not worthy of my attention and energy."

Why has lying flat resonated with ordinary Chinese?

30 Similar stories about unmotivated Chinese youth have also circulated in the past. One involved a group of young migrant workers who self-mockingly called themselves the “Sanhe gods” and would roam around the Sanhe area of Shenzhen’s Longhua district. Having grown tired of working long hours in factories for little pay, they instead took occasional one-off jobs as labourers and received cash for a day’s work.

35 Their motto was, “With one day’s pay, you can have fun for three days.” They slept in public parks, ate instant noodles and spent time in internet bars until they ran out of money. But local authorities eventually cracked down on the “Sanhe gods”, and their story never gained the type of notoriety nor longevity that “lying flat” has.

40 In the internet era when countless posts feature complaints and gripes about personal struggles and the hardships of life, the concept of lying flat stands out because of its philosophical undertones that serve not as a call to action, but to inaction.

45 “Since there has never really been an ideological trend exalting human subjectivity in this land, I shall create it for myself,” Luo said. “Lying down is my wise-man movement.” The ethos struck a chord with much of China’s young and disenchanted workforce that has been hit particularly hard by the nation’s economic slowdown, trade tensions with the West and the coronavirus pandemic.

50 This followed years of being spoon-fed the rose-tinted propaganda of Xi’s “Chinese dream” with the promise of a bright future for the nation and a “better life” for themselves. It became especially hard to swallow for the millions who have slaved away in China “996” culture of overwork – meaning shifts from 9am to 9pm, six days a week – and still cannot afford a home, much less achieve a happy work-life balance. And an increasing number have lost the motivation to even try.

What risks does lying flat pose to China?

From white-collar workers in China’s bustling cities to university students, an army of frustrated young people took to social media and internet message boards in recent months to declare themselves “lying flat youth”.

55 And across the country, T-shirts printed with “Do nothing lie flat youth” have become hot selling items. Authorities have been scrambling to suppress the phenomenon, fearing that it could challenge the established social and economic order.

In the long run, lying flat could not only affect Chinese consumption and growth, but also lower the birth rate that is already eating up the country’s demographic dividend and threatening its social welfare system, according to economists and social commentators.

60 Psychologists and doctors also warn that prolonged inactivity raises the risk of life-threatening physical and mental disorders, including heart disease and depression.

65 It is easy to understand the anxiety of Chinese authorities over the lying-flat attitude, said Dr Gavin Sin Hin Chiu, an independent commentator and former associate professor at Shenzhen University. “If it becomes widespread, it will affect young people’s expectations of income growth, consumption, marriage and childbirth, which will be detrimental to China’s ability to avoid the middle-income trap, where growth stagnates and incomes stall,” he said.

President Xi's call for a society "in which everyone participates", and his insistence that people not lie flat, was publicised just three days before authorities announced that China's gross domestic product growth during the third quarter of this year slowed to just 4.9 per cent, compared with a year earlier. China's economy had staged an impressive recovery from the impact of the coronavirus, but is now faced with numerous headwinds, including a property slump, energy crisis, weak consumer sentiment and soaring raw material costs.

The lying-flat trend also appeared to reach its zenith in the third quarter.

Additionally, Xi's latest comments fleshed out his concept of "common prosperity", saying it was time for China to advance its goal of all citizens sharing in the opportunity to be wealthy.

But he also said government officials at all levels should not make promises they cannot keep, and must avoid the "trap of welfarism" to support the lazy.

"Only by promoting common prosperity, increasing the income of urban and rural residents, and improving human capital can we increase overall productivity and consolidate the foundations for high-quality development," the Qiushi article quoted him as saying. "China must prevent polarisation, promote common prosperity and achieve social harmony and stability."

Is China censoring the lying-flat movement?

The "Great Firewall" is doing its best to keep people from talking about lying flat. When censors realised how popular Luo's original post was becoming, it was scrubbed from the internet. However, copies quickly spread online, sparking lively discussions and videos – many of which garnered millions of views each. But they, too, have since been deleted.

Authorities have used all of the tools at their disposal to steer the social narrative back toward the official line. State-backed media outlets helped lead the charge. Nanfang Daily called the trend "shameful". Hu Xijin, editor-in-chief of the nationalistic Global Times tabloid, said: "Young people are the hope of this country. Neither they themselves, nor the country, will allow them to collectively lie flat."

Analysts say that the idea of people doing nothing is particularly jarring for Chinese authorities, as it reflects a sort of silent rebellion that cannot easily be quashed. Quelling protests in the streets is one thing, but getting millions of individuals out of their beds and forcing them to engage in society is entirely different.

The censorship and preaching have, in some cases, sparked heated backlash and lent credence to the movement, particularly in the eyes of people who struggle to simply earn a living. Analysts at Nomura, in the financial services group's special report on Asia in August, said they believe that the wealth-inequality issue will continue to be a growing concern among China's leaders for years to come.

"Falling social mobility, as a result of widening wealth inequality, is sowing the seeds of discontent, especially among younger people, who have higher expectations after observing the vast amounts of wealth accumulated in cities," the report said. "This kind of disenchantment and dissatisfaction is only likely to worsen with the expected slowdown in economic growth. The lying-flat movement, which calls on young people to opt out of the struggle for workplace success and to resist the attractions of consumer fulfilment, is a direct extension of this discontent."

Do people lie flat in the United States and elsewhere?

105 At John F. Kennedy's presidential inauguration in 1961, he inspired Americans to see the importance
of civic action and public service. The JFK Library says his historic words, "Ask not what your country
can do for you – ask what you can do for your country", challenged everyone to contribute in some
way to the public good. This call came after the so-called Beat Generation movement prompted
110 people – dubbed beatniks – to rebel against conformity and traditional lifestyles in the 1950s. "Beat"
was initially slang for "beaten down".

In the 1990s, the United Kingdom classified a growing group of people as NEET – an acronym for "Not
in Education, Employment or Training", and it included those who were unemployed and not looking
for work. Around 2010, the "Satori generation" was coined in Japan to describe young people who
were seemingly free from material desires and no longer wanted to work.

115 And a few years ago, South Korea had its "Sampo generation", referring to those who had given up on
romantic relationships, marriage and having children. Eventually, the generation's name evolved to
include a disinterest in employment, home ownership, interpersonal relationships and even hope.
"It's not new across the world to see youth of different generations and different nations losing their
motivation to strive for a better life, while turning against materialism and forgoing regular jobs and
120 careers," Dr Chiu said.

But the trend is more worrying in China than in other countries, he explained, because China's
economic development is not as advanced. "The significant difference is that [similar] movements
occurred when the United States and Japan had already entered the stage of advanced economies,
with per capita disposable income much higher than the current level in China," he said. "China is now
125 at a crossroads of becoming a high-income economy or finding itself stuck in the middle-income trap.
The lying-flat movement would negatively affect China's efforts to escape the middle-income trap."
So it's little wonder that Xi and the rest of China's leadership are so intent on stamping out this lying-
flat ethos that has become such an outsized threat.

For discussion/reflection:

- In what ways might the 'rose-tinted propaganda of Xi's "Chinese dream" ' (line 46) have contributed to the lying flat movement?
- What positive outcomes might come out of the 'lying flat' movement? Consider this from the perspective of different groups/stakeholders, such as young Chinese, the older generations of Chinese, and the Chinese government.
- Based on lines 54-66, what might be the adverse impacts of 'lying flat'?
- The author suggests that the Chinese authorities are doing what they can to 'keep people from talking about lying flat' (line 82). How might this do more harm than good in terms of shaping young Chinese's beliefs and values and their understanding of the government's duty of care?
- Do you think this movement will resonate with Singaporeans, particularly among the younger generation? Why or why not?

Related Cambridge/RI essay questions:

1. Assess the extent to which different age groups in your society are valued equally. (Cambridge 2022)
2. 'People today do not work as hard as they did in the past.' How true is this of your society? (Cambridge 2018)
3. 'Work-life harmony is a myth.' How far is this true of your society today? (RI Y5 Promo 2020)
4. 'Young people today think of nothing but themselves.' Is this a fair description? (RI 2014 Y6 Prelim 2014)

SECTION D: INTER-GENERATIONAL ISSUES & AGEING

Reading 20: South Korea is No Country for Young People

EU 1-4 & 6

Katrin Park | Foreign Policy | 5 November 2021

This reading will help you understand:

- How serious a problem depression and suicide is amongst young people in South Korea, a problem that has only been exacerbated by the Covid-19 pandemic
- The economic policies and disparities, as well as cultural undercurrents that are contributing to rapidly escalating rates of depression in this group
- That widespread unhappiness amongst young voters have precipitated large swings of political support between the political incumbent and main opposition party
- Possible ways forward to cope with the mental epidemic
- The simmering tensions that exists between the older and younger Koreans, particularly in regard to the former's perception of the latter's lack of resilience

The ultra-violent Netflix survival drama *Squid Game* is a sensational dramatisation of despair in South Korea, a country that's obsessed with youth and where K-pop and K-beauty stars shine from TVs and billboards—two industries fueled by the glamour of the young. In *Squid Game*, debt-ridden individuals sign up to participate in children's games that could cost them their lives for a chance to win more than \$38 million. It's an utterly dystopian and factionalised take on South Korean society. But its mixture of youth and despair resonated in the country, where suicide has been the number one cause of death for young people since 2007.

For the past two decades, it has had the highest suicide rate among developed nations: 24.6 suicides for every 100,000 people in South Korea in 2019, compared to 14.5 suicides in the United States in 2017. Although South Korea's older adults are still the most likely to die by suicide due to poverty and isolation, young people are rapidly dying by suicide. Between 2018 and 2019, the number of South Koreans under age 40 who took their own lives rose by 10 percent, according to the Korea National Statistics Office.

At the core of this despair are economic woes, worsened by the pandemic. South Koreans in their 20s and 30s have long felt limited by the gap between the haves and the have-nots. They call the country "Hell Joseon," likening it to an infernal kingdom one can only escape through death or emigration. A college degree used to guarantee a job—perhaps not the most well-paying or fancy job but a job, nonetheless. This is no longer the case.

Even before COVID-19, the unemployment rate for young people was nearly three times the national average. In the midst of the pandemic in November 2020, almost 40 percent of new college graduates gave up their searches for new jobs. An epic housing crisis in the capital area, where nearly half the South Korean population lives, has made matters worse. The average price of an apartment in Seoul has doubled in the past five years under the current government's misguided policies on mortgage rules and tax penalties. Four years ago, it would have taken 11 years' worth of South Korea's median annual household income to buy an apartment in Seoul. Now, it costs more than 18 years' worth of income. Rents have shot up, leaving young people with limited savings and without a shelter.

The number of people in their 20s experiencing depression has nearly doubled over the past five years. Yet seeking therapy is difficult in a culture that sees it as a sign of weakness. In fact, even though almost 30 percent of South Koreans suffer from mental illnesses like depression and alcohol abuse at some point in their lives, only 15.3 percent seek treatment.

Then there's the constant pressure and endless competition like the brutal educational race that begins in kindergarten. One in three middle and high school students in Seoul have thought of suicide because of academic burdens and worries over their futures and careers, according to the National Youth Policy Institute. It's no wonder South Korea nearly tops the ranks in raising the world's unhappiest children.

When the Korean War ended in 1953, poverty was widespread. But because everyone was poor, there was less inequality. Most important, there was hope for the future—for example, the miners and nurses who went to West Germany in the 1960s and 1970s to toil in coal mines and hospitals knew their children back home would have a better life. Rapid economic growth, unfortunately, hasn't translated into shared prosperity. The housing crisis hasn't affected young people born into wealth as they pay for houses in cash or let apartments sit empty rather than rent them out at a low price.

In 2017, a record number of young voters elected Moon Jae-in for president when he promised to create a fair and just society where anyone willing to work hard could own a home and raise a family. This has not happened. Corruption among the elite has continued. Government officials benefited from the housing crisis through rent hikes and land speculation. The justice minister was indicted for bribery and fraud. One of the charges included illegally getting his daughter admitted to a university—a sore point since a university admission scandal was at the start of the corruption scandal that toppled Moon's predecessor.

Bleak prospects and social immobility have driven young people to the main opposition conservative party, delivering them landslide victories in April's mayoral elections. Sensing a youth revolt against Moon, the opposition party quickly chose a 36-year-old former entrepreneur as its leader, which would have been unthinkable a few years ago given his youth and inexperience.

"Suicide has become a global crisis. And financial distress, like debt, unemployment, and lower income, can significantly raise suicide risk," said Eric Elbogen, professor of psychiatry and behavioral sciences at Duke University, whose research found a significant association between cumulative financial strain and increased suicide risk in American adults. "Financial strain triggered by the pandemic is critical to consider and poses a risk to elevate rates of suicide, adding to the enormous health consequences of the pandemic. Understanding this link can help bolster suicide prevention efforts."

A more meaningful nod to young people would help them counter the feeling of hopelessness that has engulfed them. Right now, this means boosting social safety nets and hiring not just part-time gigs but full-time jobs with a living wage to give young people a chance. This would give them the confidence to make future plans.

South Korea should also invest in improving young people's mental health. The stigma surrounding mental illness should be removed. South Korea's pop culture dynamo of movies and music can be retooled to raise awareness and encourage treatment—for once, the country would be using its cultural assets to empower its young people rather than exploiting their youthfulness. It can learn from Finland. The Nordic country reduced the number of suicides by half since 1990 using the world's first national suicide prevention campaign. It involved all government agencies to improve treatment and support; it also made the media responsible when reporting on the subject.

Establishing a national mental health system and community-level services as well as training more mental health professionals would be an obvious step forward. At present, mental health makes up around 3 percent of the country's total health budget. For the older generation, an effort to understand how the young feel would go a long way. When a new law reduced the maximum number

75 of weekly working hours from 68 to 52 in 2018 to improve work-life balance, older people lamented it. It was their sweat and tears that raised the country from the ashes of the Korean War. Now, young people who have never known hunger, goes their thinking, are ruining the economy amid mounting debt and global competition. Rather than keeping their head down and working hard, they complain of depression.

80 Perhaps this is not a sign of young people's lack of willpower or strength. Rather, times have changed—and people have changed with it. South Koreans aren't the only ones suffering—but the discrepancy between a rich and culturally successful society and the despair of so many people is particularly painful.

85 In South Korea, support for youth should also extend to celebrities, whom many young people adore and look up to. Just to name a few, in late 2019, young K-pop idol Sulli killed herself, as did singer Goo Hara and actor Cha In-ha. In 2020, actress and model Oh In-hye killed herself. Earlier this year, actress Song Yoo-jung took her own life. A spate of suicides among U.S. cultural icons might have triggered a round of soul-searching. Not in South Korea.

For reflection/discussion:

1. Park describes how it now 'costs more than 18 years' worth of [South Korea's median annual household] income' (lines 25-26) for one to purchase an apartment in Korea. For comparison, how much income does one need to purchase an apartment in Singapore? Carry out appropriate research of your own.
2. Park also reveals how many young Koreans do not seek therapy because it is often seen 'as a sign of weakness' (line 28). Do you think there is a similar perception here? What other local factors do you think there are that might discourage sufferers of mental illnesses here from seeking help?
3. Reflect on Singapore's education system, and identify specific **aspects/elements** that could lead to 'constant pressure and endless competition' (line 31).
4. According to Park, why were people in Korea less unhappy in the past, even though 'poverty was widespread' (line 36)?
5. List and explain another example from other societies whereby 'bleak prospects and social immobility' (line 49) appear to have led to the sudden popularity of political opposition or outsiders. Carry out appropriate research of your own.
6. Park suggests that a lack of understanding is the reason why older Koreans hold the negative sentiment that young people 'are ruining the economy' (line 76) by 'complain[ing] of depression' (lines 77-78). In Singapore, what might be some obstacles – including the older generation's core beliefs and values – that might prevent a better understanding amongst older Singaporeans regarding the challenges young people here face?

Related Cambridge/RI essay questions:

1. Assess the extent to which different age groups in your society are valued equally. (Cambridge 2022)
2. When a government's finances for social welfare are limited, should they be directed towards the young or the old? (Cambridge 2015)
3. 'Poverty is a result of personal failure.' To what extent is this true of your society? (Y6 CT2 2018)
4. How can people in your society learn from its youth? (Y6 CT2 2011)
5. Is too much being expected of today's youth? (Y5 Promo 2011)

SECTION D: INTER-GENERATIONAL ISSUES & AGEING

Reading 21: The faces and insecurities of Singapore's elderly working poor

EU 1, 3, 5 & 6

Kane Cunico, Yvonne Lim & Jade Han | Channel News Asia | 15 May 2017

This reading will help you understand that:

- An ageing population has traditionally been viewed as a problem because fewer people are working and paying taxes.
- Despite this view, there are companies that are benefiting from an ageing population.

As Singapore ages, the number of seniors who work into their silver years is growing too – especially among the lower-income group, for whom retirement is an alien concept. In recent years they have become more visible as food court cleaners, servers, security guards, tissue-sellers and scrap collectors.

- 5 Given Singapore's plethora of help schemes for the needy – such as the Pioneer Generation Package (PGP) and Silver Support Scheme for the old – why do the elderly poor feel the need to work for long hours and often low pay? Do the jobs that the elderly poor do, as well as society's safety nets, offer them adequate sense of security and quality of life in their old age?

Relative poverty rising among the working elderly

- 10 In a 2015 paper on elderly poverty in Singapore written for the Tsao Foundation, Assistant Professor Ng Kok Hoe of the Lee Kuan Yew School of Public Policy made one surprising observation – while the poverty rate among elderly persons not working had fallen over the years, that for elderly persons in the workforce appeared to have actually increased dramatically.

The poverty rate among the working elderly jumped from 13 per cent in 1995, to 28 per cent in 2005, to 41 per cent in 2011.

- 15 “This should be a strong reminder that work cannot be relied upon as the only, or even the primary, response to income insecurity in old age,” Dr Ng wrote. “In labour markets where older workers are likely to end up in low-paying and undesirable jobs, work may decrease their quality of life without raising their standard of living.”

- 20 According to Manpower Ministry figures, in 2016 about 23 per cent of persons over 65 in the formal workforce were earning less than S\$1,000 a month. That's less than the 36 per cent in 2013, and 57 per cent in 2003, indicating that earnings for elderly workers have been rising.

But inflation and wages in the rest of society have also risen. And Dr Ng's calculation draws the comparison between the elderly and the general population. It uses 40 per cent of the median population work income as a “convenient poverty line”, and compares that to elderly individuals' incomes (which, besides work, could include sources such as children and state assistance).

- 25 Overall, Dr Ng has estimated that 6 in 10 elderly people in Singapore in 2011 were poor by that measurement. He acknowledges that what is considered poor “is debatable”, and notes that a project commissioned by the Tsao Foundation is looking into how much elderly households actually need for a decent standard of living in Singapore. (Singapore has no official statistics when it comes to elderly poverty, or poverty for that matter.)

Why work?

- 30 “In Singapore, no money how to live?” is what Mr Ong Hock Soon says if asked why he is working long hours as a hawker's assistant at the age of 69. But in the same breath, he'll tell you that he has turned

down offers of social assistance, and would rather be self-reliant and “work until cannot move”. That mentality of independence is something that crops up repeatedly among the working elderly.

35 Ms Nurasyikin Amir once thought like most people – that seniors should stop going around collecting heavy loads of cardboard. “Like, rest at home, you’re old, retired already,” said the volunteer with the Happy People Helping People Foundation, which assists cardboard collectors.

“But what we came to realise is that when they collect boxes, they feel more empowered; they are earning their own money, even though it’s not much, maybe S\$2, up to S\$10 a day. Who are we to stop them, right?” she said.

40 Some don’t want to be a burden on their children. Like food-court cleaner Wong Yeow Kee, 85, who works a 3pm to 11pm shift. “I have children, but I like to smoke and drink, so I work to support my habit and enjoy life. I don’t want to ask for their money.”

45 Indeed, there are those receiving financial assistance who still do the occasional odd job to “find meaning in life”, said Mr Ng Koon Sing, head of COMNET Senior Services under AMKFSC Community Services.

But yet others do it out of “insecurity” and fear that “the money will run out”, he also noted. Many would have worked at low-paying jobs most of their lives, with modest or hardly any savings which illness and vices like gambling can quickly wipe out.

The catch-22² of low-wage work

The limited job opportunities for an elderly person with little education is what concerns observers.

50 The older they get, those who previously held blue-collar jobs would find themselves even lower down the workforce rung, noted Dr John Donaldson, who has written on poverty in Singapore. “One could have been a welder in their younger years, but today, they have to downgrade and become a cleaner,” said the Associate Professor of Political Science at the Singapore Management University.

55 But wheels have been in motion to bolster the earnings of older workers. The Government’s roll-out of the Progressive Wage Model has scaled up incomes in the cleaning, landscape and security sectors –where low-wage older folks tend to gravitate. Then there is the Workfare supplement, paid by the State to top up the wages of eligible low-income older workers.

The hitch? Those doing informal work don’t benefit. And manual jobs carry the element of uncertainty, often depending on health.

60 Take Madam Lee Yuit Mei, 67, who has osteoporosis. She used to earn S\$800-S\$1,000 as a full-time cleaner, but after breaking her wrist in a fall in 2010, she switched to working part-time. She now makes just S\$350 a month working three-hour days, four times a week. But with savings squirreled away over the years, she can meet her living expenses, she says.

Too many sets of hoops?

65 For those less lucky and in need of temporary financial aid, there is the ComCare Short to Medium Term Assistance scheme. Those aged 55 and over made up about 35 per cent of applicants in 2015 – up from 29 per cent in 2012. Indeed, the problem in Singapore is not the lack of schemes to help the elderly poor – as, say, compared to other countries in the region featured earlier in this series*.

² This is defined as a situation in which the solution to a problem is impossible because it is also the cause of the problem (Cambridge Dictionary)

Said Mr Simon-Peter Lum, assistant manager of COMNET Senior Services under AMKFSC Community Services: “We’d be hard-pressed to find seniors who are the abject poor, compared to other countries.”
70 For instance, those on Public Assistance may not get a lot of cash upfront, which has often been noted by critics – but, Mr Lum pointed out, they get many other subsidies (such as for medical treatment) and fee waivers (such as rental).

The problem, rather, is that there are too many targeted help schemes – with varying criteria and limiting conditions attached, observers say. This creates two types of problems. One: Confusion and
75 lack of understanding, which might explain why some elderly poor would rather just carry on working than attempt to seek support. Said Dr Ng: “Researchers don’t understand the schemes fully, civil servants don’t often understand all the schemes available, so how would those people know where to get the help?”

Two: Having to jump through hoops to meet criteria, means that some will fall through the cracks.
80 Take the requirement that applicants don’t have children who can support them. Said Ms Nurasyikin: “Just because they have kids, it doesn’t mean that they are taken care of... But (applicants) don’t get the assistance just because the database shows that they have kids.”

The further danger, said Dr Ng, is that such rigorous means-testing would “discourage others who might actually qualify if they tried”. Ms Wong Yock Leng, a senior social worker with Tsao Foundation,
85 said: “When you ask for ComCare assistance, they will check for everything... That’s why a lot of people don’t apply anymore after that. It’s so daunting, the whole process.”

To read, watch and learn more on the elderly poor in other societies, go to:
<https://www.channelnewsasia.com/news/cnainsider/elderly-poverty-series>

For discussion/reflection:

1. Explain what Dr Ng means when he says ‘work cannot be relied upon as the only, or even the primary, response to income insecurity in old age’ (lines 14-15).
2. Why do you think there are no official statistics for poverty in Singapore (see lines 28-29)?
3. What are the reasons raised in the article for why the elderly carry on working? Can you offer possible explanations for the apparent contradictions?
4. Why is low-wage work a ‘Catch-22’, particularly for the elderly in Singapore?
5. Summarise the authors’ main criticisms of the nature of assistance schemes in Singapore, which might make them less effective. Reflect on the possible rationales for designing the assistance schemes this way.

Related Cambridge/RI essay questions:

1. Assess the extent to which different age groups in your society are valued equally. (Cambridge 2022)
2. Longer life expectancy creates more problems than benefits. Discuss. (Cambridge 2016)
3. Consider the view that longer life expectancy is always desirable. (RI Y6 Prelim 2019)
4. To what extent is ageism a problem in your society? (RI Y5 CT 2021)
5. Evaluate the claim that too much has been done for the elderly in your society. (RI Y5 Common Essay Assignment 2021)
6. Should the responsibility of taking care of the elderly fall solely on the government? (RI Y6 CT1 2019)
7. ‘Retirement is a redundant word today.’ To what extent is this true? (RI Y6 CT2 2011)
8. To what extent is raising the retirement age a necessary evil in today’s society? (RI Y5 Promo 2010)

SECTION E: ISSUES TO DO WITH WORK AND EMPLOYMENT

The resurgence of the BLM movement in 2020, particularly following the murder of George Floyd, acted as a catalyst for many organisations to introspect and address racial disparities within their structures. This period saw a significant increase in corporate commitments to DEI, with companies pledging to implement programmes aimed at fostering inclusive environments and addressing systemic biases. These initiatives often included hiring DEI officers, setting diversity targets, and investing in training programmes.

Reading 22: What comes after the DEI backlash?

EU 4 & 5

Abdallah Fayyad / Vox / 18 February 2025 [adapted]

This article will help you to:

- Understand the historical roots of diversity, equity, and inclusion (DEI) programmes
- Understand the backlash against DEI under the Trump administration
- Reflect on the strengths and weaknesses of DEI initiatives

In recent months, the attacks on diversity, equity, and inclusion policies have been unrelenting. Since Donald Trump’s win in November, several major companies — including McDonald’s, Target, Amazon, and Meta — have announced that they’re either scaling back or outright ending their DEI programs. And since Trump returned to the White House, his administration has been dismantling all DEI programs across the federal government.

The assault has been so aggressive that at one point the Trump administration seemed to just be scrapping all references to the words “diversity,” “equity,” and “inclusion” on government websites and handbooks, even in cases where they don’t actually refer to DEI programming. [According to the Wall Street Journal](#), that included deleting references like the “inclusion” of identification numbers on tax forms.

But despite the efforts of Republicans to turn DEI into a battlefield for the culture wars, DEI practices are nothing new. In fact, they trace their roots to the civil rights movement and have long been a part of corporate America, let alone organizations in the public sector. Their goal is to build fairer workplaces by focusing on things like diversity in hiring or reducing discrimination — [creating opportunities](#) that otherwise might not exist for qualified people from marginalized backgrounds.

The backlash against DEI has had measurable consequences. In 2023, for example, the Supreme Court ended affirmative action, and since then, enrollment of Black and Latino students at universities has [declined](#). Republicans have also started using the phrase “DEI” as a slur.

Understanding the history of DEI — how it came to be, as well as its strengths and weaknesses — can help us figure out how we got to this point, and, for organizations that are actually still interested in promoting diversity and fairness in the workplace, where we can go from here.

The origins of DEI

While diversity programs have faced some push and pull, until recently, they were largely cemented as a mostly uncontroversial feature of the American workplace.

Before they were known as DEI, these programs started as a civil rights era push toward integration. In the 1960s, President John F. Kennedy signed an executive order that required federal contractors

to take active steps to ensure that they don't discriminate against applicants or employees based on race, creed, color, or national origin. This was followed by the Civil Rights Act of 1964 — signed into law by President Lyndon B. Johnson — which banned all companies with more than 15 employees from engaging in discrimination when it came to practices like job training, hiring, compensation, promotion, and termination. In the late 1960s and early 1970s, some businesses started to go to greater lengths to avoid discrimination suits or bad press.

When President Ronald Reagan came into office, he pushed for cutting a lot of red tape. That included threatening to roll back affirmative action laws and advocating that discrimination within companies should be dealt with internally instead of being litigated in the courts. But companies and their employees had already started believing in their diversity programs, and Reagan received pushback from Democrats and Republicans, businesses and civil rights activists alike. In fact, most major companies said that they would keep their diversity programs regardless of whether they were required to.

Around the same time, corporate America started settling on a new case for improving diversity in the workplace: It wasn't just the morally right thing to do, it was also good for business. The demographics of the labor force were quickly changing, and so companies developed a renewed interest in promoting diversity and inclusion in order to maintain a competitive advantage.

All of this laid the foundation for the DEI programs that are being attacked today. "We kind of came to this idea that diversity is going to happen, and as a result, we need to be able to manage it correctly," said Lily Zheng, a diversity and inclusion strategist and consultant. "So this spawned a whole bunch of diversity training, racial sensitivity training, gender inclusion training to prepare the modern workforce for what was meant to be this huge influx of diversity."

In the 2010s, the rise of social movements like Black Lives Matter and Me Too led to a boom in hiring diversity czars and consultants, and many organizations, from fashion brands to academic institutions, pushed PR campaigns that included diversity pledges. In 2020, after the murder of George Floyd, organizations showed a renewed interest in promoting diversity because of the public pressure to do the right thing.

But even before the swift retreat from DEI after Trump's election win, it seemed like the so-called racial reckoning many employers promised never really materialized — and now companies are trying to pretend their commitments to diversity never really happened.

The shortcomings of DEI

While there isn't comprehensive data across the labor force to evaluate the impact of DEI programs broadly, studies that focus on different components of diversity programs have shown mixed results.

"If we look at the big picture, what kinds of things have been effective at actually helping firms to hire and retain a more diverse workforce, they're not the things that are designed to target individual bias at companies," said Frank Dobbin, a social science professor at Harvard University who has studied corporate diversity programs.

Those kinds of initiatives include things like implicit bias training, which seeks to help people become aware of their own biases and figure out how to limit their negative impact, or grievance procedures, where employees can file complaints against their managers or other people in their organizations for discrimination or harassment.

These programs have been very popular among companies, in part because they're a low lift and relatively low cost. The problem is that they aren't all that effective and, in some cases, might have

unintended consequences. Implicit bias training, for example, tends to make participants defensive rather than open to change. Even when people want to do better, few people think that they actively make racist decisions, and so they don't necessarily think the training applies to them.

"These trainings and grievance procedures, they're really designed to show people that they're biased and change their ways either through education in the case of training or punishment in the case of grievance procedures," Dobbin said. But in practice, those processes, Dobbin says, tend to antagonize people in management, especially white men.

This approach of seeing the problem as individual behaviors and beliefs as opposed to the structure and processes of an organization has been one of the [critical failures of DEI](#). That's created what some have called the "[DEI-industrial complex](#)." In fact, DEI training has swelled into an \$8 billion industry, allowing employers to pat themselves on the back for spending time and money on surface-level diversity programming like hiring consultants or public speakers for their employees, while not investing in an actual long-term strategy that would tangibly improve working conditions and address systemic barriers to entry that women and people of color face.

"Companies always want to pay for their flashy speakers, for their award ceremonies, for their external-facing communications or heritage month activities and very little is actually spent on doing things like addressing discrimination, ensuring fair pay, or creating healthy workplace processes," Zheng said. "And that's a problem because these sorts of deeper investments are what's actually needed if we want to create workplaces that are more fair, that are more equitable, that are better for everyone."

What's worth keeping from DEI?

When people think of DEI, they often think about diversity training or job titles like chief diversity officer. But sometimes, the best diversity and inclusion initiatives are much less flashy.

In the mid-2000s, a blockbuster study showed that employers are much less likely to give applicants with Black-sounding names a callback than applicants with white-sounding names. Twenty years later, researchers at the University of California Berkeley and the University of Chicago did a similar study, and while the results showed that companies had improved, applicants with Black-sounding names are [still less likely to get an interview](#).

The researchers found that the companies that were less likely to discriminate had something surprisingly simple in common: centralized processes and standards. Correlation, of course, is not causation, but that pattern shouldn't be dismissed.

"When hiring processes are not standardized, when there's no scoring rubric, when hiring managers aren't trained to give consistent results and actually evaluate based on merit, you see people's individual biases really impact the demographics of who ends up ultimately hired," Zheng said. "And so the takeaway is, if you want to fight this bias, one of the simplest things you can do is very mundane: Standardize your hiring process."

Companies can be so focused on diversity in recruiting that they avoid making changes that would help retain employees or draw people to want to work there in the first place. Acknowledging this is part of what changed many companies' approach from just thinking about diversity in hiring to making the workplace more inclusive so that people can advance their careers once their foot is in the door.

Having more objective and standardized processes can reduce the risk of unfair or discriminatory compensation, disciplinary action, or termination. That's why long-term commitments like pay-gap reviews and corrections — or accountability mechanisms like publicly releasing diversity data that

110 would encourage workers to demand more of their employers — can go a long way in promoting diversity in the workplace.

DEI programs have also been criticized for not paying close enough attention to classism. In practice, DEI programs are often the corporate-friendly approach to desegregation, where the C-suites co-opt the language of social justice while doing little, if anything, to meaningfully improve the workplace for everybody. These kinds of programs are often designed to cater to a certain type of background, like college-educated workers, while ignoring class divides that continue to segregate the labor force.

One DEI program that helps address this issue is changing recruiting practices, especially in companies that value graduates of elite colleges, which tend to have mostly upper-middle-class students. By expanding recruitment to all types of schools, including HBCUs, state schools, and two-year colleges, companies are likely to see more racial and class diversity in their applicant pools.

So what should the future of DEI look like?

With the aggressive attacks on DEI coming from the Trump administration and the kind of kowtowing we've seen from big corporations, it's clear that the DEI backlash isn't going away anytime soon. Workers looking to create more inclusive workplaces will have a harder time getting their employers to adopt or expand DEI programs.

125 That's why companies that are actually interested in advancing equality should hone in on what really works — things like standardized hiring processes, pay equity commitments, recruiting from schools outside of Ivy Leagues and the like — and leave the ineffective aspects of DEI behind, including one-off trainings, speaking engagements, and half-hearted heritage month celebrations.

Companies should be data and outcome-oriented — that is, they should figure out what it is, exactly, that needs to be addressed and tailor a solution to address it.

Zheng also says that companies have to think about how to get buy-in from everybody. That kind of coalition building, they said, is crucial to DEI's future success. Oftentimes, the way people talk about DEI makes it sound like one racial group will get preferential treatment — giving ammo to the charge Republicans often levy that companies are simply lowering standards to increase diversity, even when they're not. It's often seen, in other words, as a zero-sum game.

But Zheng suggests that the most successful DEI programs are win-wins, creating better outcomes for everybody, and advocates should focus on that communal aspect to build stronger coalitions. So before throwing out DEI initiatives altogether, companies and organizations that are actually interested in the ideals of diversity and inclusion should consider a more coalitional approach.

140 In the long run, this approach could indeed prove popular. The majority of Americans still think DEI programs are a good thing, though that number has been shrinking, and only a fifth of Americans think that DEI is plain bad. By designing these programs to benefit everyone, and by communicating that to workers across the board, DEI practitioners might garner more support. At the end of the day, Zheng says, "we just need to design systems that are fair."



DEI Case Studies: Southeast Asia

Colin Teo, Ashley Darnell, et al. | Boston Consulting Group | 21 November 2023 [adapted]

1 Standard Chartered Bank launches a financing facility for women entrepreneurs

In 2019, Standard Chartered Bank (SCB) recognized a significant shortage of targeted banking products for women entrepreneurs throughout Southeast Asia. To meet this need, it engaged a cross-functional group of women and men leaders from internal and external teams to design a targeted offering. The bank launched WOWnita, a business financing facility for women entrepreneurs that offers working capital finance loans with lower rates, collateral-free applications, quick approvals, and flexible payment plans. As part of this initiative, SCB Malaysia committed to providing working capital finance of 10 million Malaysian ringgits (approximately \$2.1 million) to women entrepreneurs. Additionally, the product offers networking opportunities through a close engagement with the National Association of Women Entrepreneurs of Malaysia (NAWEM).

Through this offering, SCB has more effectively targeted small and medium-sized enterprises and built a strong link to the Malaysia's growing segment of women entrepreneurs. The product has seen strong uptake and was particularly valuable to women clients during the pandemic, when cash-flow support was critical.

2 Singtel makes its DEI performance public

Singtel is a highly successful telecommunications conglomerate based in Singapore, with revenues of approximately \$10.6 billion and net profit of \$1.5 billion. With over 24,000 employees from nearly 100 nations and a diverse customer base, the firm values DEI as a powerful tool to create positive outcomes for its customers, employees, and communities. The company's DEI efforts are overseen by a dedicated steering committee with an explicit strategy based on inclusion for employees with disabilities such as neurodiversity and gender diversity. These initiatives inform the company's key DEI initiatives and performance metrics.

Each year, Singtel surveys employees about their feelings of inclusion, belonging, and ability to be their authentic selves at work. The data is analyzed across gender, age, and tenure to identify potential gaps. Importantly, as part of its annual sustainability report, Singtel publishes its DEI strategy, key results from the employee survey, and metrics such as representation, retention, recruiting, and access to training. This information is tracked over multiple years, helping the company hold leaders accountable for generating results.

Singtel's efforts have led to positive employee engagement and strong representation of women. The company reports that its Singapore workforce now comprises 45% women, up from 35% in 2022. The company's commitment to gender equality has earned Singtel a place on the Bloomberg Gender Equality Index five years in a row. In the firm's latest survey, 88% of employees say that the work atmosphere is open and welcoming to people from various backgrounds. Singtel takes a step beyond inclusion to ensure that employees feel accepted and valued as part of the Singtel community and connected to the organization's purpose and culture.

3 Ayala expands its DEI lens to include non-traditional aspects of identity

Ayala is the Philippines' oldest conglomerate, with revenues of \$4.6 billion, net profits of \$563.4 million, an employee base of nearly 86,000, and a wide range of businesses, including retail, healthcare, telecommunications, and others. In 2022, the company began a major strategic review in which DEI emerged as a key focus area. The strategic rationale for leaders was clear: Ayala wanted to attract and retain the best talent, encourage employees to be their authentic selves at work, capitalize on a broad variety of opinions and perspectives, and create an inclusive working culture for all.

Ayala's leadership team realized that the company needed to consider aspects of employees' identity beyond traditional demographic metrics such as gender and ethnicity. These include where employees studied, which part of the country they grew up in, and their socioeconomic status.

The company expanded the scope of its HR analytics to capture these dimensions of diversity. It also created a "mirror board"—a committee of young, high-performing talent from different backgrounds—to ensure that perspectives were collected from across the organization. Based on those insights, Ayala revamped its benefits packages, which in the past had allowed only legally recognized dependents to qualify. Under the new approach, employees could share benefits with any family member they chose, regardless of whether they had a legal tie to the employee. The expanded medical eligibility allowed 10% of Ayala's employees to enroll dependents who were not eligible before, which resulted in a 6% increase of the total number of enrolled dependents. These were primarily employees' partners of any gender and parents (up to 75 years old) of Ayala's single employees. Employees appreciated these enhancements as a sign of the company's progressive and inclusive values. Ayala also found that younger employees tend to gravitate toward companies that implement policies that are focused on purpose, diversity, and inclusion and these initiatives resonated particularly well with them.

In addition, Ayala conducted a pay equity audit and expanded its analysis beyond gender to include other factors that may have reflected bias. For example, the results showed that employees with shorter tenures were often getting paid less than longer-tenured colleagues with equivalent responsibilities. The company now undergoes a regular pay-audit cycle with this expanded view of DEI.

Note: Affirmative action vs DEI

- Affirmative Action is a legal policy created to address historical injustices and discrimination by providing opportunities to underrepresented groups. It involves initiative-taking measures to ensure that individuals from these groups have equal access to education, employment, and other areas where they have been historically marginalised. The primary focus is on creating opportunities and levelling the playing field for those who have faced systemic barriers.
- DEI initiatives represent a holistic strategy aimed at cultivating inclusive cultures within organisations. DEI efforts operate on a broader and more holistic level, focusing on creating sustainable cultural change rather than simply addressing representation quotas or targets.

Both are integral to advancing equity and diversity, addressing different facets of systemic inequality.

For discussion/reflection:

1. Do you agree with the author when he says that current 'DEI practices are nothing new' (lines 10-11)?
2. The author critiques many common DEI initiatives for being ineffective or even counterproductive. Think of cases in other areas (e.g. education, healthcare, etc.) where surface-level solutions or policies have been mistaken for real progress. How should the success of policies and initiatives be measured?
3. Zheng argues that DEI programmes should not give the impression that they are 'zero-sum games' (line 136). How can DEI programmes be reframed or redesigned to be more broadly appealing?
4. Consider the Southeast Asian case studies at the end of the article. How do the companies' approaches to DEI compare with the DEI initiatives in the United States?
5. Do research on DEI initiatives in Singapore. To what extent do you think have been successful in improving diversity, equity, and inclusion?

Related Cambridge/RI essay questions:

1. To what extent is human life in general about the survival of the fittest? (Cambridge 2020)
2. To what extent are people judged more by their physical appearance than by their abilities? (Cambridge 2017)
3. In your society, how far is equality for all a reality? (Cambridge 2012)
4. 'Equality for all is only an aspiration.' How far is this true of your society? (Y5 CT 2022)
5. Have our efforts to address discrimination made us overly sensitive? Discuss this in relation to your society. (Y6 Prelim 2021)
6. Is diversity of people and their viewpoints truly celebrated in your society? (Y6 CT 2021)
7. It is surprising that discrimination still exists in the world today.' How far do you agree? (Y5 Timed Practice 2020)
8. Is it ever possible to eliminate stereotypes in society? (Y6 CT2 2012)

SECTION E: ISSUES TO DO WITH WORK AND EMPLOYMENT

Reading 23: Amazon says workers must be in the office. The UK government disagrees. Who is right?

**EU3
& 6**

Tom Espiner | BBC News | 22 September 2024

This article will help you to:

- Consider the competing views on where desk-based employees work best
- Understand the pros and cons of flexible work arrangements from the perspectives of different stakeholders

They are two competing views on where desk-based employees work best.

Amazon is ordering its staff back to the office five days a week, just as the government is pushing for rights to flexible working - including working from home - to be strengthened. The tech giant says employees will be able to better “invent, collaborate, and be connected”.

- 5 But just as the firm’s announcement became news, the UK government was linking flexibility to better performance and a more productive, loyal workforce.

- 10 Few are short of an opinion on how effective working from home is and for a government there are broader considerations such as how, for example, [caring responsibilities](#) are affected. But more than four years since the start of the pandemic, what does the evidence tell us about how we work best and is Amazon right to believe people being in the office full time will allow them to collaborate better?

Amazon’s fellow tech giant Microsoft studied its employees during the pandemic. It looked at the emails, calendars, instant messages and calls of 61,000 of its employees in the US during the first six months of 2020. [The findings were published in Nature Human Behaviour.](#)

- 15 The study indicated that, during Covid, remote workers tended to collaborate more with networks of colleagues they already had, and that they built fewer “bridges” between different networks. There was also a drop in communication that happened in real time - meetings that would have happened in real life weren’t necessarily happening online. Instead, more emails and instant messages were sent. The authors suggested this may make it harder to convey and understand complex information.

Microsoft’s was a data-led study. But what about human experience?

- 20 A 2020 survey by the Chartered Institute of Personnel and Development (CIPD) of 1,000 senior decision-makers in organisations found about a third struggled with “reduced staff interaction and cooperation”. However, more than 40% of the managers said there was more collaboration when people were working from home.

Greater collaboration is hard to object to, but equally it is no guarantee of productivity.

- 25 In 2010, China’s biggest travel agency CTrip tried something very new among staff in its airfare and hotel booking department. Almost 250 staff were identified as potential home workers - they needed to be established at the company and have a proper home working set-up. Around half that group started working from home. The other group stayed office-based. [Researchers at Stanford University found the workers were 13% more productive when working from home](#) - mainly because workers
30 had fewer breaks and sick days, and they could take more calls because it was quieter.

Communication barriers

There was a particularly significant drop in staff quitting for non-managers, women, and people with long commutes, the researchers said.

35 However, those Chinese home-workers were seeing a bit of the office: they were spending one day a week among colleagues. It could be this brought some benefit - a separate study years later from researchers at Stanford suggested fully remote work can lead to a 10% drop in productivity compared with working in the office all the time. Barriers to communication, [lack of mentoring for staff](#), problems building a work culture, and difficulties with self-motivation were all cited.

40 [Amazon is not alone](#) in telling employees to return to the office full-time. Goldman Sachs chief executive David Solomon famously described working from home as an “aberration”. The US firm requires bankers to be in the office five days per week. Rival US banks JPMorgan and Morgan Stanley have also backed workers returning to the office, whereas some banks in Europe have taken a softer approach.

45 Elon Musk’s Tesla also requires employees to be in the office full time, leading to reports of problems finding space for them. Another Musk company, SpaceX, brought in a policy requiring workers to return to the office full-time. But it wasn’t without consequences: when it brought the policy in, SpaceX lost 15% of its senior-level employees, [according to a study published earlier this year](#).

The pandemic changed work routines that were in many cases decades old.

50 Linda Noble, now 62, from Barnsley, was used to putting on a suit and make-up. In 2020 she was a senior officer in local government, scrutinising governance in the fire service and the police service. Then Covid struck and she was working from home.

“I loathed it. I missed the communication - going into work, someone would make you smile,” she says. But with time, Ms Noble adjusted. She set up her home office and she thinks that before long she was twice as productive as previously - even if that was in part because of an inability to switch off.

55 Many disabled people also believe working from home makes them more productive. [A 2023 study](#) of 400 people suggested that disabled workers felt they had more autonomy and control when working from home, which led them to better manage their health and wellbeing, and 85% felt more productive.

Perhaps unsurprisingly, not all studies come to the same conclusions. Some suggest an improvement to physical health from working at home, others disagree. The same goes for mental health.

60 The wellbeing of staff was a key reason one UK business decided to get them back to the office as soon as possible after lockdown restrictions ended, according to one of its directors, Francis Ashcroft.

Part of a team

65 Ashcroft was chief executive of a large private UK children’s care services company. He says, “Some people were struggling with raised anxiety” and wanted to get back to the office “to be part of a team”. He added that there was “also a recognition that 80% of staff were at the coalface”, working in person in children’s homes and education, and so it was “right to come back” for reasons of fairness.

Although team members were collaborating online at 95% of what they had been, “coming back into the office added that 5% back”, he argues. “It brought a realness and a sense of belonging,” Mr Ashcroft says, adding that “when it comes to delivering a service, the teamwork was much better in the office”.

70 Despite this experience, [an umbrella review](#) of home working that examined a range of other studies concluded that, on the whole, working from home boosts how much workers can get done.

What difference there is in approach between the government and Amazon essentially boils down to whether or not some home working should be part of the mix, with Amazon believing it shouldn't.

75 Linda Noble's time solely working from home is over. She is just about to start a hybrid job. She's attracted by the "balance" between working from home and office work.

Reduce churn

According to the CIPD, benefits of hybrid working include "a better work/life balance, greater ability to focus with fewer distractions, more time for family and friends and wellbeing activity, saved commuting time and costs, plus higher levels of motivation and engagement."

80 And it may be that this can reduce staff churn. [A study published this year](#) found that a Chinese firm that adopted hybrid working reduced the rate at which employees quit by a third.

From an employee perspective, the optimum time for hybrid working is three days in the office – this makes employees most engaged, according to [a Gallup survey](#) of US workers, although it also says there is "no one-size-fits-all".

85 In the UK, the number of people exclusively working from home is falling. But, crucially, hybrid working is continuing to rise, running at 27% of the working population.

Gallup says that despite highly publicised moves by firms to get employees back in the office, the underlying trend is that the future of office work is hybrid. This tallies with the position of the UK government, which is clear that it believes the potential to work at home drives up productivity.

90 The calculation by Amazon appears to be that what evidence there is for increased productivity among employees who work in part from home fails to capture the particulars of how they operate.

For discussion/reflection:

1. Identify the different stakeholders mentioned in this article. What are the advantages and disadvantages of flexible work arrangements according to each of them? Which stakeholders would benefit the most from such arrangements?
2. Read more about flexible work in Singapore [here](#). In your view, should flexible work arrangements be seen as a right or a perk in our society?
3. What role should the government play in shaping workplace policies?

Related Cambridge/RI essay questions:

1. 'People today do not work as hard as they did in the past.' How true is this of your society? (Cambridge 2018)
2. Consider the view that some careers are more suited to one gender than the other. (Cambridge 2014)
3. 'Workers today have never had it better.' Is this an accurate view? (Y6 Prelim 2022)
4. Should working from home become the norm in your society? (Y5 CT 2021)
5. 'Work-life harmony is a myth.' How far is this true of your society today? (Y5 Promo 2020)

SECTION E: ISSUES TO DO WITH WORK AND EMPLOYMENT

Reading 24: Job jitters – Why do some worry about jobs when the Singapore labour market is strong?

EU 2, 3 & 6

Goh Yan Han, Ng Wei Kai & Sharon Salim | The Straits Times | 8 February 2025 [adapted]

This reading helps you understand:

- The range of causes affecting the sense of job security in Singapore
- Policies enacted by government to address employability and job security

Being in a firm where restructuring is taking place would obviously be distressing, but many Singaporeans are reporting anxieties even when the top-line numbers suggest their rice bowls are not under immediate threat.

- 5 At a press conference in November 2024, Prime Minister Lawrence Wong had noted that besides the cost of living, concerns about job security were often raised during his walkabouts.

A confluence of factors

At first glance, labour statistics do not bear out such insecurities, given that resident unemployment remained below 3 per cent in 2024, while long-term unemployment held steady at 0.8 per cent.

- 10 The incidence of discouraged workers – persons not counted in labour force numbers as they are not actively looking for work – is also at one of the lowest points on record, noted the Ministry of Manpower (MOM) in response to queries on the issue.

But economists pointed out that a number of rapid changes in the world of work meant there can concurrently be high employment and strong sentiments of job insecurity.

- 15 High-profile layoffs in large technology companies could have created a sense of instability that permeated other sectors, and led workers to question the security of their own positions, said Singapore Management University assistant professor of organisational behaviour and human resources Nina Sirola.

- 20 Another trend is of contract work becoming more prevalent, as firms seeking to manage costs are more willing to offer such positions than permanent employment.

Associate Professor Walter Theseira from the Singapore University of Social Sciences said people would probably feel a high level of job insecurity if much of what is on offer is contract or gig work. With workers likely to take on such roles if they see no alternative, “you can conceptually quite easily have both high job insecurity and low unemployment”, he said.

- 25 Recent surveys have attempted to look at the insecurity workers are feeling.

In [a 2023 report on the future of work](#) by the Institute of Policy Studies (IPS), 35 per cent of the more than 1,000 economically active Singapore workers polled said they were concerned that the jobs they currently have may not exist in the future. Among respondents in sectors such as production and transport operations, almost half said they were concerned.

30 A 2025 survey on economic sentiments by the National Trades Union Congress (NTUC) found that 34 per cent of respondents expressed concern about losing their jobs in the next three months. The figure was almost 40 per cent in 2024 and 25 per cent in 2023, the annual survey of 2,000 respondents showed.

35 The speed of technology change, as seen in the rise of generative artificial intelligence (AI), has also thrown out the window the sense of linear progression that workers used to have about climbing the corporate ladder, said IPS senior research fellow Laurel Teo.

“You might have to hit the pause button and take some months or years out to rethink your career, retrain and find your way in a new industry. There will be significant disruptions, there will be starts and stops,” she said. “It’s not merely job insecurity that worries people. It’s career
40 insecurity.”

Mid-career workers facing more job insecurity

NTUC, which has been tracking worker sentiment about job insecurity in recent years, said mid-career workers generally feel it more acutely.

45 In a 2022 survey of 1,000 workers, those between 35 and 54 years old were most concerned about losing their jobs, with eight in 10 saying they worried about this sometimes or often, noted NTUC deputy secretary-general Desmond Tan.

Besides finding difficulties keeping their skills up to date while juggling family responsibilities, mid-career workers may experience heightened job insecurity due to concerns about employability, [age discrimination in the workplace](#), and bosses’ perception that older workers
50 are less adaptable to new technologies and changes, he said.

In 2024, around 5,000 workers aged 50 and over were unemployed for more than a year, compared with 1,600 aged between 40 and 49, and around 1,700 aged between 30 and 39. Additionally, older workers with higher qualifications are experiencing longer periods of unemployment.

55 Major moves made so far

While Singaporeans await job-related support measures in Budget 2025, some major moves have already been made, said Associate Professor Tan of SMU. He noted that the issue is as much tied to immigration and foreign labour policy – a perennial political sticking point – as it is to technological upheaval.

60 Various policies in recent years have sought to address workers’ concerns over foreign labour, including stronger penalties against discriminatory hiring under an enhanced Fair Consideration Framework in 2020.

At Budget 2022, the Government announced that minimum qualifying salaries for new Employment Pass (EP) and S Pass holders would be raised³, while the number of work permit
65 holders in the construction and process sectors would be reduced.

³ For 2025, the minimum EP qualifying salary has been increased from \$5,000 to \$5,600, with a corresponding increase from \$3,150 to at least \$3,300 for S Pass holders.

Professor Tan said the landmark Workplace Fairness Bill passed in January should also be seen as part of the overall endeavour to deal with job insecurity. The new law expressly prohibits workplace discrimination in the categories of age, disabilities, nationality, race and sex.

70 These include government incentives to support the employment of older workers and the raising of the retirement and re-employment ages. Such workers can also tap retraining and career placement support through agencies such as Workforce Singapore, SkillsFuture Singapore, NTUC's e2i (Employment and Employability Institute), he added.

75 The "live" question remains how to have high-skilled foreign employment while also prioritising the interests of local high-skilled workers, which is a difficult balance, said Prof Theseira.

Both these issues – the role of foreign workers here, and securing Singaporeans' jobs and livelihoods – saw extensive debate in Parliament in 2021, with the issues aired fully.

80 In a 10-hour debate that ended past midnight, the Government said Singapore's answer to foreign competition in its job market cannot be to shut its doors, but to deepen investments in its people and mitigate the downsides of an open economy and strive for growth that benefits all.

For discussion/reflection:

1. According to the article, what factors affect job security today? According to your understanding, rank the impact of each factor from the most impact to the least, and in groups of 3-4 discuss your respective rankings and the reason(s) for them.
2. Why is it possible to "have both high job security and low employment" (line 24)?
3. When addressing job security for Singaporeans, what are the tensions being balanced by the government?

Related Cambridge/RI essay questions:

4. How realistic is it for countries to implement a national minimum wage for all their workers? (Cambridge 2023)
5. 'Workers today have never had it better.' Is this an accurate view? (Y6 Prelim 2022)
6. Assess the view that skills training for older workers is futile in your society. (Y5 CT 2022)

Supplementary reading:

1. "7 Workplace Challenges for 2025" <https://www.gallup.com/workplace/654329/workplace-challenges-2025.aspx>

Reading 25: Why we define ourselves by our jobs

EU 3 & 6

Kate Morgan | BBC | 13 April 2021

This reading will help you understand:

- The negative impact of linking our identities too closely to our jobs (a condition called “job enmeshment”)
- Who might be most at risk of such “job enmeshment” and why
- The choices that can be made to resist or break free of “job enmeshment” mindsets

The most popular surname in Germany and Switzerland is Müller, while in Ukraine, it's Melnik; both are words for a miller. In Slovakia, the most common last name is Varga, a word that means cobbler. And in the UK, Australia, New Zealand, Canada and the US, it's Smith – as in blacksmith, silversmith, locksmith, gunsmith. These names date back as far as the Middle Ages, when a person's job was such a defining characteristic, it became their literal identity.

Today, our jobs don't dictate our names (though research into the phenomenon of nominative determinism says the opposite might be true; think a meteorologist named 'Blizzard' or an archaeologist named 'Graves') – but they still often become a major part of our identities. After all, one of the first questions we tend to exchange with a new acquaintance is, “What do you do?”.

In many ways, it feels natural to see a person's profession as a defining detail of who they are. It can be a clue into their values, interests or background (or simply help two strangers pass time at an awkward cocktail party). But many of us have come to actually define ourselves by our occupations – which often comes at our own expense.

How did work become to be so entwined with identity – and is it too late to separate our perceptions of self from our professional lives?

Identity marker

Historically, most people didn't get to choose their jobs, says Anne Wilson, a professor of psychology at Wilfrid Laurier University in Ontario. “It was usually generational – your father was a carpenter, so you were a carpenter,” she says. “Or, you'd just take a job based on the opportunities available.”

But increased access to education over the past century has led to the emergence of more varied jobs, and thus more income tiers. So, jobs have become a significant marker of identity in a more nuanced way. When someone says they're a surgeon, you generally assume they have strong education and high income – two metrics that can determine one's standing in society, and affect how you subsequently judge the person. Of course, it's a two-way street: many *welcome* this judgement, because they desire to associate themselves with the wealth and accomplishment their professional titles imply.

“That is especially true among the ‘educated elite’,” says Wilson. “For people who have a certain type of job and certain class, it often becomes how you identify yourself and how others identify you.”

However, those who do let their jobs consume their identities may be doing so at their own expense. When people invest a disproportionate amount of their time and energy into their career, explains Wilson, it can lead to a psychological state called ‘enmeshment’, where the boundaries between work and personal life are blurred.

“This tends to happen especially for people with jobs that are relatively self-determined, where you're not clocking in at nine and out at five,” says Wilson. People in high-powered executive positions,

35 lawyers, doctors, entrepreneurs, academics and others who set their own hours “can end up letting their jobs fill a lot of – or most of – the time in their lives”.

The enmeshment trap

There are some common signs of enmeshment, like thinking about work whenever you aren’t there, and bringing up your job within the first three minutes of a conversation, says Wilson. Enmeshment
40 allows the job to “eat up one’s time and identity, leaving less space for hobbies and interests. It makes it harder to connect with people who aren’t a part of your working life.”

When you become so enmeshed in your job that it begins to define you, you also may begin to let it determine your own value. This can have disastrous effects. “If you tie [your self-worth] to your career, the successes and failures you experience will directly affect your self-worth,” says Wilson. “And
45 because we live in a society where careers are less likely to be lifelong, if we switch or find ourselves out of a job, it can also become an identity crisis.”

And enmeshment doesn’t only threaten the way we feel about ourselves personally. Janna Koretz, founder of Azimuth Psychological, a Boston-based practice focused on the mental health of people in high-pressure jobs, says that linking self-worth to your career can turn a career hurdle into something
50 considerably tougher to overcome. “Inevitably, something will happen,” she says. “There will be lay-offs, a recession, your company will be acquired, and suddenly your job isn’t what it used to be. It becomes really existential for people, and they have poor coping strategies because it’s earth-shattering. So, it becomes depression, anxiety, even substance abuse.”

But until there’s a problem, most people who’ve slipped into a career-centric identity don’t even realise it’s happening. “We work with people who are uncomfortable with how much they’re defined by their job,” says Koretz. Ironically, she adds, most would also say they’re doing their “dream job”, or something they love.

A new cultural identity

However, we may have a rare opportunity to disassociate who we are with what we do. The pandemic’s
60 forced disruption of all elements of our lives – work, especially – has caused many to evaluate what’s actually important to them. Some have taken on new hobbies; others have evolved their bonds with family and friends.

“When we face experiences that remind us that our mortal existence is transient and that tragedy can strike with little or no warning, we tend to be motivated to evaluate what makes life worthwhile,” writes Clay Routledge, a professor of psychology at North Dakota State University, US.
65 Routledge is one of the co-authors of a recent study on how American adults derived meaning in their lives.

So, while our careers are still in the picture, of course, we may be at a juncture where our jobs become only one significant puzzle piece of our lives.

Wilson points out that doing work you love is not a bad thing, nor is considering what you do for a living an important part of who you are. But she says moving away from a system where people are defined primarily – or exclusively – by their jobs will take more than realising there is a problem, or re-prioritizing in the wake of the pandemic. It will also require a cultural shift away from the idea that each person has a professional “calling”, dictated by who they are, and that the goal of life should be
75 to discover it. “We often set people up to feel dissatisfied; if they don’t find themselves in that perfect job, they’ve somehow failed,” she says.

80 Changing that narrative may need to begin long before people actually enter the workforce. Research shows that pressure to find “a calling” makes students feel lost and depressed. Even young children get the message that the career they choose will be part of who they become; consider how often today’s kids are asked, “What do you want to be when you grow up?”.

Discussing careers with children – especially little girls – can help them see the myriad possibilities their future holds. But Wilson says asking young people what they want to be may have knock-on effects. “The idea that this is when we want kids to determine a life course may influence the degree to which, as adults, we end up tying our identity so much to our jobs.”

85 While parents can begin to make those changes with their children, adults who feel too enmeshed in their careers have some recourse, too. Being deliberate about making time to relax and socialise outside work can help. It can be difficult to make friends as an adult, but joining groups or clubs can provide a leg-up. Picking up hobbies can be very helpful, as long as they have nothing to do with your job.

90 Koretz warns that identities develop over time, and cautions against trying to change too much, too fast. She encourages her clients to add new identifiers slowly. “Rather than drastic, very difficult changes, get hobbies a little at a time, make friends a little at a time,” she suggests. “Ultimately, it’s similar to diversifying a financial portfolio. You have to diversify your life. Diversify yourself.”

For discussion:

1. In relation to the Singapore context, assess the applicability of Morgan’s following observations, considering the contributing factors and evaluating the significance of the possible consequences:
 - a) *Jobs have become a “significant marker of identity” (line 17) and the basis on which to “judge the person” (line 20)*
 - b) *People “invest a disproportionate amount of time and energy in their career” (line 30)*
 - c) *“Even young children get the message that the career they choose will be part of who they become” (lines 78-79)*
2. In Singapore, to what extent has there been “a cultural shift away from the idea that each person has a professional “calling”, dictated by who they are, and that the goal of life should be to discover it” (lines 73-75)? What do you think may have contributed to or discouraged such a “shift”?

Related RI essay questions:

1. ‘Work-life harmony is a myth.’ How far is this true of your society today? (RI 2020 Y5 Promo)
2. ‘An education in sports or arts is still seen to be undesirable in your society today.’ Do you agree? (RI 2017 Y5 Promo)
3. ‘Always follow your dreams.’ Is this good advice for young people today? (RI 2013 Y5 Promo)

SECTION F: CRIME, PUNISHMENT, AND JUSTICE

Crime is not simply about breaking the law — it is shaped by the society in which it occurs. What is considered criminal often reflects a community's values, power structures, and cultural norms. Behaviours seen as illegal in one context may be acceptable or even celebrated in another, showing that crime is socially constructed, not fixed. How societies choose to respond — whether through punishment, rehabilitation, or a mix of both—raises deeper questions about justice, fairness, and compassion. This is especially clear in debates over capital punishment and in how we treat youth offenders, who often face pressures beyond their control, such as poverty, peer influence, or unstable family environments. Considering the personal reasons for criminal acts and the influence of wider systems and societal inequalities at play encourages us to ask what kind of society we want to build, and what justice really means in practice.

Reading 26: The debate over capital punishment

EU 2 & 3

Claire Andre & Manuel Velasquez | 16 November 2015

[adapted from "Capital Punishment: Our Duty or Our Doom?"]

This reading will help you:

- Understand the key arguments for and against capital punishment
- Understand the ethical, social, and economic implications of the death penalty.
- Evaluate the effectiveness of the death penalty as a deterrent to crime
- Examine how justice and equality intersect in the administration of capital punishment.

The current state of capital punishment

The global community largely condemns the use of the death penalty, with a majority of countries supporting a moratorium as a first step towards abolition. The death penalty has been abolished in practice or law in 144 countries, and in 2024 abolition efforts showed progress in four countries. Despite this, known global executions increased in 2024 for the third straight year.

The United States is one of an increasingly isolated number of countries that retain and use the death penalty, making it an outlier among its closest allies, most of whom have long abandoned the practice and are vocal advocates in favour of abolition. Secrecy around the death penalty continues to impede a complete understanding of legal and execution practices in countries retaining the death penalty, including the United States. Vulnerable populations, such as ethnic, religious, or racial minorities, as well as the impoverished, psychosocially impaired, and juveniles continue to be over-represented across death rows in most retentionist countries.

Arguments in favour of capital punishment

Capital punishment is often defended on the grounds that society has a moral obligation to protect the safety and welfare of its citizens. Murderers threaten this safety and welfare. Only by putting murderers to death can society ensure that convicted killers do not kill again.

Second, those favouring capital punishment contend that society should support those practices that will bring about the greatest balance of good over evil, and capital punishment is one such practice. Capital punishment benefits society because it may deter violent crime. While it is difficult to produce direct evidence to support this claim since, by definition, those who are deterred by the death penalty do not commit murders, common sense tells us that if people know that they will die if they perform a certain act, they will be unwilling to perform that act.

If the threat of death has, in fact, stayed the hand of many a would be murderer, and we abolish the death penalty, we will sacrifice the lives of many innocent victims whose murders could have been

25 deterred. But if, in fact, the death penalty does not deter, and we continue to impose it, we have only sacrificed the lives of convicted murderers. Surely, it's better for society to take a gamble that the death penalty deters in order to protect the lives of innocent people than to take a gamble that it doesn't deter and thereby protect the lives of murderers, while risking the lives of innocents. If grave risks are to be run, it's better that they be run by the guilty, not the innocent.

30 Finally, defenders of capital punishment argue that justice demands that those convicted of heinous crimes of murder be sentenced to death. Justice is essentially a matter of ensuring that everyone is treated equally. It is unjust when a criminal deliberately and wrongly inflicts greater losses on others than he or she has to bear. If the losses society imposes on criminals are less than those the criminals imposed on their innocent victims, society would be favouring criminals, allowing them to get away
35 with bearing fewer costs than their victims had to bear. Justice requires that society impose on criminals losses equal to those they imposed on innocent persons. By inflicting death on those who deliberately inflict death on others, the death penalty ensures justice for all.

 This requirement that justice be served is not weakened by charges that only the black and the poor receive the death penalty. Any unfair application of the death penalty is the basis for extending its
40 application, not abolishing it. If an employer discriminates in hiring workers, do we demand that jobs be taken from the deserving who were hired or that jobs be abolished altogether? Likewise, if our criminal justice system discriminates in applying the death penalty so that some do not get their deserved punishment, it's no reason to give lesser punishments to murderers who deserved the death penalty and got it. Some justice, however unequal, is better than no justice, however equal. To ensure
45 justice and equality, we must work to improve our system so that everyone who deserves the death penalty gets it.

Arguments against capital punishment

 The case against capital punishment is often made on the basis that society has a moral obligation to protect human life, not take it. The taking of human life is permissible only if it is a necessary condition
50 to achieving the greatest balance of good over evil for everyone involved. Given the value we place on life and our obligation to minimize suffering and pain whenever possible, if a less severe alternative to the death penalty exists which would accomplish the same goal, we are duty-bound to reject the death penalty in favour of the less severe alternative.

55 There is no evidence to support the claim that the death penalty is a more effective deterrent of violent crime than, say, life imprisonment. In fact, statistical studies that have compared the murder rates of jurisdictions with and without the death penalty have shown that the rate of murder is not related to whether the death penalty is in force: There are as many murders committed in jurisdictions with the death penalty as in those without. Unless it can be demonstrated that the death penalty, and
60 the death penalty alone, does in fact deter crimes of murder, we are obligated to refrain from imposing it when other alternatives exist.

 Further, the death penalty is not necessary to achieve the benefit of protecting the public from murderers who may strike again. Locking murderers away for life achieves the same goal without requiring us to take yet another life. Nor is the death penalty necessary to ensure that criminals "get
65 what they deserve." Justice does not require us to punish murder by death. It only requires that the gravest crimes receive the severest punishment that our moral principles would allow us to impose.

 While it is clear that the death penalty is by no means necessary to achieve certain social benefits, it does, without a doubt, impose grave costs on society. First, the death penalty wastes lives. Many of those sentenced to death could be rehabilitated to live socially productive lives. Carrying out the death
70 penalty destroys any good such persons might have done for society if they had been allowed to live. Furthermore, juries have been known to make mistakes, inflicting the death penalty on innocent

people. Had such innocent parties been allowed to live, the wrong done to them might have been corrected and their lives not wasted.

75 In addition to wasting lives, the death penalty also wastes money. Contrary to conventional wisdom, it's much more costly to execute a person than to imprison them for life. The finality of punishment by death rightly requires that great procedural precautions be taken throughout all stages of death penalty cases to ensure that the chance of error is minimized. As a result, executing a single capital case costs about three times as much as it costs to keep a person in prison for their remaining life expectancy, which is about 40 years.

80 Finally, the death penalty harms society by cheapening the value of life. Allowing the state to inflict death on certain of its citizens legitimizes the taking of life. The death of anyone, even a convicted killer, diminishes us all. Society has a duty to end this practice which causes harm, yet produces little in the way of benefits.

85 Opponents of capital punishment argue that the death penalty is inherently unjust, emphasizing that justice demands equal treatment for all individuals, especially in matters of life and death. Recent data reveals significant racial disparities in death penalty sentencing. For instance, in Texas, Black individuals constitute 14% of the state's population but represent 47% of death row inmates. Similarly, nationwide statistics indicate that while Black and Hispanic people make up 31% of the U.S. population, they account for 53% of death row inmates—41.9% and 11.3% respectively. These figures suggest that
90 factors such as inadequate legal representation, socioeconomic status, and racial bias significantly influence who is sentenced to death, rather than the severity of the crime alone. Critics contend that individuals often end up on death row due to an inability to afford competent legal defence, lack of resources to support their case, or systemic biases against political or racial minorities

95 The death penalty is fundamentally unjust, particularly due to the irreversible risk of executing innocent individuals. Since 1973, at least 200 people in the United States have been exonerated and freed from death row, highlighting significant flaws within the criminal justice system. A 2014 study estimated that approximately 4.1% of death row inmates may be innocent, underscoring the potential for wrongful executions. The finality of the death penalty eliminates any possibility of rectifying such miscarriages of justice. In contrast, if the death penalty is abolished, individuals wrongfully convicted
100 can be released and compensated for the time they unjustly served, allowing for corrective measures that are impossible once an execution has been carried out.

105 The case for and the case against the death penalty appeal, in different ways, to the value we place on life and to the value we place on bringing about the greatest balance of good over evil. Each also appeals to our commitment to "justice": Is justice to be served at all costs? Or is our commitment to justice to be one tempered by our commitment to equality and our reverence for life? Indeed, is capital punishment our duty or our doom?

For discussion:

1. What are the primary reasons given in support of the death penalty? Which do you find most compelling, and why?
2. Does the death penalty serve as an effective deterrent to crime? Why or why not?
3. How does the issue of racial and economic bias affect the fairness of the death penalty?
4. Should justice prioritise fairness and equality, or should it prioritize punishment and deterrence? Can both be achieved?
5. Is capital punishment a necessary tool for justice, or does it contradict the moral values of society?
6. Would life imprisonment without parole be a better alternative to the death penalty? Why or why not?

Related Cambridge/RI essay questions:

1. Evaluate the measures taken in your society to deter crime and punish criminals. (Cambridge 2024)
2. To what extent is it possible 'to make the punishment fit the crime'? (Cambridge 2013)
3. Should capital punishment still have a place in your society today? (2020 RI Y6 Timed Practice)

Reading 27: Punishment vs Rehabilitation – Finding the right approach to crime and justice

EU 2, 3 & 6

Tom Blackout | Mar 24, 2020 [adapted from “Why Rehabilitation, not Harsher Prison Sentences makes Economic Sense”]

This reading will help you:

- Compare different global approaches to criminal justice and incarceration
- Evaluate the ethical, financial, and social implications of punishment vs. rehabilitation
- Discuss the effectiveness of community sentences versus incarceration

Global approaches to criminal justice

How should we treat convicted criminals? This is a matter of continuing public debate and varies enormously across countries. Even within the so-called developed world, there are wide variations. The US, for example, imprisons more people per capita (over 700 per 100,000) than any other country in the world. At the other end of the spectrum are the Scandinavians. Norway, for example, has one of the lowest, at 66 per 100,000.

While the composition and severity of crime varies, the US and the Scandinavian model represent different philosophies. The US system focuses more on punishment, whereas the Scandinavian model emphasises rehabilitation: treatment and support aimed to help the offender become a law-abiding member of society. This might include developing skills to improve employability or treating mental health problems, for example.

The UK falls somewhere in between these two models. Although it has the highest prison population per capita in western Europe, the country has experimented with initiatives aimed at diverting low level offenders away from prison.

Operation Checkpoint: A case study in deferred prosecution

One of the largest such schemes – Operation Checkpoint – is being run by Durham Constabulary. This “deferred prosecution scheme” allows offenders for certain types of relatively low harm offences (such as theft or criminal damage) to avoid prosecution if they participate in a programme that addresses their causes of offending – such as mental health issues or substance abuse. The first set of results from this programme, recently published, show a 15% reduction in reoffending rates when compared to similar offenders who did not participate.

A back of the envelope cost/benefit analysis suggests that the programme also represents good value for money, with the benefit to society from reduced re-offending estimated at £2 million against a cost of half a million for running the programme. Of course, while not every rehabilitation programme in the UK has been rigorously evaluated, these results are consistent with other evidence across England and Wales indicating that non-custodial alternatives can reduce crime.

Retribution or rehabilitation?

The effective response to crime has always been a matter of debate. While the retributive idea of justice seeks to inflict a cost or hardship on the criminal as a just response to crime, the rehabilitation model seeks to provide support that can reform the criminal.

While this debate has often been cast as one between those who fully believe in punishment and those who want to see prison time completely cut and replaced with rehabilitative programmes, most people believe in both. The debate is more often about what the right mix is.

In the UK, for example, there is wide public support for tough criminal justice sanctions. But there is just as much support for rehabilitation. And when presented with evidence around the cost of prison (roughly £40,000 per prison place per year), a majority support looking into cheaper alternatives to prison: meaning there is public support for alternatives to custody that can rehabilitate criminals.

A particular type of alternative to custody is a deferred prosecution agreement, where criminal charges are not brought against defendants if they fulfil certain conditions. The success of Operation Checkpoint will no doubt spur more interest in the area.

Reoffending rates

An international comparison reveals some interesting trends. [Norway moved its focus from punishment to rehabilitation](#) (including for those who were imprisoned) 20 years ago. This was followed by large reductions in reoffending rates. Compared to a reoffending rate of around 50% within a year in the UK, Norway's is around 25% in five years.

There is much to learn from this. A lot of people processed within the criminal justice system have vulnerabilities that can make them prone to offending, which might suggest why rehabilitation can be so successful. Recent evidence suggests that the UK prison population has serious levels of self-harm. And a recent report finds that 90% of the UK's prison population suffer from mental health problems. Releasing such people without investing in their treatment is bound to lead to reoffending.

Though less dramatic, the same report finds that nearly 40% of people detained by the police also suffer from mental health issues. A substantial portion of criminals, then, could benefit from support rather than punishment. Locking up or otherwise criminalising people with these vulnerabilities also raise ethical issues. In particular, what would be a just response to crime committed by the vulnerable?

The economics of crime

From an economic perspective, rehabilitation makes sense. A recent study that colleagues and I undertook across England and Wales provides illustrative examples of changes in sending more people to prison (a proxy for a model that emphasises punishment) versus community sentences (a proxy for a more rehabilitative approach). Based on a statistical model using data on case disposals and crime rates across England and Wales, it provides estimates of how changes in case disposals affect crime rates.

For example, sentencing 1% more offenders to prison for property offences (including theft and handling) is estimated to reduce next year's recorded crimes by 2,693. But a similar 1% increase in community sentences reduces these offences by 3,590. When one considers that community sentences cost on average a quarter of prison sentences, it appears there is scope to reduce property crime (approximately 72% of recorded crimes in the analysis) more cost-effectively and humanely through a greater use of community sentences instead of prison.

The results suggest that initiatives like the Durham model could be used more widely, leading to a more cost effective and humane criminal justice system. Views on crime and punishment differ. Yet almost everyone would agree that we care about crime because of the harm caused by it. One does not have to have any particular ideological bent to advocate an approach that reduces harm. There is evidence that rehabilitation (including within prison) reduces crime and can be cost effective. Economic analysis, therefore, reinforces the idea that punishment is not the best solution for reducing the harmful impact of crime.

For discussion:

1. How do different countries' approaches to criminal justice reflect their broader social values?
2. What are the advantages and disadvantages of a rehabilitation-focused criminal justice system?
3. What ethical considerations arise when dealing with criminals who have mental health issues?
4. How does economic analysis support or challenge the argument for rehabilitation over punishment?
5. How can public perception of rehabilitation programs be shifted to gain broader support?

Related Cambridge/RI essay questions:

1. Consider the view that people imprisoned for crimes should lose all their rights. (Cambridge 2022)
2. 'The purpose of the justice system should be rehabilitation, not punishment.' Discuss. (2021 Y5 Promo)
3. 'Criminals are victims too.' To what extent do you agree with this view (2021 RI Y6 CT)

SECTION F: ISSUES TO DO WITH CRIME, PUNISHMENT, AND JUSTICE

The two readings below examine the nature of rehabilitation work for young people in the Singapore context. The first provides a general insight into the system of rehabilitation for young offenders in Singapore, while the second looks more deeply into the how the different strands of rehabilitation work towards providing a good outcome for potential or young offenders.

They will help you to consider and assess:

- The balance to be struck between justice/deterrence and rehabilitation
- The social and psychological factors to consider for sentencing and rehabilitation

Reading 28a: Young offenders face more challenges completing probation amid factors like impulsiveness, peer influence

EU 2-4

Cindy Co | Channel News Asia | 21 June 2021

Younger offenders tend to face more challenges completing their probation orders due to a range of individual and social factors such as being impulsive and susceptible to peer influence, said the Ministry of Social and Family Development (MSF). According to an annual report released by the ministry earlier this month, the overall completion rate for probation orders issued by the Youth Court fell for the second year in 2020. It was 73 per cent in 2018, before dropping to 66 per cent in 2019 and 64 per cent in 2020. The completion rates were the lowest for those under 16 years old, at 66 per cent last year.

"Research shows that younger offenders tend to face more challenges in completing their court orders as compared to older offenders," an MSF spokesperson in response to CNA's queries. "Youths at this stage of development are relatively more impulsive, have a higher need for instant gratification, are susceptible to peer influence and are still developing in their cognitive functioning.

"This could lead them to face more challenges in making sound decisions and thinking through consequences of their behaviours when faced with risky situations." The ministry noted other factors such as the youth's participation in employment or education. "Individual factors, such as the youth's self-control, coping style, engagement in constructive activities such as education or employment, and social competence could also influence the completion of probation orders," it added. Completion rates for probation orders are also affected by family circumstances, the family's supervision and involvement in the youth's activities, school or work, said the spokesperson.

Completion rates for those under 16 years old

For offenders under 16 years old who were charged in the Youth Court, MSF said they tend to have "higher risks and needs". "This may explain the higher complexity of cases that are placed on probation orders by the Youth Court. These youths are likely to have past brushes with the law, associate with peers with pro-criminal behaviours and lifestyles or other risk-taking behaviours that require more intensive intervention," said the spokesperson.

But the number of offenders aged below 16 who were charged has dropped over the years. "This is partly due to the approach of diverting first-time youth offenders who commit minor offences away from the court, following police investigations," said MSF, adding that these offenders may instead be required to undergo rehabilitative programmes run by social service agencies. "This provides the youths the opportunity to be guided in the community without being exposed to the court system," the ministry said. The majority of those placed on court-ordered probation last year had committed offences related to theft and voluntarily causing hurt. A "small proportion" had been involved in unlicensed moneylending, vandalism and mischief.

Completion rates for youth probationers in hostels

35 According to the annual probation report, 54 per cent of youth offenders who were required to stay in a hostel had completed their probation in 2020. This is lower than the 72 per cent completion rate for offenders who were not required to stay in a hostel. When asked why this was the case, MSF noted that only 7 per cent of new probation orders had hostel residence as a probation condition in 2020. The remaining 93 per cent lived with their families, a relative or caregiver.

40 "Probationers who are placed in hostels would have been assessed to have more complex issues such as limited family support or supervision, family violence, substance abuse, aggression and other risk-taking behaviours, and that supervision at home would be inadequate to help shift their risk of reoffending," said the MSF spokesperson. "They are more likely to face challenges in complying with their probation conditions given their past unstructured lifestyle and more entrenched offending behaviours. This may see them reacting to the imposition of boundaries, rules and structure and a lack of motivation to change their lifestyle and mindset."

Use of technology, engaging families

50 With more complex profiles of offenders, there is a need to better understand the underlying issues that influence offending, said MSF's spokesperson. These issues include peer pressure, attitudes, beliefs, family relationships and personal motivations. The ministry found that technology could be used to engage younger offenders and motivate their families. "Recognising the strong tech-savvy nature of our youth and the prevalence of a gaming culture amongst them, efforts are underway to digitalise two core rehabilitation programmes, Victim Impact and Law and Order, into an ongoing gaming format," the spokesperson said.

55 The Probation and Community Rehabilitation Service is also providing targeted intervention and scaling up the intensity of its programmes. For instance, probationers will go through offence-specific intervention, such as theft intervention or violence prevention, to reduce their likelihood of reoffending.

60 As family is key in a youth's rehabilitation, MSF has also adopted family-based approaches and programmes, such as the Functional Family Therapy programme. Since January last year, authorities have been piloting the Functional Family Probation programme for those under 18. The probationer and the family participate jointly in almost all sessions conducted by the probation officer, and it aims to empower and motivate the family to "take ownership of issues and work at resolving them together".

65 "MSF will continue to work with key community partners, such as educational institutions and employers, to strengthen the supportive climate and guidance for youth offenders," said the spokesperson. "These include efforts to tailor interventions based on the learning needs of these youth offenders, providing them with more opportunities to access resources and mentoring to explore their strengths and develop skills, and increase families' capacity to support these youths beyond the probation orders."

SECTION F: ISSUES TO DO WITH CRIME, PUNISHMENT, AND JUSTICE

Reading 28b: 'I regret committing crime': Inside the Probation Service and lives of youth offenders'

Derek Paulo et al. | Channel News Asia | Updated 5 Feb 2022 [adapted]

EU 1, 2 & 3

[Note: The names of the offenders have been changed]

Probation is essentially supervision of an offender in the community, which means the person is able to go to school or work. Probationers or those who have completed their probation orders can lawfully declare that they have no criminal record.

“It’s a second chance because it’s an opportunity for them to recognise the harm that they’ve caused others, to make amends, to stop offending,” said chief probation officer Carmelia Nathen, the director of the Probation Service. “If not for probation, the court can commit them to an institution like a juvenile rehab centre, or to prison,” she added.

The investigation

So how does the Probation Service evaluate these minors’ suitability for community-based rehabilitation in the first place? For one thing, the officers must ensure that public safety is guarded, which is why it takes about four to six weeks to assess a case.

“The probation officer considers many factors in assessing whether they’re suitable for probation or not: Whether they’re involved in school or any positive activities, whether they’re motivated to change,” cited Probation Service assistant director Gabriel Low. “We also look at the severity of the offence, their history of offending behaviour as well as the family make-up.”

Sometimes the investigation throws up inconsistencies in statements. This was the case when Charis Chenxu, another Probation Service assistant manager, was evaluating the case of 16-year-old Ahmad, who was charged with rioting, receiving stolen property and violating circuit-breaker rules. In the first interview, his parents reported that he would stay out all night “probably just once a month to fish”. In the second session, he himself said he was not allowed to stay out late.

But when Chenxu highlighted that he may have to follow time restrictions – sometimes given to offenders during investigations to see if they can comply with instructions – she learned that he was “not used to getting home early”, in his words. In fact, he was used to staying out three or four times a week. His father, however, said he was “not sure” about this. “Even if the details aren’t offence-related at all, we still want them to be forthcoming because these can give us insight into the youth’s offending behaviour,” said Chenxu. “If they’re not truthful, it could affect our assessment,” she added.

At least eight in 10 probationers are under the age of 21, and family support is a factor in considering youth offenders for probation. Youths who have experienced “relatively poor” parental supervision “get charged at a much earlier age”, said senior principal clinical and forensic psychologist Chu Chi Meng, the director of the National Council of Social Service’s Translational Social Research Division. “And what happens is, when they come into the system, they tend to also re-offend fast.”

This makes home visits “crucial” to probation officers’ investigations, said Chenxu, “because we’re able to pick up any concerns.”

Youth offenders who need discipline and more structure and support than can be found at home are not necessarily unsuitable for probation. There is another option. “In the probation order, one of these conditions may include a stay in a hostel,” cited Low. “Residence in a hostel would take maybe nine to 12 months.

40 And in that period, they're only allowed to return home generally on the weekends." That was the court's decision after five weeks of investigation into Ahmad's case. Following two weeks in the Singapore Boys' Home, he was transferred to a hostel for a 12-month stay, during which he can still go to work. After that, to monitor compliance with his curfew, he will be electronically tagged with a device for four months as part of eight months' probation at home.

Victim? What victim?

45 To stop young offenders from becoming a menace to society again, the Probation Service also tries to reset their thinking by running programmes for them. Zack, for example, attended a victim impact programme after he was sentenced in August to 27 months' probation for theft and aiding unlicensed moneylenders. It is a core programme for all probationers.

50 "We guide them through thinking about the victims – how the victims feel when an offence is committed," said senior probation officer How Shi Ying. "Then you get them to develop some empathy for the victims. Sometimes they may feel that certain offences that they've committed or certain actions that they've done are justified because they have their reasons. So we get them to think about other people's perspectives."

55 Zack admitted that he did not think about this previously. "I'm quite shocked. I affected a lot of people," said the 15-year-old. "I regret ... committing crime." He said a friend of his could not afford to pay a fine for trespass and was in two minds about getting the money through loan shark harassment. "He didn't have the guts (to do it). So I said to him, 'I'll do it with you,'" recounted Zack.

60 Zack must now wear an electronic tag and has a curfew from 8pm to 6am. He said he had never thought about the consequences of his actions because "doing something bad was quite fun". One of the reasons probationers like him have committed offences is that "they have a deficit in certain skills", Low noted. "They react based on their impulses. So the core programmes are meant to then teach them certain skills to ensure that their risk issues are addressed and they don't get into trouble again."

65 Zack and his family also attend counselling sessions – facilitated by his probation officer – to work on their relationship. "I come from a family that's ... not so broken. I don't know why I'm so broken." Only when he was brought to the Institute of Mental Health did they realise there was a deeper issue. Zack had moderate attention deficit hyperactivity disorder (ADHD). He was also diagnosed with oppositional defiant disorder; as the name suggests, children with this disorder show defiant behaviour towards authority.

70 "Such children may demonstrate an irritable kind of mood. They usually can be spiteful ... And when adults are trying to give instructions, they'd react negatively," said Jennifer Teoh, the director of the clinical and forensic psychology service at the Ministry of Social and Family Development [MSF]. "Such disorders can result in them seeking risky behaviour (for a) thrill. And because they don't really think through their actions, [and] the consequences, it kind of predisposes them to act out in an antisocial manner."

75 The ADHD medicine Zack was given has helped, and he does better in school now. "I won't get distracted or very rowdy," he said. Following his diagnosis, his parents also "try very hard to understand him", knowing now that "he can't express himself so well", noted probation officer How. "One thing that we value is family involvement. If ... the family is supportive, the boy would also make positive changes."

80 And she saw that change in him when he applied to be a peer leader at school to welcome this year's Secondary One students. "In the past, he tried to get respect, or rather, tried to be a leader of a group

in a bad way, with his friends who were more of a negative influence,” she said. “Now ... he wants to use that leadership and that desire for respect in a more positive way.”

85 When a breach happens

While some offenders find redemption, others find themselves facing the music when they breach their probation conditions.

That happened to 19-year-old Zaid, who had forged his teacher’s signature four times in his movement book at school. By signing out himself, he gave himself more time before he returned to his hostel.

90 He had been given 22 months’ probation for theft, including a nine-month placement in a hostel for probationers. He had also been put under a 10pm–6am curfew. But there has been poor compliance. “He’s received warning after warning for breaches of the time restriction, failing to attend community service, failing to report to me, failing to attend school as well,” said senior probation officer Dayana Noor Mohamed.

95 Breaches like failing to comply with time restrictions or failing to attend school aren’t criminal offences. But they’re a big deal,” said assistant director Low. “We’re trying to teach them that rules are important. They need to follow rules. “And, of course, by extension they need to follow the law. So if there’s a breach of probation conditions, then it’s perhaps their lack of motivation to ... make positive changes. Also, perhaps it’s a deficit in their skills.”

100 In the case of Zaid, according to Dayana, his breaches stemmed from his need for a sense of relatedness, most recently to his girlfriend, with whom he was having “relationship issues”. “He wanted more time to discuss things with her,” said the officer, explaining the forged signatures. Or, in his words, “to help her because she’s got some problems”.

105 To help him get his priorities right, Dayana’s sessions with him have revolved around peer refusal skills and decision-making skills. But in situations “where he feels that he’s about lose this person”, he would still take risks, she noted. For his acts of forgery and breaking curfew, he had to go back to court.

110 But Dayana met him first to try to navigate him around his “self-sabotaging behaviour”. “I’m not asking you to choose (between the relationship and probation). I’m asking you, how can you handle both? You have to handle both,” she told him. “Say in future ... you have a job and you have a wife. Do you forget about your wife and then you just go to work?”

“I just realised what I can do and what I can’t do,” he said afterwards. “I actually don’t know how to look out for people. If I’ve got a problem, how do I want to look out for people?”

115 Helping offenders with their coping skills is part of the work of officers like Dayana that people do not often see. “People have the misconception that we’re just there to supervise, check on their time restriction, scold, scold, scold,” she said. “But a large part of it is (about) going through intervention plans, running the programmes, making sure that they understand.”

Rehabilitating families

120 There are also times when the officers struggle to help and rehabilitate not only the probationer, but also their families, especially when the family problems run deep. There are times when families fail young offenders, for example when parents find it hard to change their ways, even if the probationer has changed.

That was how Lisa felt after she had stopped taking drugs, quit smoking and was trying hard to win her father’s approval during her 24-month probation for substance abuse. “Even (though) my urine tests

125 were negative, he'd still think I'm taking drugs," she recounted. "He'd constantly tell me, 'Oh, your other friends (are) already at the polytechnics. They've graduated.' "Do I not see that? Like obviously I know that (and) I'm affected by it ... By telling me you're ashamed of me, this and that, it doesn't help."

130 Although she used to go clubbing frequently and her father disapproved of her lifestyle, she was "learning how to change", noted probation officer J Aswanee, who cited how the 20-year-old found a job and was going to start school. "She spends time with people who are ... working or schooling. (Her) activities have also changed. Recently, she went to paint with her friend at the beach," said Aswanee. "She's already trying her best."

135 Still, given the strained relationship between parent and child, Aswanee flagged a potential problem: "She might begin seeking relationships with negative peers instead. So this might also mean that she goes back to her old habits ... which we don't want."

of the fights at home – dating back to Lisa's teenage years – and lack of family support, Aswanee arranged for her clients to articulate "some of these grievances in a safe environment" and how they could meet each other halfway. But the session did not go well.

140 When Aswanee spoke to him two weeks after the session and suggested "it'd be very helpful" if he began affirming Lisa's efforts, he acknowledged that he could "do better to have a better family" and needed "to learn". Changes in parenting behaviour take time, noted Aswanee, "and we can't force change". Still, change lies at the heart of probation and rehabilitating youth offenders, both on their part and their families'.

145 "These are their formative years ... We want to make sure that we break the cycle early," said senior principal clinical and forensic psychologist Chu. "Family does matter a lot ... If we can help with the environment, you have a better chance."

150 For Lisa, things got better with four months left in her probation. "I'm thankful that the session happened ... My dad stopped talking about the past – completely stopped," she said. "Maybe he realised that ... other people are telling him (the same thing). The thing about my dad is he needs other people to tell him. If I tell him, he won't believe me." She has tried to understand where he is coming from as a single father of two. "I just always remember he's my dad, and he's done a lot of good things for me," she said.

155 Lisa is also "so proud" of herself and what she has achieved during her probation. "I don't even need anyone to tell me that. I can just tell myself that," she said. "I didn't want (my dad) to think that I'm a bad person ... (But) I read this book: It taught me that I don't have to seek any sort of validation from anybody."

160 This is one way Aswanee thinks probation officers can help probationers to face setbacks on their own in future. "I strongly believe there's good in people," she said. "My job is to identify this good and ... get them to recognise this good for themselves."

Watch the full Channel News Asia series here: ["Inside The Probation Service"](#)

For discussion:

1. From the articles, what important realisations can you draw about how rehabilitation can work to bring about a favourable outcome for offenders and society in general?
2. [For group work] In the second reading, the probation workers discussed how they rehabilitate offenders (self-regulation, handling peer pressure, working with changing self-concept, working with relations with family). In this article, there are three offenders with different challenges in meeting the imposed probation orders; Ahmad, Zack and Zaid. In your groups:
 - a. *Identify the specific challenges each probationer face in meeting their probation orders*
 - b. *Possible causes for their difficulties in meeting with these demands*
 - c. *How the different interventions attempt to rehabilitate the probationers*
 - d. *Your assessments of whether the measures can lead to long term rehabilitation based on personality of probationers, family circumstances and societal expectations.*

Related Cambridge/RI essay questions:

1. Consider the view that people imprisoned for crimes should always lose their rights. (Cambridge 2022)
2. 'The purpose of the justice system should be rehabilitation, not punishment.' Discuss. (RI 2021 Y5 Promo)
3. How far is punishment an effective solution to crime? (RI 2019 Y6 CT2)